

SECOND EDITION

Planning Process Drama

Enriching teaching and learning

Pamela Bowell and Brian S. Heap



A David Fulton Book

Planning Process Drama

Process drama is now firmly established, internationally, as a powerful and dynamic pedagogy. This clear and accessible book provides a practical, step-by-step guide to the planning of process drama. Grounded in theory and illustrated in practice, it identifies and explains the principles of planning and shows how they can be applied across age ranges and curricula.

Drawing on the authors' wide-ranging practical experience and research, examples are built up and run throughout the book, at each step showing how and why the teachers' planning decisions were made. This second edition features:

- two completely new chapters: one deals with planning for diverse learner groups and the other moves the reader on from the pre-action planning phase to the 'planning on your feet' required as the drama unfolds
- a wider range of examples illustrating the planning principles in practice
- incorporated new material to reflect recent understanding of how learning takes place.

Written as a conversation between reader and authors, *Planning Process Drama* will help practitioners to update and refine their practice and strengthen their understanding, skills and confidence.

Planning Process Drama will be an essential guide for students undertaking initial teacher training at primary level, in addition to both Drama and English at secondary level, and a Masters in Drama in Education. It will also prove to be valuable reading for specialist and non-specialist teachers in both the primary and secondary sectors who teach, or wish to teach, process drama.

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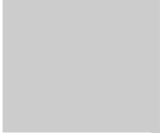
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This book is warmly dedicated to the memory of Prof. Rex Nettleford, former Vice Chancellor, University of the West Indies and Dorothy Heathcote, the towering figure of drama education whose inspirational work brought us together and set us off along the path.



Contents

List of figures

Foreword

Preface

Acknowledgements

- 1 Drama and education**
- 2 Distilling the principles of planning for process drama**
- 3 Theme/learning area**
- 4 Context**
- 5 Role**
- 6 Frame**
- 7 Sign**
- 8 Strategies**
- 9 Planning for diverse learning groups**
- 10 Making it happen!**
- 11 Planning 'on your feet' in the unfolding drama**
- 12 Process drama planner**

Further reading

Works cited in the text

Index



Figures

[1.1 The drama learning helix](#)

[2.1 The cornerstones of process drama](#)

[2.2 Principles of planning process drama](#)

[6.1 The two aspects of frame](#)

[7.1 Pierce's sign classification](#)

[7.2 Bruner/Heathcote's trichotomy](#)

[7.3 Sign grid](#)

[10.1 The process drama engine](#)

[11.1 The hourglass dilemma](#)

[11.2 The unfolding drama](#)



Foreword

This valuable book is a collaborative venture between two internationally acknowledged leaders in drama in education – Pamela Bowell in London, England, and Brian Heap in Kingston, Jamaica – and represents so well their continuing development as professional educators in search of ways to support classroom instructors involved in incorporating this interactive and engaging art form. Building on their first version written ten years ago, they have constructed a revised and supportive framework for implementing techniques and strategies that will help teachers working with different age groups and disciplines to organize and implement process drama as a powerful medium for learning.

Theatre is at the heart of drama education and the authors bring that awareness to each aspect of their work, exploring a variety of forms that draw upon the common elements of theatre: focus, metaphor, tension, symbol, contrast, role, time and space. But they create, with those principles, a system for helping teachers apply them to actual classroom contexts – in drama lessons, in extra-curricular activities and in areas of the curriculum. For those of us involved in professional development, the questions that teachers bring forward often reveal the real needs of the classroom, and the authors have structured their book around the questions that matter to those who are actually working with the students: *‘But already there’s not enough time to fit everything in. How can we add drama?’*, *‘Does drama really always have to be about people and the human condition?’*

The responses to these queries are full of insights concerning the practice of teaching and learning, as well as offering concrete suggestions for strengthening the dynamics of drama as a force for education. The chapters are cleverly arranged so that the information on drama methodology is cumulative, with the questions and answers continually moving the readers into the specifics of how drama could work for them. Useful and workable strategies are provided for the authors’ four core goals: to establish the dramatic context, to move the story of the drama forward, to explore a greater depth of meaning and feeling, and to help the participants reflect on the drama.

As well, the models of drama work taken from classroom experiences allow us to see these goals and strategies ‘in action’; we know that this book is written by practitioners who blend theory and practice and who offer authentic contexts for building meaningful drama experiences with students. The assessment strategies that are included will help teachers to see what has happened over time with their students as a result of the drama experiences, and the diagrams will present holistic views of the processes and strategies they can refer to as they explore themes and issues with the many forms and conventions that drama provides.

We are grateful that Pamela Bowell and Brian Heap are sharing their experiences and learning as drama educators with us in this book, helping us to continue to plan, develop and focus our own lessons carefully and with intention, to incorporate the voices of all of our students, to think deeply about what we have attempted or achieved, to honour the wants and needs of our students, and to make the teaching of drama a truly significant component of the school curriculum.

David Booth
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Preface

This book is about that type of drama in an educational setting that is known as process drama. Often called drama in education or ‘living through’ drama or ‘experiential drama’ or applied drama, it is the sort of work that is created not for a watching audience but for the benefit of the participants, themselves.

Process drama is to be found in all age phases of school and in the hands of both specialist and non-specialist drama teachers. It is practised in education systems around the world, as part of a discrete drama curriculum or as a cross-curricular pedagogy.

If you are looking for help to implement process drama with your students, then no matter which phase of education you teach in, nor which curriculum structure, this book sets out a framework of guiding principles and advice that will enable you to plan and deliver process drama to suit your needs and constraints.

We have drawn on a range of examples that were originally taught by a number of different teachers, ourselves included. However, for clarity and continuity, we have referred to the teacher as ‘she’ throughout the text. Similarly, on those occasions when it has been necessary to speak about an individual child we have adopted the convention of ‘he’.

While we have referred to numerous examples to illustrate different points in the text, we have introduced four ‘key examples’ that run throughout. As we discuss each planning principle the key examples appear so that it is possible to follow through the planning of each drama, seeing how each layer is laid upon the next to build its structure.



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Our thanks go to our respective institutions, colleagues, friends and students (of many ages) and families who have been our most ardent supporters; Jonothan Neelands on whose classification of drama strategies we have drawn and *Drama Australia Journal* and *Applied Theatre Researcher* for permission to reproduce in [Chapter 11](#) parts of material first published by them.

Chapter

1

Drama and Education

KEY QUESTION: Where does drama fit into education?

Drama in education has had a rather roller-coaster existence. Whether in the UK or other parts of the world, there are times when it is clearly evident that drama is valued but there have also been times when it has been out of favour, the victim of a 'back to basics' approach to education.

This situation has been largely politically driven, dependent upon changing governmental opinion about the value of arts in education. However, in the past, there have also been divisions among some practitioners, themselves, regarding what the precise nature of drama in education should be – a situation that has not always worked to drama's advantage. Fortunately, this situation has been steadily giving way, internationally, to a climate of greater consensus in which practitioners recognise an inclusive model that seeks to accommodate a range of ways of making drama, all grounded in performance. These might include, for example, opportunities for students to engage in dramatic playing, like a dressing-up corner in the early years setting, perform a classic text, participate in a theatre-in-education programme or share in improvised work in the classroom. What is important, here, is that we understand that *all* these forms of drama experience share the same common elements of theatre: focus, metaphor, tension, symbol, contrast, role, time, space; and that when, as teachers, we come to plan the drama experiences for the students we teach, no matter what sort of drama we intend to do, we need to bear these elements in mind.

So, drama experiences in an educational setting can, and indeed should, be varied. Teachers need to provide students with the opportunity to engage in a range of challenging, exciting and stimulating drama experiences, grounded in a range of genres that enable them to understand and manipulate the art form of drama. Students should learn to use it not only to develop an understanding of themselves within the world but also to comment on their

experiences of it.

‘But why Teach Drama in the First Place?’

Well, the obvious, short answer for teachers in some parts of the world is ‘because the national curriculum demands it’. However, we believe there are more compelling educational reasons that we would like to discuss here as a way of placing this book in the context of students’ learning.

We believe that children inhabit the world as fully as adults do – and our task as teachers is to create opportunities that will enable them to interact with that world and to understand it more fully through their interaction so they may function more successfully in it.

However, we recognise that the majority of experiences in school offer students a sort of second-hand interaction with the world, filtered through the teacher, television producer, author and so on. In circumstances such as these, feeling is easily separated from thinking and knowing and when this separation occurs the chance of information becoming personalised and, therefore, usable knowledge is reduced. In order to usefully know, we need to feel.

As long ago as 1966, Jerome Bruner endorsed this view in *Towards a Theory of Instruction*, when he suggested that a learner needs to participate actively in the learning process and that a child’s feelings, fantasies and values need to be incorporated into lessons so that knowledge becomes personalised. The drama process makes this possible. By its nature, it affords the chance for first-hand interactive learning experience. In creating a world within a drama and inviting learners to invest directly and actively something of themselves in it, the teacher creates the opportunity for understanding to be perceived, which is directly transferable to the real world.

‘How Can this be?’

We realise that on the face of it, this might seem paradoxical. After all, by its nature drama is make-believe, a fiction, and therefore could be viewed as an escape from reality rather than the reverse. However, to accept this is to ignore the root of the drama process, which is the way in which children make sense of the world around them. That is, through using dramatic play to practise life. The eminent scientist, Jacob Bronowski, in his essay, *The Imaginative Mind in Science* (1981) suggested that ‘a child’s play frolics in the fantasy world and experiments in the rational world’ and that both of these elements are engaged by imagination. It is this unique human ability that enables us all – not just children – to play and to create circumstances that

are not actually present to our senses now. This means that we can manipulate images to conjure worlds which are beyond our immediate experiences and by doing this we open the door to all imaginative thought.

The drama process draws upon this natural ability to create imaginary situations through which to explore real experiences: upon our ability to willingly suspend disbelief so that the upturned table is a sailing ship or the school hall is a rainforest when we want them to be. Drama has the ability to link different areas of experience by putting together the faces of fantasy and reality. This enables experiences to illuminate and enrich each other so that changes in perception and understanding can occur. It is a process that provides the opportunity to see afresh and differently.

All children in the course of their dramatic playing project themselves into all worlds, possible and not possible, and by doing so discover for themselves the boundary that lies between them. Imagination actively harnessed within the drama process allows us to see various courses of action, weigh them up and test them out, without suffering the long-term consequences of choice.

If we are parents, early years teachers, have younger siblings or other young children in the family or if we are just keen observers of the behaviour of children, we will all have copious examples of this phenomenon in action. The parent who hears her words of censure echoed when her child plays 'mummies and daddies'; the teacher who sees her own actions recreated in the playground as the children play 'school'; the younger child who creates a situation in which, *this time*, his view prevails instead of that of his older brother or sister.

This is one of the cornerstones on which drama in education is built and, because drama is a social, interactive arts process, it creates experiences that enable the development of cognitive, emotional, social, cultural and creative understanding and skills.

'But isn't Drama Just about Acting?'

Of course, one of the important things drama does is to give its participants the opportunity to develop performance skills and perform to others. We mentioned this at the very beginning of this introduction. We also pointed out that performance and the elements of theatre underpin *all* work in drama in an educational context.

However, just as the learning that children gain from involvement in music, dance and the visual arts within education is wide-ranging, so the potential for learning provided by drama is more encompassing than the term 'acting' suggests. Teachers, especially those who are new to drama, may apply too narrow a definition to it and, by so doing, limit the opportunities for their

classes.

Drama is empowering. Through the unique process of ‘enactment’, its diversity of form stimulates creativity and imagination, aesthetic sensitivity and fulfilment. Drama provides opportunities for investigation and reflection, for celebration and challenge. It is a potent means of collaboration and communication that can change the ways people feel, think and behave. By its combination of the affective and the effective, it sharpens perception, and enables personal expression and the growth of intellectual and emotional literacy. It provides a framework for the exploration of ideas and feelings and the making of meaning. Drama is embedded in culture and provides a means by which children and young people can understand themselves and relate to those around them.

When teachers create drama opportunities for their students, they provide a complex, rich and vivid means through which the students become artists and, through learning about the art form, develop a means through which to learn about the world around them.

‘But how can they Learn about Drama and about other things through it?’

Well, it is not quite as odd as it sounds. The important thing to realise is that drama always has to have content. It has to be *about* something. So, it offers two strands of learning opportunity that are both always present – learning about the nature of drama and learning through drama about other things. It may be that the teacher and/or students decide to focus on one or other at any given moment, but they are both there, always. Perhaps the diagram ([Figure 1.1](#)) would help clarify things.

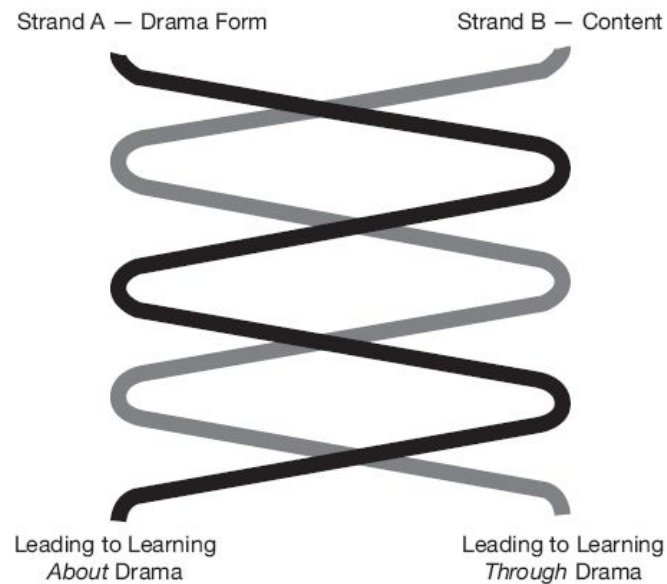


Figure 1.1 The drama learning helix

Now let's explain the diagram. A helix is a very good model to explain what we mean. In fact, it has often been used in the past by other practitioners to illustrate the relationship between form and content. It demonstrates quite graphically that the two strands of learning are always there, entwined together. Although one may be in sharper focus than the other at any given moment the other is always present. It also shows that the focus can shift between the two strands. This could be from moment to moment within a drama lesson, or from session to session within a unit of work or from year to year through an entire drama curriculum.

Where the emphasis is on developing theatre skills and an appreciation of theatre, Strand A would obviously be brought to the foreground, but Strand B *must* be present because as we have said earlier all drama has to have a content – it must be about something. Similarly, when the emphasis is on learning about other things through drama, Strand B will be brought into sharper definition. However, if what you are doing is going to be called drama, Strand A *must* be engaged because unless you are using the art form of drama, whatever you are doing, it is *not* drama.

In staging the wedding scene from Shakespeare's *Much Ado About Nothing* as part of a GCSE drama class, for example, one's focus might be on the honing of the performance skills needed to impart the emotional level of the situation. This focus is clearly drawn from what we are calling Strand A. However, in order to discover their characters' motivations and inform their

performances, the students will need to engage with what this scene of the play is *about*. In fact, it is concerned with jealousy and revenge and in trying to understand this therein lies the possibility of examining something of the nature of human relationships – a focus that lies in Strand B.

On the other hand, in a drama with 9-year-olds about the problem of the social costs of traffic congestion in cities – a Strand B focus – the teacher will also be able to press them, for example, to develop their skills in using a range of drama strategies to present ‘evidence’ to town planners as effectively as possible – a focus from Strand A.

‘So what’s this Book about?’

As we have already stated, drama in an educational setting encompasses many different types of drama. However, in our experience, it seems that while teachers value the complete range of approaches, there are some that they find more problematic to structure than others. This leads many to avoid ways of working that they find less easy to implement and yet which have the potential to provide rich and rewarding experiences for students and teacher alike.

What has come to be known as ‘process drama’ is a case in point and this book seeks to provide a clear guide to the fundamental principles of planning and teaching using this type of approach.

DISTILLING THE PRINCIPLES OF PLANNING FOR PROCESS DRAMA

Process drama is a term used to describe the type of drama in which performance to an external audience is absent but presentation to the internal audience is essential. Whereas in some other ways of working, the meaning is made by the theatrical ensemble of actors, playwright, director and designers and communicated to a watching audience, in process drama the participants, together with the teacher, constitute the theatrical ensemble and engage in drama to make the meaning for themselves.

Fundamentally, this is a whole-group drama process, essentially improvised in nature, in which attitude is of greater concern than character. This is not to say that participants in process drama never work in other configurations (they frequently do) nor that they never plan or rehearse aspects of the drama before-hand. However, it is essentially, as the great drama teacher Dorothy Heathcote frequently described it, lived at life-rate and operates from a discovery-at-this-moment basis rather than being memory-based. That is to say that participants in process drama will not normally be involved with learning and presenting lines from a pre-written dramatic text – a play – but will be ‘writing’ their own play as the narrative and tensions of their drama unfold in time and space and through action, reaction and interaction.

It focuses on developing a dramatic response to situations and materials from a range of perspectives. In other words, participants in process drama take on roles that are required for the enquiry, investigation or exploration of the subject matter of the drama. The task of the teacher is to find ways in which to connect the students with the content and enable them to develop responses to it through active engagement and reflection.

By privileging the participants’ ability to empathise and respond to a situation or given materials, the way is open for the teacher to introduce a range of dramatic strategies that will lead to deeper engagement with the subject matter of the drama while, at the same time, broadening the participants’ experience of the conventions of the art form and their ability to creatively manipulate them for themselves.

‘What do Students Learn through Process Drama?’

Practitioners have described the areas of learning in drama in a number of different ways but most agree that the learning falls into broad categories that include:

- learning about the art form;
- personal, social and cultural learning – including language, moral and spiritual development;
- and cross-curricular learning.

If we refer again to the helix diagram of learning strands, it is easy to see how the areas of learning relate to the strands. Strand A subsumes the learning about the

art form area and Strand B subsumes the cross-curricular and personal, social and cultural areas.

It is important that we recognize this broad scope for learning inherent within engagement with drama because such recognition will enable us as teachers to plan drama experiences for children that provide optimum potential for that learning to take place.

The most important aspect to keep in mind is that, no matter which learning objectives we have set for the students – personal, social and cultural, cross-curricular or about the art form – the absolutely most effective way of ensuring that the children achieve them is to plan the best drama experience possible. In a nutshell: the better the drama, the better the learning.

The better we can make the process drama experience for the participants through our careful planning, preparation and delivery, the greater will be the learning about the art form of drama and about other areas of the curriculum through drama. But, good drama, if it is to be effective, like any other educational activity, requires serious planning.

‘Are there any Guiding Principles to Planning Good Process Drama?’

Process drama rests on a number of cornerstones. We have already identified one in the preceding chapter – the innate predisposition of children to learn through dramatic playing. There are others, also, as you can see in the diagram (Figure 2.1), that we need to identify and keep in mind as they underpin the planning of the drama: a recognition that learning takes place most effectively when it is contextualised, that learners who have a sense of ownership about their learning have a greater commitment to it and therefore gain more from it as a result and that, universally, human beings use drama to symbolically represent life experiences and to make comment on them. These all have a direct bearing on the planning of process drama.

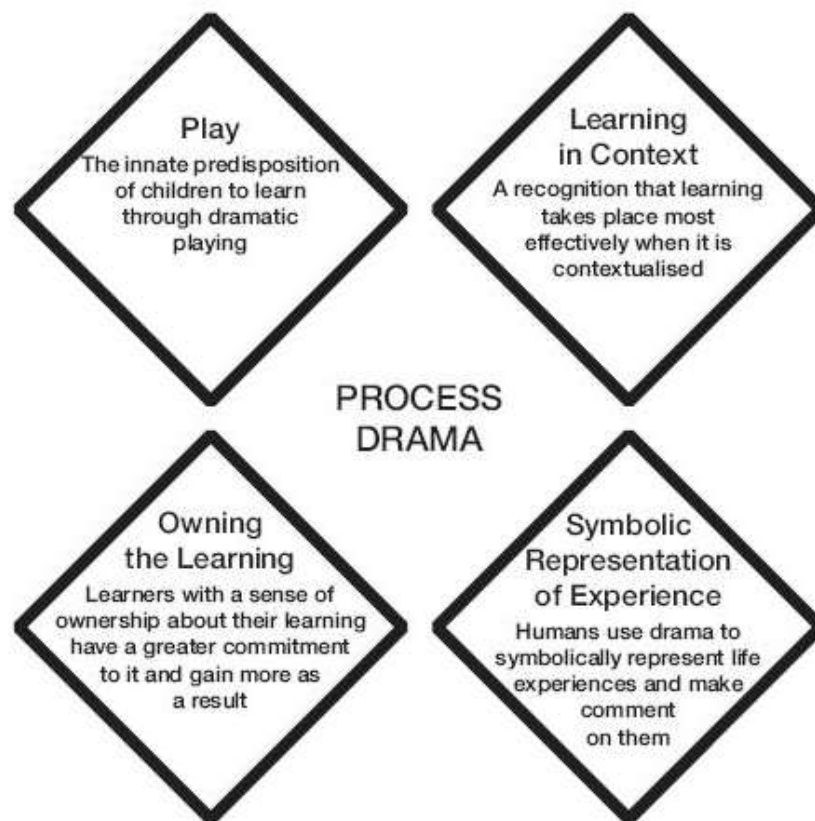


Figure 2.1 The cornerstones of process drama

Crucially, each informs the nature of the learning structures we create with our students and impacts upon the place of the teacher within them. As this book unfolds, we will return to each of these in greater detail but now we wish to turn to the principles of planning process drama.

The Principles of Planning

Drama, like any other subject, needs to be planned with rigour if the teacher is to provide the best opportunity for the participants to learn. Our experience over many years has led us to the conclusion that the principles of planning process drama remain constant whether planning for 5-year-olds, 15-year-olds or, indeed, any age of learner. So, the rest of this chapter sets out an overview of what we consider to be the key principles of planning for process drama that, we believe, will help you no matter in what age phase of education you teach.

These planning principles are namely:

1. theme/ learning area
2. context
3. roles
4. frame
5. sign
6. strategies.

Perhaps it would be useful here to say something that will help to clarify our terminology. We mentioned in the opening chapter that all forms of drama experience share the same common elements of theatre including focus, metaphor, role, tension, symbol, contrast, time and space. If we are planning a process drama we have to ensure that what we build is scaffolded by these structural elements. The six principles of planning we have named here and their implementation, which lie at the heart of this book, are the means by which we construct the drama and ensure that the elements of theatre are incorporated

So let's look in a little more detail at each of them here. This will be a brief introduction in which we can see how the principles of planning and the elements of theatre relate to each other. When we revisit each planning principle in its own dedicated chapter, we will be exploring each in greater detail.

1 Theme/ Learning Area

We've already stated that drama must be about something. It must have content. This is actually what the theatre element 'focus' refers to. It is the particular aspect of the human condition under examination in the drama. In the educational setting, this focus or content will most likely be drawn from the broad curriculum as themes and topics or from the cross-curricular issues such as personal and social development. It is from these themes, topics or issues that the focus of the drama will be distilled, so that in process drama we can say that the theatre element of 'focus' is created through the choice of theme or learning area.

2 Context

In order to explore the theme or learning area on which we have decided to focus, we will need to develop a dramatic context. This dramatic context provides the particular fictional circumstances in which the theme will be explored. Essentially, as a fiction, the dramatic context stands for the real life human experience that will be explored in the drama. In other words, the dramatic context is the theatrical element of metaphor.

3 Roles

Another fundamental element of theatre and central to all performance forms is the taking of a role. In this aspect, the relationship between the planning principles and theatre elements is most obvious, because they share the same terminology.

4 Frame

Tension is the theatre element that 'charges' the drama. In planning for process drama, frame is a term we have used to describe the tension giver. Frame provides the means by which competing protagonistic and antagonistic forces, that is to say those characters or agencies in the drama that are in conflict about the outcome of the central dilemma, are introduced. In our view, planning an effective frame is the most crucial principle of all. While frame is a term borrowed from sociology, we would argue that it admirably suits the social nature of the art form.

5 Sign

An intricate system of signs including objects, sounds, language, gestures and images combine in all theatre genres to bring significance to the events of the

drama and direct attention to them. Signs represent more than just their utilitarian function. As we have established, dramas are metaphors for life experience and, within this framework, signs are the means by which the theatre element of symbol is evoked. The crucial aspect of signs, therefore, is that they function symbolically and efficiently. This means that organisation for significance is a fundamental principle for planning process drama.

6 Strategies

These are ways of working based on performance forms that bring the drama into life . In recognising that action in space and time are the elements that make theatre a dynamic form, strategies enable us to make adjustments to each. Moreover, using a range of strategies supports the element of contrast in the drama. This is important because drama hinges on three sets of contrasts – silence and sound, stillness and movement and darkness and light. Strategies that allow us to adjust time, space and contrasts help meaning to be made through the friction at the interface between them. In process drama terms, the judicious use of a range of strategies, therefore, enables teacher and students to explore time, place and event from different perspectives.

'This Seems like a lot to take in'

We know that this may sound a bit daunting but we hope that as the book unfolds you will see how these principles and elements relate to each other and how it is possible for even a quite inexperienced teacher to get to grips with the planning of high quality process drama with confidence.

Let's move on by seeing, in Figure 2.2 , how the planning principles relate to each other . If you remember that by following these principles of planning you will be building in the necessary theatre elements to your drama, then what we need to do now is look at the questions the teacher needs to ask herself in order to help her plan.

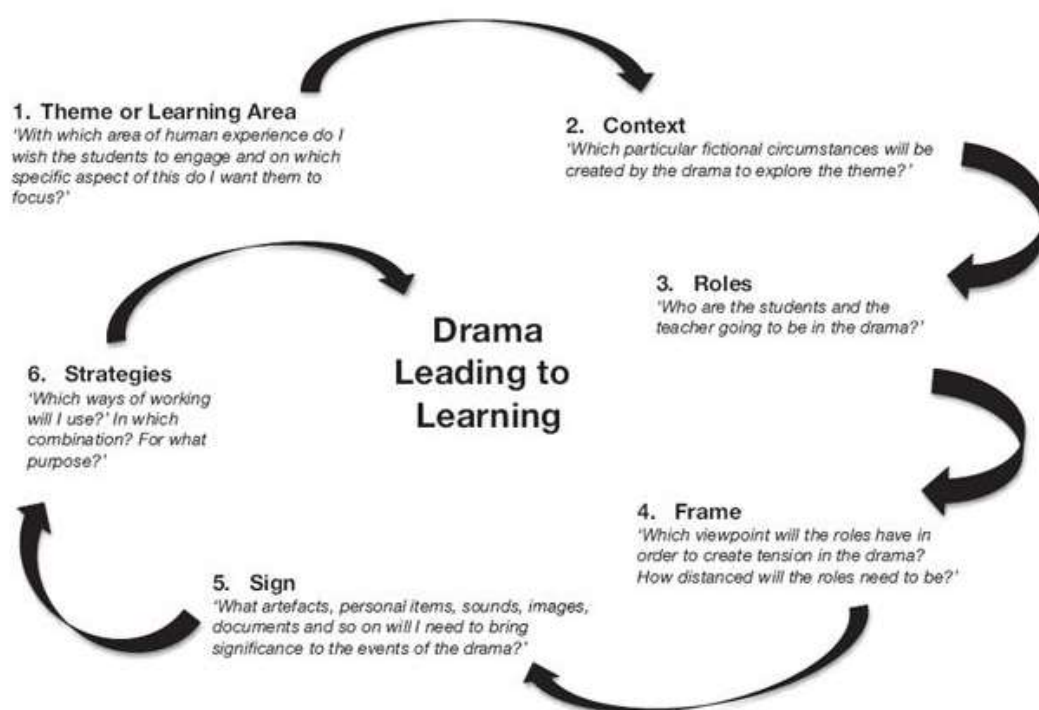


Figure 2.2 Principles of planning process drama

You can see in the diagram that each of the planning principles can be presented in terms of a series of key questions that the teacher must answer. So, we are going to look at each of the principles and, this time, explore the key questions for each.

1 Theme/ Learning Area

‘With which area of human experience do I wish the students to engage and on which specific aspect of this do I want them to focus?’

Just as with every other curriculum area or subject, it is essential from the beginning of the planning process for the teacher to identify precisely what her learning objectives for the class are. Particularly in the enduring climate of accountability in education, teachers need to clearly identify what precisely they wish students to gain from each lesson so that they can make informed decisions about how best to plan for that learning to take place. Moreover, because process drama is always concerned with matters of human significance, the teacher will also need to define the theme or learning area in terms of the human dimension within it.

2 Context

‘Which particular fictional circumstances will be created by the drama to explore the theme?’

The answer to this question will often be in a broad, abstract or conceptual form. However, in order for the students to engage with the theme, the teacher needs to present it in a concrete form and within a defined framework made up of a carefully selected place, time and situation in which the action of the drama can unfold. An appropriately chosen dramatic context will offer the fictional circumstances in which students have the opportunity to thoroughly explore the theme in a meaningful way.

3 Roles

‘Who are the students and the teacher going to be in the drama?’

The fundamental activity in drama is taking on a role – imagining that you are walking in the shoes of someone else and exploring a situation through that person’s eyes. Having selected a dramatic context – the fictional circumstances of the drama – the teacher will now need to ‘people’ it by deciding upon the roles, that is to say the people that the students are going to become in the drama. She will need to ensure that those she chooses are found in the time and place of the context and will have an appropriate ‘reason’ for engaging with the theme. Because teacher-in-role is a fundamental aspect of process drama, the teacher will also have to decide on which role she is going to take in the drama.

4 Frame

Which viewpoint will the roles have in order to create tension in the drama and how distanced will the roles need to be?’

The currency of process drama is talk, and so creating the climate in which meaningful talk can be generated is a key element of planning. In process drama it is the point of view that a role has about what is happening in the drama that is critical in generating this climate. It gives participants something to talk about and one aspect of frame provides the dramatic tension necessary to drive the drama forward – the communication frame. There is a second aspect of frame that is concerned with what Dorothy Heathcote calls ‘protecting into the experience’. Often in drama we want participants to engage with sensitive or difficult material or with situations that are far beyond their own immediate experience. In circumstances like these we need to find a framework that will enable participation safely. Application of the second aspect of frame allows this to happen – it is known as the distancing frame.

5 Sign

‘What artefacts, personal items, sounds, images, documents and so on will I need to bring significance to the events of the drama?’

When planning a process drama, we deliberately set out to create an exciting, stimulating learning experience for our students that will engage them on a

number of levels. We do this, however, with a clear learning outcome in mind, and so need to ensure that in the midst of such an experience, the students' attention is directed to the heart of the learning. One of the key ways in which this happens is through the use of signs. These are things such as artefacts and personal items – documents, sounds, images and three-dimensional objects for instance – which bring significance to the drama, direct the learners' attention and help them to explore actively the precise focus of the lesson.

6 Strategies

'Which ways of working will I use? In which combination? For what purpose?'

There are many different ways of creating the drama, of making it happen, of moving it forward and enabling reflection on what has happened in it and enabling contemplation of what is to come. An informed choice of strategies, by the teacher who recognises their different qualities, will provide students with the opportunity to learn about the art form and will also provide them with the means to explore and present the content of the drama and to reflect upon it.

'Can you Say More about these Principles in Detail?'

Yes. It is important now to explore each of the principles in more depth so that the way in which they relate to each other and combine to produce a powerful process drama can be seen more clearly. So, in subsequent chapters, we will examine each principle in closer detail. As you work through the planning sequence and especially as you become more familiar with what to do, you will find that, often, ideas will overlap, pop into your mind simultaneously or in a different order to the one we are setting out here. However, to make sure that we pay sufficient attention to each principle, so that we explain them clearly, we are going to deal with each one separately by setting them out in a linear sequence. Moreover, if you are new to process drama, following this sequence, step by step, will help you to understand and plan successfully. What follows next, then, is the chapter dealing with the first principle, and this is the one that always comes first – deciding the theme or learning area.

CHAPTER 3: THEME/LEARNING AREA

KEY QUESTION: With which area of human experience do I want the students to engage?

While there will always be unexpected outcomes, learning through process drama is not arbitrary or random. In determining a theme for drama, whether she is a generalist primary teacher or a drama specialist in secondary school, the most important question for the teacher to ask is ‘What do I want the children to learn about? What is the focus of the drama?’

We have already considered that when learners are engaged in drama, the nature of the experience means that they will have the opportunity for learning in three broad categories – learning about the art form of drama itself, personal, social and cultural learning, and cross-curricular learning. If the teacher bears these in mind, they will help her to find the answer to the very important question she has asked herself. The result should be an informed choice of theme or learning area for the drama.

So, for example:

Personal and social learning

- Do the learners need to work more effectively in a team?
- Do they need to enhance their self-esteem?
- Do they need to have a greater connection to the local community?
- Do they need to understand how people have dealt with racism?

Learning about the art form

- Do they need to work on drama using space and levels?
- Do they need to be able to express themselves more physically?
- Do they need to use more dialogue and use voice more expressively?
- Which new strategies do I want to introduce to the class?

Cross-curricular learning

- Do they need to learn about the great contribution of women in the First World War?
- Do they need to know about the worldwide achievement of the West Indies in sports, art and culture , music, science and technology, public life, medicine, etc.?
- Do they need to explore the impact of global warming on world climate?

Asking ourselves such questions will help begin to focus on what we want the participants to learn from the drama and will also put us in a position to make informed decisions in planning the experience for the class.

‘But what about Prescribed Curricula?’

Many teachers find themselves working within the constraints of what variously might be called a state, a provincial or a national curriculum. In these circumstances, the scope of drama may well be contained by these prescribed curricula so that our practice is shaped by what is laid down by local or national authority . In effect, for some teachers , this may mean they have a very broad range of possibilities from which to work. For others, opportunities will need to be found from within a much narrower and more closely defined spectrum of activity.

In some countries, drama exists in the curriculum as a discrete subject in its own right. Elsewhere, it is subsumed within another subject or seen as a largely pedagogic tool or perhaps as an elective or extra-curricular activity.

Even where drama is part of a statutory curriculum, as we mentioned in Chapter 1 , changes in government and political priorities often lead to a curriculum restructuring. This means that teachers in many situations, especially primary school teachers, frequently find themselves faced with having to teach some things with which they are less familiar or less confident – and sometimes that’s drama. Given that our individual training experiences are different, it is not surprising that some teachers, perhaps, will be a bit daunted when faced with a drama curriculum.

However, it seems to us that the content of most drama curricula can be broken down into a number of broad categories:

- creating drama – including investigation, experimentation and responding to stimuli;
- presenting drama; and
- responding to/ critically reflecting on drama.

Looked at in this way, what is prescribed becomes more manageable and, although some might see this as an over-simplification and others may well use alternative categories, we think that this breakdown is a helpful one for teachers who are new to the teaching of drama.

If we think about this a bit more, it becomes clear that experience of process drama is one among a range of opportunities that the teacher may well need to offer to learners if their curriculum is going to be delivered effectively. By looking in more detail at how to structure process drama experiences, as we shall be in the following chapters, and by following through a number of key examples, we will be able to see how it provides opportunities to meet curricular requirements.

But there are also other key cross-curricular themes that many teachers are required to address, such as personal, social and health education (PHSE); the spiritual, moral and cultural dimensions of the curriculum; good citizenship and social cohesion and creativity. Here, process drama offers a dynamic, effective and affective means through which learners can engage with these important issues. This is because the social interaction of human beings and the exploration of issues that are significant to them lie at the heart of all drama.

‘But Already there’s not Enough Time to Fit Everything in. How can we Add Drama?’

No matter where we teach, it seems certainly true that we have ever greater demands placed upon us. In curricula that are crowded there is a real concern about how teachers can ensure that each subject is given due attention. Under circumstances like these, especially in those situations in which drama does not stand as a discrete subject, finding the time for it can be difficult.

However, if we look at this problem from another point of view, we can perhaps see another way to make time available.

We have already pointed out that process drama, as all drama, must have content; it has to be about something. We’ve already suggested that cross-curricular themes lend themselves to exploration through drama. But, in addition to this, we can also look to the curriculum content of other subjects as a source of material. Exploring this through drama will provide exciting and engaging opportunities to enhance learning about that content and also provide time in which learners can continue to develop their ability to use the drama form, just as we illustrated in the diagram about learning Strands A and B in Chapter 1 . So, providing that when we choose the subject matter we remember that drama is always concerned with people, with matters concerned with the human condition, then the scope for drama within the whole curriculum is really very broad.

‘Does Drama Really Always have to be about People and the Human Condition?’

Actually, yes it does. It is absolutely essential to remember that drama is concerned with people and their life experiences. Drama, like all art forms, is concerned with the symbolic representation of life experience and this is compounded by its being a social, interactive arts process – drama is essentially about people and their relationships, dilemmas, concerns, hopes, fears, aspirations, celebrations and rites of passage, all of which create ties that bind them together.

So, when choosing the learning area, we need to identify some aspects of the human condition to learn about. This seems relatively straightforward if, for example, the teacher is embarking on an examination of ‘racism’ or ‘friendship’ or

The Diary of Anne Frank, which all obviously deal with some aspect of human experience.

However, if something like 'transport' is the class theme (which may well be the case in a primary or an elementary school, for example) then we must ask how 'people' and 'transport' go together. The teacher needs to tease out the human dimension because, while little learning about the topic will come from students pretending to be cars or trains, a great deal will come from their considering, in role, the dilemma of new roads disrupting old communities or the dichotomy between the benefits of air travel and the accompanying environmental pollution.

Teachers often see traditional tales such as Goldilocks and the Three Bears; the Anansi stories of West Africa and the Caribbean; or Aesop's Fables, all of which feature animals as central characters, as a potentially rich source of drama. This is, indeed, true . However, dramas based on such stories will only succeed if we remember that they work metaphorically and actually reflect the human condition and not the behaviour of animals. So in dramas based on stories like these, even when participants take on the role of animals, they will need to be focused on the resolving of the human-like dilemmas that face them rather than 'acting' like animals.

Again, if the teacher really thinks about it, even a learning area like 'seismology' has within it the potential for drama, provided it is approached from the point of view of the impact of nature upon people – for example, the impact of earthquakes and volcanoes on different civilisations, the dilemma between the need to enforce strict building codes and the demand of people for cheap housing in an earthquake zone, or the dilemma of those who farm the nutrient-rich soils on active volcanic slopes but who are at daily risk from an eruption.

‘Could you Give Some More Detailed Examples?’

This might be a good point at which to introduce a set of four key examples that we will be developing and to which we will be returning at each stage in the book as the planning process unfolds.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

Theme/Learning Area

Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.

Background

A class of 30 mixed ability 6- and 7-year-olds in an inner-city infant school in London. This was a lively class of children who had some previous experience of process drama. The drama took place within the classroom, with tables moved back when appropriate and was taught in five weekly, one-hour sessions, combining timetabled time for science and drama. This was because the hall was unavailable at the time needed.

Reasons for Selecting Theme

In line with the science curriculum, the teacher wished to use process drama to enhance the learners’ investigative skills and develop their appreciation of the need to care for living things in their environment. She also wished them to develop their skills of collaboration, decision-making and problem-solving. Finally, she wished to broaden their knowledge of drama strategies by using ways of working that the children had not yet met. This theme – *taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people* – offered the potential for developing a process drama that had, at its heart, a human dimension in the shape of a conflict of interests.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

Theme/learning area

What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?

Background

A class of 32 mixed ability 8- and 9-year-olds in an inner-city primary school in London with a particularly rich ethnic and cultural mix. This was also a lively class that had some experience of process drama. The drama, for the most part, took place in the hall and was taught over ten, weekly 45-minute sessions, combining timetabled time for PHSE and for English.

Reasons for Choice of Theme

The children's own family backgrounds were very diverse. The overwhelming majority came from families that had relocated to London from a range of places, both intra- and internationally. In order to explore and celebrate this situation and to respond to elements of the PHSE and citizenship curriculum requirements, the teacher decided on this theme – *what makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?* Dramatically, this also held the potential to draw upon the archetypal narrative structure of 'the journey'.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

Theme/learning area

Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?

Background

A group of 35 Jamaican able and talented 11- to 13-year-olds selected from different schools to participate in a workshop held over five consecutive days. Some of the students involved were developing behavioural problems associated with the fact that their current scheme of work in school was insufficiently challenging and was uninteresting to them. One of the aims of the workshop was to help teachers and parents of the students understand the need to develop supplementary enrichment programmes.

Reasons for Choice of Theme

The brief given to the teacher by the organisers of the workshop was to use drama with a science-based theme that could readily accommodate a range of creative and artistic expression and visits by resource persons from the community, and could culminate in a presentation of work to parents, teachers and friends. A high level of ability among the students also meant that the theme selected, while relating to the existing curriculum, would have

to be more challenging, motivating the students to fully engage their intellectual capabilities. It was further felt that the controversial nature of a theme like *creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?* might stimulate a high level of debate and discussion. There was also a need to encourage greater self-motivation in the participants, and therefore, a need to develop an authentic research atmosphere in which the task-oriented dramatic activity could take place.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

Theme/learning area

Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?

Background

This drama was done with a class of 40 students (19 girls and 21 boys) in a secondary day-school in Lusaka, Zambia. The highly enthusiastic and motivated group of students had very little, if any, previous experience of process drama. The work was conducted in a standard classroom setting during a one-day workshop split into two sessions, one in the morning and another in the afternoon. There were a number of observers present at the sessions at various times during the course of the day including an ethnographer, the class teacher, the deputy head teacher, a representative of the British charity Voluntary Service Overseas and three representatives of the charity Save the Children (Sweden and South Africa) as sponsors.

Reasons for the Choice of Theme

The school was selected as part of a pilot project by the Ministry of Education in Zambia in order to evaluate how useful process drama was as a methodology in the Zambian context and in particular its effectiveness in the delivery of HIV/AIDS education. The sessions conducted with the Zambian students were largely in response to observations that traditional didactic methods applied to HIV/AIDS education, uninformed by the perceptions of young people and unrelated to the contexts of their lives, were unlikely to have much impact. One of the main objectives of the process drama sessions was the need to combat the dangerous capacity of the HIV/AIDS pandemic to produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals, as well as to counter the

temptation for individuals to distance themselves from such stigma and possibly the care of those infected. In deciding on a theme for the drama it was decided that a more compassionate approach should be taken, rather than risk replicating the often emotionally detached tone of public campaigns encouraging abstinence, being faithful and the use of condoms. Using the experience of the drama to nurture an immediate concern for those persons infected and affected would assist in working towards the eradication of stigma, an important part of any educational intervention in this aspect of human experience.

We hope that it is clear from our four key examples that the teacher needs to be sure about what she wishes to teach through process drama and that she must hold in mind, always, that the drama must have human interaction at its centre.

‘Are there any other Considerations Regarding Choice of Theme?’

At first glance, the contents of some prescribed curricula may not readily appear to lend themselves to exploration through drama. Sometimes they appear to be too general or too academic to inspire any real creativity in the approach to their delivery. However, all curricula address at least *some* aspects of human experience and this is the key to bringing drama and the rest of the curriculum together to enable learning. Broad themes can be broken down into a range of topics and subtopics in a way that will eventually reveal the human dimension and so yield their potential for exploration through drama and we shall talk about this in greater detail, shortly. However, we also need to bear in mind that other constraints impact upon planning, and factors such as time, space and availability of resources have to be given serious thought, too.

The availability of resources is an issue. We have to be sure that the learning area for the drama chosen by the teacher can be supported by the appropriate materials and information. The process drama approach to learning often creates an imperative for research, manufacture and creative endeavour – in fact, this is one of its many strengths. The teacher, therefore, needs to be able to provide what the learners need. For example, if she chooses to do a drama in which they will be required to create illuminated manuscripts, then clearly she needs to be able to provide paper and markers at the very least. Or, if the drama demands that the learners make a variety of sound effects, then the teacher will need to provide the means by which these can be made. This does not imply that a teacher needs to have a stock cupboard full of paper or

musical instruments before she can plan for drama; imagination can create much of what is needed. However, in a drama with particular tasks at its heart that demand that the participants actually undertake them (such as creating manuscripts), if those sorts of resources are in short supply, then the drama should be about something else!

Yet another critical consideration in choosing a theme for drama is the amount and type of space that the teacher has at her disposal. Many teachers automatically think that in order to teach a drama session they need access to a large, open space such as the school hall or a drama studio. However, in practice, much high quality drama can take place in the ordinary classroom environment. This does not mean that a large space might not be desirable, even crucial, for some sections of a drama but it does mean that if it's not available, then with a judicious choice of theme, the teacher can create a drama with her class, which is positively enhanced by taking place within the classroom where chairs, tables and writing materials, for example, are available.

In other words, as a teacher you need to cut your coat according to your cloth! And on an encouraging note, we want to stress that some of the most creative and educative drama is born out of situations that have the fewest resources.

‘What Comes Next?’

We have now reached a point where the teacher is clear about the learning area for the drama. However, this is still in an abstract or conceptual form. She now needs to decide which particular set of circumstances will be created in the fiction of the drama to explore the theme in a concrete way. So, in the following chapter we will consider what the teacher needs to do in order to choose the *dramatic context* and will be using a range of examples, including our key examples, to illustrate the points we are making.

KEY QUESTION: Which particular circumstances will be created by the drama to explore the theme?

The term ‘context’ is frequently used in drama. It is a key notion but one which can seem complex because, in reality, the same word is used to refer to several different but important *sorts* of circumstances.

Other practitioners have written extensively about the different contexts in drama but we are going to highlight just three aspects of context in relation to drama and concentrate on the one we feel teachers new to process drama find most difficult to define – that is the *dramatic* context.

‘Could you Explain what you Mean by these Different Aspects of Context?’

It’s not really very complicated. Let’s start with the one with which we will all be most familiar, *the real life context*.

Education does not happen in a vacuum. As teachers, we all know that we need to take many different circumstances into consideration when planning learning experiences for those we teach: their age, gender, experience, the social health of the group, the culture and ethos of the school, the place in which the drama is to happen, the curriculum demands and so on. These considerations have a bearing on the planning of process drama, too, and the teacher will have had them in the forefront of her mind when choosing the theme or learning area she wishes the class to tackle in the drama. When you come to plan process drama for yourself you will bring your own clear knowledge and understanding of all these circumstances to the choices you make in planning the drama for your class.

For example, if you have a confined space in which to work, then planning a

drama that demands a great deal of physical activity in a lot of space would not be appropriate; if you have a class for whom the language of instruction is not their mother tongue, this too will impact on the choice of subject matter and structure of the drama; if you are inexperienced in teaching drama, you might wish to start with a more simple, one-lesson drama rather than one that runs on over a number of sessions; if there has been an instance of bullying in the class, creating a piece of drama that explores the issue analogously will be much more appropriate than one in which the child who has been bullied is placed in a vulnerable position.

Let's now look at the second sort of 'context' that impacts on process drama – *the need for learning to have a context*.

Educational research, such as the work of Margaret Donaldson in her seminal book, *Children's Minds* (1978), has long underlined what we, as teachers, already know from our experience – that is, that learning takes place most effectively when it is contextualised. While we are able, on occasion, to change the learning context for learners (a visit to the museum, theatre, fire station, for example), with the best will in the world, time and financial constraints usually mean that for delivering the greatest part of the school curriculum there is only one basic context for learning – that is, learners in the classroom with the teacher.

However, there is a way in which we can access an infinite variety of contexts for learning without leaving the school. This, of course, is through imagination in action – drama. As we have already stressed, children naturally use dramatic playing as a way of learning about the world in which they live. They naturally place themselves in imagined roles or places and by doing this explore the 'what if' of a wide range of situations in an attempt to understand them better.

The human ability to 'willingly suspend disbelief' and imagine ourselves into an infinite variety of experiences is one of the foundations upon which process drama rests. It allows the teacher to harness the learners' creative energy in order to *contextualise* the learning that she wants for them.

For example, children's language learning takes place and develops through interactions in meaningful circumstances that suit the context in which the language is required. Process drama can create an infinite range of meaningful circumstances that provide just such opportunities for different modes of language, both verbal and written, to be used in context. We know, of course, that these circumstances are *fictional*, but because of the participants' suspension of disbelief, they become, for the duration of the drama, *'real'*.

Furthermore, drama engages participants on a cognitive, kinaesthetic and *emotional* level. Coupled with their suspension of disbelief, this means that

they find a ‘real’ reason in the drama for doing a host of activities – researching, problem-solving, negotiating, writing, building relationships and so on – because they *care* about the outcome of the drama. When children in school do things simply because the teacher requires them to, drama becomes a powerful means by which the teacher can help them to construct an imperative for learning, *for themselves* – what Dorothy Heathcote, in the video, *Pieces of Dorothy* (1993) called ‘education for self-direction’. Of course, as teachers we will always need to require learners to do a host of things as part of their learning activities in school. However, if a teacher recognises the power that drama has to *motivate* learning by engaging students at the *affective* as well as cognitive level, then she has at her disposal the means to aid the development of the whole person.

‘This is a Bit Complicated; Could you Give a Practical Example?’

Well, here is an example from a drama with a class of 6-year-olds in London, around the theme of non-standard units of measurement. The children, as villagers, developed a very real concern about the giant’s sore feet and the need to make him a pair of sandals. To achieve this, they were forced into using non-standard units of measurement – their own hand spans, feet and so on – in order to carry out the vital task of measuring the size of the giant’s feet. This they did with a rigour and application that was born out of the sense of purpose provided by the fictional context of the drama.

In this instance, the drama contextualised learning about the mathematical concept of non-standard units of measurement through a cognitive, kinaesthetic and *emotional* engagement with the material. It provided the class with a ‘real’ reason for using hand spans and such, and the multifaceted nature of the experience maximised their opportunity to *remember* what they had done and to feel good about what they had achieved.

As we said a moment ago, drama contextualises learning in fictional circumstances. If a teacher is convinced by drama’s ability to do this, then she needs to be able to plan these circumstances, or *dramatic contexts*, in which the learning can take place. This is the third aspect of context that we wish to explore. It is directly connected to the choice the teacher has made about what she wants the class to learn about – that is the theme or learning area, which we discussed in the previous chapter.

The selection of a particular set of fictional circumstances is the first big test for the teacher in planning process drama. She must develop the skill to translate what may be a general, broad or even abstract theme into a *concrete*

situation in which the participants can interact in a meaningful way. In other words, she has to choose an appropriate *dramatic context* in which to explore the theme.

‘How Do I Go about Choosing an Appropriate Dramatic Context?’

The success of your choice will depend on your ability to tightly define *exactly* what you want the learning to be about. If, for example, you had chosen ‘The Vikings’ as the learning area for an upper primary class, you might be tempted to think that you have decided enough to move on to the choice of dramatic context. However, ‘The Vikings’ is actually too loose a definition to allow for clear planning. It is not sufficiently focused. A teacher is unlikely to plan a successful history lesson, for example, with such an unfocused learning goal. She will ask herself ‘what exactly about the Vikings do I want the class to learn about today?’ and plan her lesson accordingly. So it is with planning process drama. The *exact* nature of the learning you want to promote will lead you into a range of dramatic contexts that will allow that learning to take place.

If we follow the Viking example, we need to decide what, *precisely*, it is about the Vikings that you want the students to learn in the drama. It isn’t sufficient to say ‘we’re going to do a drama about the Vikings’ – the teacher needs to identify *exactly what* about the Vikings she wants the class to engage with; for example, the navigation skills of the Vikings, the social structure of the Vikings and its consequences, the Vikings as artists, the Vikings as warriors, the Viking myths and legends, Viking settlements and occupations, the effect of the Vikings on other peoples, the Anglo-Saxon response to the Viking invasion.

‘But the Possibilities Seem Endless!’

Let’s take an example. Having narrowed down the focus of enquiry from the general topic of ‘The Vikings’ to a more specific aspect, such as how the Anglo-Saxons responded to the Viking invasion, it is possible to think of a range of *dramatic contexts* in which this might be explored.

<i>Place</i>	<i>Time period</i>	<i>Event</i>
Holy island	Viking times	The Viking landing
Mainland village	Viking times	Preparing to repel the invaders
Monastery	Mediaeval times	Chronicling Viking invasion
Village	Modern times	Commemorating defence of

Film studio	Modern times	village Making a film about the invasion
Archaeological site	Modern times	Excavating site of battle
Museum	Modern times	Setting up living museum display

And many more

Now a choice has to be made from this list. It might seem overwhelming at first but it is really a situation that should actually be seen as advantageous. In effect it means that the teacher has leeway to select the context that will most suit and benefit the particular class for whom the drama is being planned. Therefore, multiple dramatic contexts are available to you as a teacher, each offering a different handle on desired learning outcomes. You just need to remember that no context is necessarily better than another. They all simply offer different possibilities to the learners.

‘So how can you Tell what Kind of Dramatic Context will be Most Appropriate for a Particular Class?’

This is where the *real life context* informs your thinking about the dramatic context. Because each class has its own particular strengths and weaknesses, mix of personalities and needs, culturally specific curriculum and ethnic and gender mix, what seems to be a good choice for one group will not necessarily be at all appropriate for another. But the idea of focusing the learning area in order to get to the dramatic context remains the same. As we can see from the Viking example, there are basically three steps:

- Step 1* Decide exactly what you want the class to learn about the theme;
- Step 2* Think of as many dramatic contexts as possible in which it might be explored;
- Step 3* Choose the one that best suits the students for whom it is intended.

‘Could we Try it with Another Example?’

Let’s take something that is not necessarily historically based and at the same time is broad and universal, for example, Water.

Step 1 Exactly what do I want the children to learn about water?

- Water is a precious commodity and we need to conserve it

Step 2 How many contexts can I think of in which this could be explored?

•

<i>Place</i>	<i>Time period</i>	<i>Event</i>
Plant nursery	Present day	Finding ways to reduce water costs
Hospital	Present day	Devising systems for recycling waste water
Mountain forest	Present day	Preventing lowland flooding created by deforestation
Desert oasis	Present day	Calculating water needed to get caravan across the desert
Village community	Present day	Designing ways of storing water for use in dry season
Life raft after plane wreck at sea	Present day	Deciding how to collect potable water to stay alive
Polluted river	Present day	Experimentation with natural means to decontaminate water, such as water hyacinths
<i>And many more</i>		

Step 3 Choose the one that best fits the children for whom it is intended.

- Class: Year 5 (9- to 10-year-olds) in Kingston, Jamaica.

Real Life Context

Water is a critical issue in Jamaica, the students regularly wasted water by failing to turn off water in school washbasins. They had difficulty in seeing consequences of this negligence. Teacher judged that a dramatic context was needed which brought home to them that (a) water has a cost and (b) without water, things die.

Dramatic Context

From brainstormed list above, the plant nursery was chosen by the teacher as the context that would most suit this class because growing plants would most immediately bring home to them the consequences of actions.

It is important to say again that this choice did *not* mean that the other possible contexts offered poorer learning opportunities *per se*. They offered a range of lenses through which to examine the desired learning but the one chosen, in the opinion of the teacher, was most appropriate for the particular

class.

It is also important to point out that each would have given a different *slant* on the chosen theme. They would have all addressed the issue but the learning outcomes would have been somewhat different.

So, the teacher needs to bear in mind that the dramatic context provides an appropriate lens through which learners can examine the theme.

‘Could you Say More about Choice of Context?’

Perhaps this is a good time to return to our key examples that we first introduced and examined in [Chapter 3](#) when we talked about choice of learning area or theme.

What we will do now, in each key example, is identify the contexts the teachers selected and give reasons for their choices.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

Theme/learning area

Taking plant species from an environment and the consequences of this for local people.

Context

Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.

Reasons for Choice of Context

Remember that the teacher is deciding on the particular fictional circumstances that will be created by the drama to explore the theme. Remember, also, that we have stressed the human dimension in choice of theme. Since an action is already implicit in the theme – that is the act of removing a species of plant from its environment – in identifying the context, it only remains to settle on the particular circumstances that will be created in the drama to enable that ‘removal’ to take place and for the consequences of that action to be revealed for the purposes of the drama. A range of possibilities come to mind – the vandalising of the flower beds in the local park; deforestation by international logging companies; overharvesting of crops; ‘slash and burn’ agriculture; the smuggling of rare orchids, for example. However, in the end, the teacher here chose the collecting expedition by botanists to the rainforest as the context.

The inspiration for this was drawn from the fact that while natural sources for new medicines are still being discovered in plants, the relentless assault upon the world’s rainforests means that with every species lost the potential

for another cure is also lost. But, the context for this complex and serious situation has to be pitched at a level 6- and 7-year-olds can understand.

On a dramatic level, this context also provided the imperative for generating a range of thought, feeling and action on the part of the children, which would address the various learning goals that the teacher had in mind when beginning to plan the drama – see [Chapter 3](#) as a reminder.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>
Emigration – what makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.

Reasons for Choice of Context

As you will remember from the discussion in [Chapter 3](#) about how the teacher chose this particular theme, the children in this class almost all came from families who had undertaken such journeys as these. Some of the children, themselves, had journeyed from other places and others had parents or grandparents who had relocated. Some had come to this part of London from other towns and cities in the UK, but most of their families originated in places such as Bangladesh, Hong Kong, India, Ireland, Nigeria, Pakistan, the Philippines, Somalia, Turkey and the West Indies.

This choice of theme, therefore, was highly relevant to this class, but it was important not to select a context featuring one real life journey that would, by definition, exclude and devalue the journeys of the others. Therefore, finding a context that was removed in time and was an analogy for the sorts of journeys undertaken by their families was very important. By locating the drama in a journey that none of their families had really taken but that paralleled the experiences of them all, meant that they all could be involved equally in the fictional journey *and yet* draw upon their family histories as fuel for the drama.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>
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Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth? Present-day Jamaican law firm preparing to defend a client.

Reasons for Choice of Context

The brief given to the teacher in this instance, as outlined in [Chapter 3](#), was very wide-ranging. The students involved were highly capable and in need of a challenge. The controversy implicit in the theme selected already had a strong theatrical precedent in the play *Inherit the Wind*. But these were Jamaican children and the teacher was not sure that the students involved would be particularly interested in exploring the finer, historical details of the 1925 ‘Scopes Monkey Trial’ in Tennessee when rationalists challenged the law forbidding the teaching of evolution theory – the inspiration for the stage drama. However, the *issues* raised by the historical events could still have a continuing resonance for the students.

Sustaining interest in a court drama over the five-day period of the workshop was both unlikely and undesirable. Also what was needed was a dramatic context in which the students could be engaged in meaningful tasks. So, it was *preparing to defend a case* that was similar to, but not identical with the original that, in the teacher’s view, provided the most appropriate context in this particular situation.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/ AIDS on family life in Zambia –why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.

Reasons for the Choice of Context

The choice of context for this drama was influenced by the need to give the students something of a first-hand experience of the potentially negative

impact of stigma. At the same time it was important to protect the participants against having to take on the role of a stigmatized individual in the drama themselves until they had been given the chance to consider the full implications of that. In many ways the context was probably very familiar to the participants, even though the specifics of the situation appear rather daunting, since they involve an older brother, 'Thomas Musonda', taking on the responsibility for an infant sibling, 'Mark Bwalya', who, being HIV positive, is a potential target for stigmatization. But what this choice of dramatic context does is to remove the possibility of the HIV status being blamed on any kind of irresponsible adult sexual behaviour on the part of the main protagonists and allows the students to build an idea of someone who is HIV positive while maintaining a level of detachment and objectivity.

What can be drawn from the four key examples in relation to the choice of dramatic context? We can see that all of the teachers were concerned with *balance*. They each needed to find a context in which the various requirements of the curriculum learning area, the social, cultural and personal learning, the learning about drama itself and the needs and interests of the learners, could be held in balance *and facilitated by* the process drama structure.

'But, Doesn't Narrowing Down to the Specific Dramatic Context Mean that Teachers May Omit things from the Curriculum Brief?'

It is unrealistic to expect any particular learning experience to provide learners with *all* there is for them to know about the subject matter. What is important is allowing them to engage with the particular circumstances of a social encounter so that they will come to their own understanding about the learning. So, even where a theme appears to have been already narrowed down to what seems to be little more than a minor incident, the potential it holds for unpacking the curriculum is huge.

The Dolly Johnson Story is a case in point. This incident refers to the first woman, a laundress in Kingston, Jamaica, to have contracted cholera in the serious outbreak in the 1840s. She is mentioned in the autobiography of Mary Seacole and it is believed that she contracted the disease by taking a basket of laundry from an infected ship that came to Kingston from New Orleans. The incident, however, has great potential for learning within it and may be explored through drama in several different dramatic contexts.

Dolly Johnson Story

<i>Place</i>	<i>Time period</i>	<i>Event</i>
Dolly Johnson's laundry	1840s	The quarantining of the laundry
Jamaica National Assembly	1840s	Taking steps to control the cholera outbreak
On board the infected ship	1840s	Dispatching laundry ashore
On a film set	Modern times	Making a film of The Dolly Johnson Story
At an archaeological site	Modern times	Excavating the laundry buildings
At a new hospital	Modern times	Commissioning a new ward named after Dolly Johnson

So, within the relatively narrow confines of Dolly Johnson's story (narrower say than 'the transmission of infectious diseases' or 'the history of Public Health') it is still possible for the teacher to find a range of dramatic contexts in which to actively explore the theme. Sometimes, a teacher may be surprised at finding the 'universal' in the 'particular'. For example, a deeper understanding of public health issues in general, as well as those of Jamaica in the 1840s, may be gained as a result of engaging in some shape or form with Dolly Johnson's personal tragedy.

Identifying the right context or spending time carefully selecting a context pays dividends because it may serve to personalise big issues and so serve to make familiar the unfamiliar.

In summary, in preparing a dramatic context for process drama it is important to remember that all drama is essentially about people and their relationships, concerns, hopes, fears, aspirations, celebrations and rites of passage. So, the teacher whose theme is *well-chosen* will have used this understanding to inform her choice. With this understanding, it is possible, therefore, for that choice to be stimulated by reference to such diverse areas as history, geography, sociological events, current affairs, literature, science, personal relationships, visual and performing arts, political events, the contents of specific school curricula, myths, legends, cultural forms and moral issues.

The spectrum of human experience is the content source for process drama and it is from this that you will make your choice of theme or learning area. This done, you will then make your choice of dramatic context and in doing so, you will be aware that a small and particular set of circumstances holds within it the possibility of exploring the big issue.

‘Where to Now?’

Well, having decided on what the class is going to learn about and the fictional circumstances in which it is to happen, you now need to decide on the people who will inhabit the fiction. In other words, you are now faced with selecting the *roles* that both the students and you will play in the drama. And this choice is the subject of the next chapter.

Chapter

5

Role

KEY QUESTION: ‘Who are the students and the teacher going to be in the drama?’

Let’s begin with the students. We have pointed out that one of the cornerstones of process drama is the innate predisposition of children to take on imagined roles and place themselves in imagined circumstances in order to understand the world in which they live. Indeed, the fundamental activity in any type of drama is taking a role – that is, imagining that you are someone else in a fictional context and exploring a situation through that person’s eyes.

It is obvious, therefore, that when the teacher sets about planning a process drama experience for her class, she needs to understand that she will be setting up a situation in which they will be behaving as if they were people other than themselves. It is also clear that she needs to ensure that the roles she plans for them will ‘match’ with both the learning area and with the dramatic context in which it is to be explored.

The choice of roles for the students might seem a big task. However, it’s not quite as difficult as it sounds. As soon as the teacher has identified the dramatic context in which she wishes to explore the theme or learning area, the roles that are required for the drama will, actually, begin to suggest themselves.

For example, if we look at one of the examples from [Chapter 4](#), The Vikings, there is a very clear relationship between the context and the roles in the drama. The roles, in fact, begin to emerge quite naturally from within and around the dramatic context.

<i>Place</i>	<i>Time period</i>	<i>Event</i>	<i>Roles</i>
Holy Island	Viking times	The Viking landing	<i>Anglo-Saxon monks on Holy Island</i>
Mainland village	Viking times	Preparing to repel the invaders	<i>Anglo-Saxon villagers</i>
Monastery	Mediaeval times	Chronicling Viking invasion	<i>Mediaeval monks</i>
Village	Modern times	Commemorating defence of village	<i>Village community committee</i>
Film studio	Modern times	Making a film about the invasion	<i>Film production company</i>
Archaeological site	Modern times	Excavating site of battle	<i>Archaeologists</i>
Museum	Modern times	Setting up living museum display	<i>Curators</i>

You will find that as soon as you start to think about the context in which the theme can be explored then possible roles for the students will pop up into your mind by association.

The second set of examples from [Chapter 4](#), on Water Conservation, shows a similar pattern of development.

<i>Place</i>	<i>Time period</i>	<i>Event</i>	<i>Roles</i>
Plant nursery	Present day	Finding ways to reduce water costs	<i>Horticulturalists / gardeners</i>
Hospital	Present day	Devising systems for recycling waste water	<i>Hospital staff</i>
Mountain forest	Present day	Preventing lowland flooding created by deforestation	<i>Forest rangers / environmentalists</i>
Desert oasis	Present day	Calculating water needed to get caravan across the desert	<i>Camel drivers and desert traders</i>
Village community	Present day	Designing ways of storing water for use in dry season	<i>Farmers</i>
Life raft after plane crash at sea	Present day	Deciding how to collect potable water to stay alive	<i>Survivors</i>
Polluted river	Present day	Experimentation with natural means to decontaminate water such as water hyacinths	<i>Biotechnologists</i>

In looking at these examples, we hope that you can see that the roles are mainly groups of people associated with the chosen dramatic context. They

are groups that one might reasonably expect to find intimately involved with these particular situations and circumstances.

When identifying roles for your class, this group aspect is important for a number of reasons. The first is that you will want to ensure the full participation in the drama by everyone in the class. In the examples given above, this would be fairly straightforward since we have Anglo-Saxon villagers, film makers, monks, forest rangers and even biotechnologists – all groups large enough to accommodate a class, however large; an important consideration when class sizes can vary so enormously.

These examples present themselves to the planner quite readily, as is most usually the case. There can be occasions, however, when you have to think a little bit more carefully in order to identify an appropriate grouping. This is often the case where the stimulus for the drama is a story or literary text.

Some stories may, indeed, provide lots of opportunities for group roles, *The Pied Piper*, for example. Rat catchers, townsfolk, the children of Hamelin spring immediately to mind and all could provide very satisfactory roles through which the class could engage with the learning. But, in say, *The Three Little Pigs*, the teacher may have to think more widely around the immediate story so that group roles can be identified and the whole class accommodated. It would not be very enabling of the drama nor the learning to have multiple sets of three little pigs. However, if we choose a dramatic context such as one in which the Wolf is put on trial, then we may reasonably invite a group of witnesses from the village community to come forward and give evidence for or against him. In this way we can ensure the participation of the whole class in the same, shared fiction.

While this is clearly an example from the early years, the same principle applies when working with older students. In a process drama approach to *Romeo and Juliet*, for example, members of the class might assume the group role of the Montague Clan speculating on the origins of ‘the ancient grudge’ between themselves and the Capulets. In turn, they might well assume the group role of the Capulets in order to explore the grounds on which they would forbid Juliet ever to marry a Montague.

This identification of a group role, which will embrace all of the participants, is a key task for the teacher planning process drama, not least of all because it helps to focus all of the class on the issues and tasks of the drama. In addition, the group approach assists in achieving consensus as well as in the application of a common point of tension to the drama, both key issues in successful process drama and both of which we will return to in further detail in subsequent chapters.

‘Do you Mean that all the Participants are Expected to Play the Same Kind of Part in the Drama?’

In the sense that they will all be villagers, or monks or Capulets, this may seem true, *on the face of it*. However, within the group identities we have mentioned, there lies enormous scope for individual differences, levels of participation and opinions. This is not only desirable but essential to the success of the process drama.

Let's look at the examples of contexts through which to examine how the Anglo-Saxons responded to the Viking invasion. In each context, the group roles we have identified all have scope for individual difference. If we look closely at the Mediaeval monastery example, we see that the group role is that of monks who are engaged in writing chronicles. This provides the drama with a framework in which all the class can work together. However, there is still scope for a variety of occupations within the overall context of chronicling, for example, scribe, paper maker, quill maker, ink maker, illuminator, librarian, woodcarver, leather worker, weaver, bookbinder and so on. These will enrich the drama and provide opportunity for the action, reaction and interaction we mentioned in [Chapter 1](#), while still maintaining the community perspective and the group focus of the drama, which is the chronicling of the Anglo-Saxon response to the Viking invasions.

‘Could you Go Over this Again, Please?’

Perhaps it would be a good idea at this point to reintroduce our key examples of initial planning for process drama, this time adding the roles we used to begin the dramas.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists

As we discussed in the chapters on Theme and Context (Chapters 3 and 4), this drama set out to examine some of the effects upon indigenous peoples of the exploitation by others of their native plant species. Having settled upon the context of a Ministry of Agriculture expedition to locate and collect specimens of a recently identified plant, the teacher was then faced with the

choice of roles for the children.

In fact, a number of different roles suggested themselves – people of the rainforest, Ministry officials, scientists, doctors, expedition organisers – all of these groups of people could have a legitimate presence within the context of this drama that offers the learners a gateway into the desired learning. However, ultimately, the teacher selected the role of botanists for them.

‘Can you Say why?’

To begin with, botanists form a group that would naturally engage with the substance of the drama, that is to say, with plants and their habitats. Botanists work ‘in the field’ regularly and so it is reasonable to suppose in the fiction of the drama that botanists could go on a plant collecting expedition to the rainforest. Working in a scientific way is also implicit in this role, as is a level of expertise. These are all attributes that have embedded in them the possibility for action and this is important because one way of describing drama is as *ideas in action*. Such action allows the teacher to enable the learners to both explore some of the ways in which drama allows the ideas to be made manifest *and* allows them to engage with the curriculum. In other words, through the actions that are implicit in the roles, the teacher has the means by which to engage the learners in both of the strands of learning we discussed in [Chapter 1](#) – Strand A about drama and Strand B through drama about other things.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students’ roles</i>
Emigration – what makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London

In our second running example, we can see that although the theme and context of this drama were very different from the previous one, the planning challenge faced by the teacher remained the same. That is, she needed to find roles for the students that would bind them together as a group of people. She also needed to ensure that this would be a group who could reasonably be expected to be in the chosen context. This grouping, as inhabitants of London,

is not so tightly defined by occupation as the botanist example. However, this drama did not require it. The nature of the theme and context meant that this drama was not concerned about ‘professional activity’ but about examining an aspect of the human condition. It was, therefore, important for the teacher to choose a group role for the learners that would provide a community in which there was a range of values, perspectives and attitudes but a collective interest in the finding of gold in Australia.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students’ roles</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm preparing to defend a client.	Junior lawyers

As we saw in [Chapter 4](#), this drama already had a strongly theatrical precedent in the treatment given to the events of the famous ‘Scopes Monkey Trial’ in the play, *Inherit the Wind* (as well as its subsequent film versions). So the drama being planned was immediately working with potentially controversial material, and a legal context *suggested by*, but *not* recreating the historical events of the original trial in 1925. However, an enormous range of possibilities still existed for developing roles even within that narrowed context. Because of the real context within which the drama took place, the teacher needed to ensure that the roles selected for the students would provide a framework in which the issue could be addressed in a cool and balanced manner. Therefore, the decision to cast the students in the roles of lawyers, with the attendant demands of that profession to consider *evidence* rather than being swayed by a tide of emotion, was made by the teacher. Further, a defence rather than a prosecution brief was considered more desirable socially, as well as being more conducive to the gathering and careful weighing of supporting evidence. The junior position in the law firm served to bind the participants together because they could be reasonably expected to do most of the leg-work in evidence-gathering, an important consideration for

this task-based drama.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia –for an HIV why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring positive sibling.	Mark and his brother Thomas Musonda as collective roles

Because the major focus of this drama involves the personal experience of the two brothers, and in particular that of 12-year-old Thomas Mosunda who is given the enormous responsibility of caring for his younger sibling, a way had to be found to allow the students to enter intimately into that experience. They needed to be given the opportunity to invest something of themselves in the protagonists of the drama and not remain emotionally detached from it.

Having spoken earlier about how group roles focus the class on the issues and tasks of the drama, as is clearly illustrated in the previous key examples, here we have an example of a drama in which a large group of students is given the opportunity of playing one role collectively. This does not mean that we have forty different Marks or Thomases emerging, but that individual students of either gender are encouraged and enabled to contribute to and build a composite role, which serves both the drama and the learning. Using a technique reminiscent of forum theatre, in which individuals can step into a situation to alter the course of the drama, here the common interest of the students is focused on contributing to the building of these composite roles. In so doing they also build a collective concern about the dramatic dilemma that faces them and are motivated to work towards developing a range of possible outcomes for the drama.

Other possible group roles, such as neighbours or members of Mark and Thomas's extended family, would not as readily facilitate the opportunity for the more empathic encounter provided by experiencing the brothers as collective roles. So it was that in this drama these collective roles functioned in such a way as to bind the participants together in a similar way to that of a group role.

‘What do you Mean by Binding?’

In process drama, we all need to be ‘in the same boat’, so to speak, yet must hold a very individual perspective on our common situation. So, selecting roles for the participants that bind them together from the outset of the drama is *critical*.

The roles the learners assume in the drama may immediately bind them together in different ways. For example:

- *by kinship* – family members, members of a tribe, descendants of common ancestors
- *by occupation or skill* – printers, shoemakers, needle workers, vets, sail makers, pharmacologists
- *by belief or ideology* – monks, nuns, vegetarians, politicians, pilgrims to Mecca, Rome or the Ganges
- *by knowledge* – guides, language translators, navigators, stockbrokers, alchemists
- *by induction* – baptismal candidates, deputies, awardees, members of a Hall of Fame, members of a secret society
- *by age* – teenagers, pensioners, centenarians, juvenile offenders
- *by qualification* – graduates, driving instructors, licensed food handlers, first aiders, paramedics
- *by uniform* – soldiers, nurses, police officers, traffic wardens, astronauts, Salvation Army
- *by need* – homeless people, orphans, alcoholics, famine victims
- *by location* – air passengers, prisoners, hospital patients, palace guards, villagers
- *by common experiences* – mothers, widows, home owners, war veterans, refugees
- *by interest and hobby* – collectors, train spotters, dog fanciers, golfers, flower arrangers.

So, if we look again at our four key examples, we can see that in the Rainforest drama, the learners were in the role of botanists, bound together by *skill* and *knowledge*; in the Gold Strike drama, they were in the role of Londoners, bound together by *location*; and in the Creation/Evolution drama they were bound together by *qualification* and *occupation*; and in the HIV/AIDS drama they were bound together by *kinship* and *need*.

Of course, the above list is by no means exhaustive and many other elements can bind people together. Indeed, it may be possible to classify a role under several headings. For example, soldiers might be bound together simultaneously by occupation, ideology, uniform, location and common

experience. The main point, here, is that looking at ways in which people are bound together like this can help you as a teacher identify roles that quickly bring a sense of cohesiveness to the drama. However, the selection the teacher ultimately makes will always need to be the one that best serves the learning area within the chosen dramatic context.

‘But Won’t the Group Role Restrict the Chance for the Students to Express Themselves, Individually?’

Of course, as we said in the opening chapter, drama is a powerful means of enabling personal expression. However, this needs to be fostered within a framework that is disciplined and structured but not strictured. It is also essential to remember that drama is a *collective, social* art form that is created by participants working collaboratively. Random self-expression, therefore, by a class-sized group of individuals will rarely facilitate the development of the drama.

Not unreasonably, then, drama in schools frequently had a bad press in the days when the main justification for pursuing it as an educational activity was that it would foster self-expression in the child. Mass self-expression all over the school hall was often perceived as chaos – and often this was the correct perception. Fortunately, thinking and understanding about how and what makes drama so effective as a learning medium has moved on as the discipline has grown and developed.

Having to focus the class on the task at hand regardless of the subject or discipline area, be it science, history, literature or whatever, is part of basic classroom management whatever approach (whole-class, small group or individual seat work) is being taken. So, what the drama teacher is attempting to ensure in planning for process drama is that in order to negotiate her way through a potential minefield of individual attitudes, opinions and emotional responses to the situation under scrutiny she first of all establishes a group focus on the theme through a group identity within the fiction.

There are, of course, other types of drama that are part of the drama within education canon, which *do* encourage and, indeed, demand individual work – when examining monologue, for example, or working on the development of non-verbal means of expression. However, these *usually* fall outside the parameters of process drama in which it is the cohesiveness of the group as it moves through the experience of the drama together, albeit with shades of response, which is essential.

‘Is it Possible for the Students to be Themselves in a

Drama?’

This can *appear* to happen from time to time in process drama, though, most often, it would be misleading to say that the students are being themselves. They must undergo some change in behaviour once they accept the fictional context of the drama. Since in process drama the participants’ engagement with the role is not so much deepened by characterisation as by attitude, it is often the attributes they bring to the drama that are of uppermost concern.

Often, when the role is not clearly defined in a *situated* identity (i.e. occupation, social position), the students may simply be ‘good at finding things out’ or ‘good at helping’. A good example of this was a one-session drama with a class of 9- to 10-year-olds, exploring the theme of latitude and longitude. The children appeared to be themselves in the first part of the drama, enjoying themselves at the beach, playing with a ball. However, the teacher and class had agreed beforehand that there would be, hidden in a tree trunk, an old piece of paper containing the clue to some buried treasure. This clue contained the latitude and longitude coordinates but only the teacher knew this.

The main test for the children in the drama was how far they could build the tension by *not* finding the paper. The point of this was to get everybody focused on the clue, indeed, playing with dramatic irony, so that the longer they took in not finding it, the more its presence in the room grew and the more important it would be when it was eventually ‘discovered’. The pleasure the children had in keeping themselves and the teacher in suspense was enormous, too. The point we are making here is that, although to an outside glance, this looked as though the children were merely themselves, in actuality, by virtue of the suspension of their disbelief they had entered a fiction and were *in role* as themselves.

Let’s take another example. One memorable session on Power and Authority was conducted with a class of 18-year-olds and 20 visiting (real) soldiers. In the drama, the students took on the situated roles of police officers and other uniformed personnel, while, dressed in fatigues, the soldiers played themselves by acting out how different their own behaviour might be when they were out of uniform – in other words, soldiers in uniform, in role as themselves out of uniform. The point of this was that the soldiers felt the military uniform affected their own bearing and deportment as well as other people’s perception of them. They noticed how people, particularly uniformed police officers, adjusted their behaviour towards them according to whether the soldiers were in or out of uniform.

Sometimes in a drama, the situated identity of the role is not anything like

as clear as monk, Anglo-Saxon villager or biotechnologist. In a drama about a lost child, a class of 8-year-olds simply became people who had offered to go out and look for him but, once into the drama, they very quickly began to assume *adult* attitudes and responsibilities and create for themselves previous ‘experience’ on which to draw during the search.

Almost always in their own dramatic playing, children take on adult roles. This is very readily understood. Children are extremely perceptive and early in life recognise that the power to control and change the status quo lies firmly in the hands of adults. Having recognised this, they assume adult roles in their dramatic playing in order to understand and empower themselves. As teachers, therefore, it should come as no surprise to us that, when we come to create process drama with children in school, they will naturally assume adults’ roles in the drama. In our earlier examples from [Chapter 4](#), on the Vikings, unless the teacher specifically makes it otherwise, then the drama will *not* be about Anglo-Saxon village *children* or *child* novices at the monastery because children will, almost certainly, naturally assume that the drama is about adults.

This understanding is very important for the teacher when planning process drama. Recognising that students readily take on adult roles will impact on her choice of roles and, indeed, dramatic context.

However, one of the differences between process drama and other types of drama in educational contexts lies in the nature of the teacher’s active involvement with the unfolding drama. In process drama, the teacher frequently needs to take a role in the drama *herself*. This is known as teacher-in-role or TIR for short, and in this aspect of planning, you also have to plan your role in the drama as well as the students’.

‘Could you Explain more about Teacher-In-Role?’

One of the cornerstones of process drama, mentioned earlier, is a recognition that learners who gain a sense of ownership about their learning by having the opportunity to help shape its direction have a greater commitment to it and gain more from it as a result.

In a sense, this implies that there needs to be a more even-handed partnership between the teacher and the students than is sometimes the case in the classroom. As we pointed out a moment ago, children are very astute in understanding social power structures and this is one of the reasons they take on adult roles in their own dramatic playing, as a means of empowering themselves. This is another part of the foundation upon which process drama rests and we actively build upon this to help construct the drama.

However, this understanding that children have about ‘how things work’

can also work against them becoming involved in shaping the drama and, therefore, developing their sense of ownership about it, unless we are careful in our planning. As teachers, how many times have we all felt that the learners we are working with are giving us the answers that they think we want, *because* we are the teachers and they are in the more subordinate position of learners?

Clearly there are times when this situation is both necessary and desirable. But, there are times when it will not do, and one of those times is when we are wanting to work in process drama.

We are certainly *not* encouraging any abrogation of responsibility on the part of the teacher. Teachers will always carry the ultimate responsibility for what goes on in their classrooms. However, within the process drama framework that we are setting out in this book, which is absolutely predicated upon teachers making informed, professional decisions about learning within a curriculum structure, we are suggesting that the usual relationship between teacher and students needs to be set to one side, *at times*, as one means by which the learners can gain a sense of ownership about what they are doing.

One of the most effective ways of managing this power shift, within the context of the drama, is through teacher-in-role.

‘But I Can’t do that, I’m not a Good Actor!’

This is an understandable reaction but there are two things to bear in mind that will make the prospect of teacher-in-role less daunting than it seems. First, teacher-in-role is much less about acting in the external theatrical sense of putting on a costume and finding a voice and set of mannerisms for a character and much more about enabling students to enter the drama. Second, if we think about it for a moment, we will recognise that teaching can be a performance art in itself, anyway. We give performances in our classrooms, daily. As soon as we stand in front of the class we are, in effect, ‘commanding our stage’; by the way we modify the way we speak, our facial expressions and body language, we ‘deliver our dialogue’; when we respond to the behaviour of the class we are teaching we may give the response that the ‘script’ demands, which may not be the response we would otherwise give – how many times have we all wanted to laugh but have felt the need to be stern? – we often withhold what we know, in order to create an effect. Under these circumstances we are playing the part of a teacher – we are acting the role.

For example, a teacher, observed in a class of rising 5-year-olds in Jamaica, was teaching a mathematics lesson – her learning focus being the numeral ‘4’. After proceeding through a whole range of traditional reinforcement activities

including songs (4 green bottles, 4 men went to mow), I-spy games (4 fruits, 4 animals, etc.) and actions (draw a number 4 with your finger – one stroke down, one stroke across, another stroke down) she suddenly did something quite different. She turned to the chalkboard and then, turning slowly around to the children with a terribly worried expression on her face, she said, anxiously, ‘Oh, dear! I’ve forgotten how to make a 4!’ The children needed no further prompting since they understood immediately from her expression that the teacher was inviting them to ‘play’ and was inviting a response, which they duly gave – that is they explained to her the method of making a ‘4’ that she had just taught them (one stroke down, one stroke across, another stroke down). The teacher then proceeded to make life very difficult for her young charges by assuming the role of a most inept student. However carefully the children instructed her, she managed somehow (trying to make the 4 on the chalkboard) to get it all wrong. She pushed the children to the absolute limit of their patience before she finally managed to get it right. A young student teacher, who had been observing this class was heard to remark, ‘She’s in role’ which, of course, the teacher was. She was clearly demonstrating a type of behaviour totally at odds with her accepted teacher persona and well outside the normal expectation of her young students. This teacher was very deliberately teaching from a position of ignorance. She was clearly portraying herself as a total incompetent, displaying a type of behaviour that effectively shifted the power structure within the classroom. The teacher had voluntarily yielded her power to the children so that they could become ‘the teachers’ and she ‘the taught’. So, it was not only her role that had shifted. By taking on the role of the incompetent she had, by inference, negotiated new roles for the children (i.e. teachers) that they were more than happy to accept.

This is an example of a teacher confidently stepping into a role and deliberately denying her own knowledge in order to empower the children with knowledge and allow them to have ‘the upper hand’ in the learning situation. We are sure that you will be able to recall numerous situations in which you have employed a similar teaching strategy.

You will recognise that there was never any indication that, because the teacher had abrogated her power, she would lose control of the class. The children clearly understood the nature of the ‘playing’ structure at work in this instance and were happy to ‘play by the rules’ and to relinquish their new-found power in order for the next phase of the lesson to be introduced. What lingered in the classroom after this encounter was a sense of ‘colleagueness’. It is not a sense of the teacher imposing her curriculum on the children so much as the development of a partnership between teacher and students as they move through an experience of mutual discovery. The children never lost

sight of the fact that they were operating within a fictional context and the teacher never lost control of her class.

If you have ever created a similar type of situation in your classroom, and we are certain that you will have done, then you are ready to take what is really a small step into teacher-in-role within a process drama.

Here is an example in which a deliberate process drama was created. In the real context of a nursery class of 3- and 4-year-olds in London, the children who stayed all day took a nap after lunch. It was the practice of the school for the children to remove their outer clothing before going to sleep. Unfortunately, this particular group of children were not very competent at dressing themselves again afterwards and staff found themselves spending an inordinately long time in helping children to put their clothes on. So the teacher decided to find a means to help the children to become more adept in this skill.

She told her class that she had a 'friend', Sue, who was having some difficulty. The friend hoped that, as she had heard from their teacher that they were particularly kind and helpful children, they might try to help her sort out her problem. The children readily agreed to meet the 'Sue' – the teacher-in-role.

The teacher slipped around the corner and returned in a sorry state. She was very upset and hesitant about approaching the children. The children were bemused by 'Sue's' appearance and started to giggle. The teacher-in-role was then able to point out that this was the very problem that she had. She told them that ever since she had left home that morning, people had been laughing at her and she didn't know why. She thought this was very rude and unkind and couldn't think what she could possibly have done to make people behave in that way.

In fact, the teacher had dressed herself in a completely higgledy-piggledy fashion. She had gloves on her feet, shoes on her hands, her cardigan on back to front and a handbag slung around her neck. No wonder the children laughed.

However, as the sincerity of her role came across, the children's attitude rapidly changed and they became very caring of her. Very gently one little girl took the teacher's hand, patted it and told 'Sue' that she had got her clothes on wrongly and that this was why people had been laughing at her. 'Sue' asked how this could be rectified and of course the children responded that she should dress herself properly. Now came 'Sue's' confession that she didn't know how to and the tentative request that the children explain what to do.

The interchange that then followed, rather like the example of the number 4, saw the teacher-in-role make things difficult. The children became more

and more exasperated as 'Sue' failed again and again to do her buttons up, but at the same time, ever more precise in their instructions until, at last, 'Sue' was ready to face the world properly turned out. With this accomplished, 'Sue' said a huge thank you to the class and, with a parting request for them to say hello to her friend, their teacher, she slipped round the corner again.

The teacher then returned to her class in her own clothes, no longer in role to be greeted with a chorus of 'Your friend, Sue, was here and she said to say hello! She had all her clothes on back to front and we helped her to get dressed properly. She was upset by people laughing but we made it all right'.

There are two important points here. First, the children behaved in a completely responsible fashion during the meeting with 'Sue', were focused on the problem and did not run rampage though the teacher had apparently relinquished her authority. Second, even though the children knew perfectly well that 'Sue' was their teacher pretending to be someone else, their ready suspension of disbelief and their obvious innate understanding of how drama works meant that when the teacher returned the children were bursting to tell her all about the meeting with 'Sue' and what they had done to help her and to absolutely slip back into the usual teacher-student relationship when this drama was over.

The point we are making here is that if you take on a role in a process drama and by doing so 'stop being teacher' for a while, this does not mean that you will not be able to regain your previous relationship with your class. Remember that children are used to coming in and out of role all the time in their dramatic playing. They recognise that, when one of them takes on the role of 'king' and gives orders that the rest willingly carry out during a pretend game, after it is over the relationship between the 'king' and his 'subjects' reverts to the normal, peer friendship. Similarly, they will recognise that when their teacher comes out of role, the normal classroom relationships apply once more, just as was the case when 'Sue' had left the nursery.

'So is Teacher-In-Role only for Use with Young Children?'

No. We do not see the use of TIR as being restricted to use with young children. We have just used these very simple examples from the early years as a way of indicating the roots of the strategy in normal teaching behaviour.

This next example is of another one-lesson drama, this time with a class of 16-year-olds. The teacher is consciously using a TIR approach but in a situation where both students and teacher still play roles very close to their own, situated identities in the school so the fictional circumstances of the drama are not too far removed from the school experience familiar to both of them.

The teacher introduced the session by explaining to the students that she was going to use a TIR approach. They agreed that when the teacher moved from behind the desk she would emerge in role. She had not indicated what her role would be but she carried in her hand a letter and almost immediately began to negotiate her fictional role, that of principal or head teacher. This fact was laid in through what she said to the students and, of course, she also had to make sure that they clearly understood who they were in the drama, too. 'Good morning, student council members!' she said. 'Is this the full number of people on the student council?' 'Nobody is missing?' So, immediately the participants knew who they were in the drama; no longer themselves but were members of a student council. The teacher continued by apologising for the short notice of the meeting, commended everyone for attending before revealing her own role in the drama. 'As principal of this school, I have always tried ...'. So now they knew who she was and, of course, the letter was important to the drama because it, purportedly, contained an expression of concern from the student council about the rate of teenage pregnancy in the school and a request for the installation of a condom vending machine in the senior school toilets. When asked whether anyone knew about this letter, it was hardly surprising that no one among the participants responded. However, when further pressed, one or two entered into the drama by acknowledging their part in sending the letter and began openly to voice their concern. Very quickly more of them became more willing to enter the action more fully and began to consider the pros and cons of the condom vending machine as a solution to the problem.

At all times, the contribution of the 'principal' was slow, measured, considered, authoritative (not authoritarian) as various opinions were aired. After a very lively discussion, the teacher signalled that she was coming out of her role as principal and informed the class that the drama would now move on. Re-entering her role in the drama as principal, she then refocused the roles of the class so that they very quickly understood that they were now parents at a PTA meeting. When the contents of the letter from the student council were revealed to the students in role as parents, it was like a bombshell. Many of them expressed vehement opposition to the proposed vending machine. The final result was that, after a long period of deliberation, the students, in role as parents, embarked upon the introduction of a mentoring programme and the development of a timetable of structured extra-curricular activities, as well as additional intervention strategies for needy students of the fictitious school.

We have chosen these three examples because they are very simple and help to illustrate how the shift from the real context into a fictional one can be

achieved by only a small shift in the context and the behaviour of the teacher.

‘In the Examples you’ve Given, The Teacher Still has the Power, Doesn’t She?’

When planning TIR, the teacher has to remind herself what the ‘accepted’ power structure in classrooms already is. Implicitly, the teacher is endowed with the power. Her status, relative to that of the students, is high and can be perceived as a barrier to the realisation of the more open, creative learning relationship between students and teacher that is needed in a process drama. At its worst this implicit relationship produces authoritarian teachers, resentful students, and sometimes open and direct confrontation between the two. Yet shifting the power structure in classrooms is something that can, and frequently does, happen naturally and almost subconsciously.

‘Isn’t this a Bit Manipulative?’

Well, smoothly effecting shifts in the relative status of the participants in process drama is critical. The implicit power structure of the classroom we referred to above, with the teacher’s status high relative to that of the students, will be open to change within the fictional circumstances of the drama. One power structure belongs to the real life context of the classroom while the dramatic context clearly opens up an opportunity for a renegotiation of the participants’ relative status. A teacher-in-role need not always take up an authority position within the drama. This was clearly illustrated in our example with the teacher and the numeral 4. She appeared to give up all her power when she admitted, in role, that she couldn’t remember how to make a ‘4’. But the teacher’s status within the drama has more to do with ‘voice’ than social position. For example, if the teacher was to take on the role of a king we might be forgiven for assuming that she had taken on a highstatus role in order to provide some modicum of insurance for her real life role of teacher. However, although a king may be quite obviously of high social standing he can still be in low status relative to those around him if he is uncertain, needs advice or has a terrible problem or dilemma facing him. Alan Bennett’s highly successful play, *The Madness of George III*, clearly plays with just such a situation so that the main action hinges on the vulnerability of the monarch relative to those around him. On the other hand, a tramp or other personage of low social standing may assume high status if his manners are impeccable relative to those around him and if he demands high standards of etiquette and good manners in others.

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‘Why is an Understanding of Role Status so Important for the Teacher?’

In earlier chapters we noted that learners who have a sense of ownership about their learning have a greater sense of commitment to it and gain more from it as a result. The task of all teachers, surely, is to maximise the possibilities for students to learn. If we accept this, then process drama, particularly with teacher-in-role as a central strategy, is a powerful means by which teachers can enable this to happen. Because the usual hierarchy of the classroom is set to one side within process drama, the way is open for the learners to make a contribution to the shape and direction of their own learning. The teacher sidesteps her usual position of ultimate authority, final arbiter of situations and fountainhead of knowledge – especially when she chooses a role that is more vulnerable – so that the learners are confronted with the decision-making, researching, problem-solving and team working necessary to resolve the central dilemma of the drama.

Having established this background from which process drama, with teacher-in-role, springs so readily, we now need to return to our four key examples to see how the teachers in these situations introduced TIR into their planning and to consider the reasons that led them to the choices they made.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists	Civil servant from the Ministry

Reasons for Choice of Teacher's Role

So, the teacher had decided on the role of botanists for the children. Having done this, a range of possible roles for herself in the drama had to be considered. She could, for example, have taken on the role of fellow botanist, Chief Scientist, Minister of Agriculture, one of the indigenous people of the rainforest or civil servant from the Ministry of Agriculture. All of these roles could have enabled her to enter the drama. However, any choice in planning process drama has consequences for the drama that the teacher will need to bear in mind. In this instance, the teacher needed to think through the effect each of these possible roles might have on how the drama might unfold and

select the one that would most suit the needs of the children and the needs of the drama. Each one carried a particular body of knowledge, level of expertise, authority and responsibility. The task for the teacher was, again, one of balance. She needed to select the role that would most adeptly facilitate the children's learning by most adeptly facilitating the drama. The advantages offered by the civil servant role were several. First, by becoming an administrative assistant to the absent Department Head, she put herself into the position of being able to mediate between the 'botanists' and the 'boss'. By declining to take on the role of the boss, she maintained a level of authority by virtue of being his right-hand person but relinquished ultimate authority because she was not him. From this position, she was able to throw the children back on their own resources, decision-making processes and such because she did not have the ultimate say and, furthermore, the person who could have had it was absent. This choice of role had further advantages. By becoming an *administrator* rather than another botanist, she ensured that she did not have the expertise, within the fiction of the drama, to which the children could defer. In fact, she created the reverse situation by the choice, so that she, from her position of ignorance, could probe, challenge, enquire, speculate, query and support the children in their role as the experts and, therefore, in their learning by empowering them, and, *in some respects*, disempowering herself.

Let's look at Key Example 2, where the teacher did something similar but through an apparently much less flexible choice of role.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London	Ship's captain

Reasons for Choice of Teacher's Role

In this example, we can see that there was a greater 'distance' between the roles of the students and the role that the teacher had selected for herself. In the first example, in which the roles were bound by skill and knowledge, the teacher, although not in role as a botanist herself, chose a role that was

attenuated to the same field by virtue of the tasks incumbent upon a civil servant in the Ministry of Agriculture given responsibility for facilitating the expedition. However, here, in Key Example 2, the students are in role as inhabitants of London, bound together by location, but the teacher's role represents the possibility of *going somewhere else*. Although she could have taken on many others' roles in the drama – fellow Londoner, returnee from Australia, public official, the Beadle for example, map maker – the choice of ship's captain provided her with the best opportunity to give information in role about the gold strike in Australia – by virtue of 'having just returned' *and* the means within the drama, the ship, for the Londoners to go to Australia to seek their fortunes. She mitigated against the authority of her role, as the drama unfolded, by revealing that she needed the Londoners to help crew the vessel in order that she, and they, could sail for Australia.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers	Head of Law Chambers

Reasons for the Choice of Teacher's Role

Having made the decision to place students in the roles of 'lawyers' because of the need to gather evidence, it might seem rather obvious that an authority role like 'Head of Law Chambers' should have been chosen by the teacher in order for her to enter the drama. Yet several others were available to her but were eventually discarded, including defendant, office cleaner, fellow lawyer, newspaper reporter or presiding judge, for example.

Head of Law Chambers might, then, not be quite such an obvious choice, particularly if, as we have been implying, the teacher was supposed to be trying to give up some of her power. However, roles of authority figures like 'the boss' do not always have to be what they seem. In this particular instance the interests of the Head of the Law Chambers were clearly aligned with those of her staff. What was clearly binding them together was the common ground of their profession. The Head of Chambers' strength may well have resided in her ability to 'lead' the defence of a client, but she remained, nonetheless, heavily dependent upon her colleagues' ability to furnish her with a body of

evidence without which she would be unable to argue the case in court.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia –why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.	Mark and his brother Thomas Musonda as collective roles	Shadowy role as narrator or community member

Reasons for Choice of Teacher's Role

Because the participants in this drama were engaged with building the roles of Mark and his older brother Thomas collectively, the role of the teacher tended to be somewhat shadowy. Rather than taking a fixed, consistent role in the drama, the role held by the teacher tended to shift subtly as needed from narrator, questioner and facilitator to full participant and direct contributor alongside the students to the building of the collective role. Since the participating students were largely coming to process drama for the first time, the teacher also introduced strategies like hot-seating and thought-tracking by taking a role and demonstrating their use in practice. The nature of this particular drama also called for frequent shifts and adjustments in strategies including the time frames used, which had to be initiated by the teacher as facilitator.

We hope that we have made clear here that teacher-in-role is fundamental to process drama and not simply a strategy in the sense of being one among many theatre forms available to the teacher. For us, *TIR enables the teacher to operate strategically from within the drama and so negotiate and renegotiate circumstances within the fiction in order to enhance the drama and by doing so the learning opportunities.*

Once the teacher has identified the theme, the particular dramatic circumstances in which it will be explored, and who she and the students are going to be in the drama, she is still faced with the enormous question – what are we actually going to do in the drama? There has to be some element present that galvanises us into action. The prerequisite for this call to

meaningful action we call *frame* and that is the subject of our next chapter.

Frame

KEY QUESTION: ‘How will the roles be framed? That is, which viewpoint will the roles have in order to create tension in the drama and how distanced do the roles need to be?’

Let’s begin this chapter by returning for a moment to the key examples we have been carrying through since [Chapter 3](#). So far, for each of them, we have identified theme, context, students’ roles and teacher’s role, as follows:

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students’ roles</i>	<i>Teacher’s role</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people hold different views.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists	Civil servant from the Ministry

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London	Ship's captain

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers	Head of Law Chambers

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Teacher's role</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia –why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.	Mark and his brother Thomas Musonda as collective roles	Shadowy role as narrator or community member

For each one of these examples, we know the theme – that is, what it is we want the students to learn about; we know the context – that is, the particular fictional circumstances in which the drama will unfold; and we know the roles – that is, who the students and teacher will pretend to be in the drama. But, in each of these examples the critical element is missing; that is, the *imperative for active participation*. We don't yet know what it is that will drive the participants to action in the drama. What is missing is *dramatic tension*.

‘Why is Dramatic Tension so Important?’

We pointed out early in this book that in process drama the participants – the

class and teacher together – ‘write’ a play as the narrative of the drama unfolds in time and space and through action, reaction and interaction. We need to realise, therefore, that the elements of theatre that work in *all* well-crafted plays also need to be invoked in process drama. One of those crucial elements is dramatic tension.

Dramatic tension is the fuel that fires the imperative for action in a play. It is created by the friction that exists at the interface between the differing, and sometimes rival, values, beliefs and aspirations of characters. As the drama unfolds, the reactions and responses of the characters are motivated by their own, often competing, attitudes to the turn of events and the behaviour of others.

The key factor that impacts upon the creation of dramatic tension in a process drama is that there is no predetermined, written script into which the playwright will have already woven the motivations for characters’ responses and actions.

During the rehearsals for the staging of a play, actors will frequently ask, ‘What’s my motivation?’ and seek the answer from the subtext of the playscript so that their performances will be informed by an understanding of what makes their characters ‘tick’. In process drama participants need to understand this, too, but cannot draw the answer from a script. This is, actually, critical. Just giving students a role in a process drama is quite sterile, both in terms of learning about and through drama, without the imperative for active participation that is provided when the inclusion of dramatic tension throws the circumstances and the events of the drama and the relationships between the roles into sharp relief.

Therefore, the teacher needs to provide it for them by other means and the means to the creation of dramatic tension in process drama is called ‘frame’.

‘Why Call it Frame?’

Frame is a concept refined by the eminent Canadian sociologist, Erving Goffman, whose work in *Frame Analysis* (1986) was adapted and applied by Dorothy Heathcote to process drama. Goffman uses ‘frame’ to refer, essentially, to the *viewpoint* individuals will have about their circumstances, which helps them to *make sense* of an event or situation, and to assess its likely impact upon themselves as individuals. Translated into terms of process drama, we could say that Goffman’s frame constitutes a means of laying in the dramatic tension by situating the participants in relation to the unfolding action.

‘This Seems a Bit Complicated’

Well, yes, it is rather, but we consider that ‘frame’ is the most important process drama planning principle of all. Getting this one right really does go a long way to ensuring that the drama you create with your students will be of high quality and, therefore, offer the greatest learning opportunity. So, it’s worth spending some time teasing out the key issues surrounding the concept of frame. It might seem a bit complex at first but by the end of this chapter we are confident that you will have the knowledge and understanding to ensure that the roles in your drama are well framed.

‘Why is it so Important for the Roles to be Framed?’

Well, we can say that in real life, whenever we come upon a set of circumstances we do not come to them neutrally. We see them from our own particular *point of view* – a window that has been shaped by our previous life experiences. While these points of view are unique to ourselves in their minute detail, nonetheless groups of people who have experiences or interests in common often have similar viewpoints. For example, when there is an occurrence within the world of education, those of us who are teachers will see it from a particular viewpoint that is different from those who are not teachers. While this does not imply that we will all have the *same opinion* about it, it does mean that we will share a *collective concern* by reason of what binds us together as a profession and the effects that a likely outcome of that occurrence will have on us.

In planning process drama, we need to ensure that we lay in for the participants a collective concern for how the events of the drama will unfold, because it is in these events, and the roles’ responses to them, that the learning is located. In the [Chapter 4](#) discussion of students’ roles, we argued for the need to find ways of binding groups together. This, in fact, is the first step on the way to creating the collective concern. So, in our key examples, the botanists, the Londoners, the lawyers and the siblings are already connected to the learning area by reason of their common interest; that is by who and what they are.

However, there is a further step to take. We should not allow ourselves to think that just because we have laid in the common interest we have also provided dramatic tension. At this point, we have only succeeded in preparing a state in which the *possibility* for dramatic tension to be created lies. We now need to find a mechanism through which we can shift the position of the roles from one of merely a common interest, born out of a group identity, into the desired *collective concern*. This shift is achieved by the addition of *investment*. On the surface, common interest and collective concern may seem to be interchangeable terms, but they’re not. In providing a ‘real’ need to

engage ever more deeply with the events of the drama (and therefore the learning) we ensure that the roles *care* about what has happened, is happening and might happen and are motivated into action. This, now, provides the collective concern. And with the collective concern comes dramatic tension because while collective concern endows all the participants with an investment in the outcome of the drama, they will *not* all necessarily want the *same* outcome.

If we return to what we were saying earlier about dramatic tension being born from the friction between differing and often opposing attitudes, values and aspirations of characters in a play, then we can see that this friction is precisely what the frame provides. However, frame can actually do this in three ways.

- First, through the differences in opinion between the students' roles – 'I think we should negotiate with the strangers', 'No, I think we should run', 'I think there may be something in this for me'.
- Second, through the differences between the students' roles and the teacher-in-role – 'You'll all have to work overtime and for less money', 'But my family can't survive on what you pay now'.
- Third, through the differences between the collective view of the students and the teacher-in-role, together, and an absent antagonist – 'What are we going to do to get past the monster?'

In whichever of these ways the teacher plans to use frame to invoke dramatic tension, it will lead to greater focus and commitment to resolving the 'dilemma' of the drama and, consequently, a greater potential for learning. This is because frame enables, further, the contextualisation of learning and promotes the students' opportunity to take ownership of their learning and help shape its direction.

'How does Frame Help this Student Ownership of Learning to Come About?'

Well, we would argue that drama, as much of life, is concerned with the exploration of what binds people together; the inborn instinct to relate to others in both positive and negative ways so that these bindings become the seeds of *talk and action*. Moreover, they become the seeds of the *type* of talk and action demanded by the drama – botanists' talk, travellers' talk, lawyers' talk, a sibling's talk and what it is they are actually doing – gathering evidence, collecting plant species, travelling across the world to make their fortunes or grappling with the stigma attached to a health condition.

If we accept that drama is essentially an art form that has talk as its

currency, then it is clear that we must ensure that this collective concern is *present in the drama* at the outset. The importance of this is that it propels the participants into discourse – *it will mean they have something to say* because they have a ‘handle’ on the situation.

Of course, people communicate not only by the words they choose but also by the non-verbal signals of body language that combine with the words to make the meaning plain.

Moreover, there are times in most types of theatre when non-verbal means of expression are fore-fronted – mime and dance spring obviously to mind. In addition, we do not wish to imply that the verbal nature of drama means that the characters in a play all converse happily together. Indeed, there are times when characters in plays clearly do not do so, just as in life. Often, drama is as much about the conflict of people not communicating with each other as it is about the reverse. Nonetheless, ultimately, we do wish the students in process drama to use the spoken language to negotiate the meaning of their unfolding play and, through it, the learning inherent within the drama.

Through our own practice we have come to the conclusion that the quality of the process drama experience and, therefore, the quality of the learning it generates, most importantly rests upon the teacher’s ability to provide the most appropriate role *and* frame for the learners. In effect, frame is the means to the creation of dramatic tension and, as we hope we are making clear, in order to get good learning you need good drama and to get good drama you need good dramatic tension!

In genres of theatre that require performers to take on roles within a play with a pre-written text, it is quite clear that those characters have no previous life experience that will shape their viewpoint on the events of the play. Until the actors lift the text from the page and bring the characters to life they have only ever been a series of words on paper. However, if the playwright has done the job well, the subtext of the play and the in-built dramatic tension will give the actor his role’s point of view. This will mean he will know what motivates the role and will enable him to approach the unfolding events within the play with an attitude that will drive his performance.

In process drama, too, the roles that the students will take on quite clearly do not have previous life experience. They are, actually, in an even less developed state than roles in a play text because process drama does not have a predetermined written script. Coupled with this is the fact that the people who are going to create the roles – the students – have, themselves, a more limited range of life experiences on which to draw.

‘So How can the Students Proceed?’

problem of the lost horses. They will enter the drama, not with the experience of enslavement but they *will* have an understanding of secrecy. Nor will they have archaeological experience but *will* have great understanding of the constraints of time.

If we return to our key examples, in Key Example 1 we can see that the teacher's planning ensured that the roles of the students were not just botanists but they were botanists *who had to keep their expedition secret*.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Civil servant from the Ministry	. . . must keep their expedition to the rainforest secret.

In Key Example 2, the students were not merely people living in London in the early 1850s but were people living in London *who were discontent with their lives*.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Ship's captain	. . . are discontent with their lives in London.

In Key Example 3, the students were not just in role as junior lawyers but as junior lawyers *who needed to meet a deadline for gathering and presenting evidence*.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Head of Law Chambers	. . . need to meet a deadline to present evidence for the official hearing.

In Key Example 4, the students were not just in role as baby Mark's older brother Thomas Musonda but as an older brother *who had to decide whether to leave his brother at an orphanage*.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.	Mark's brother Thomas Musonda as a collective role who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Shadowy role as narrator or community member	. . . has to decide whether to leave his baby brother at an orphanage.

From this, we hope that it is clear that in each of the key examples, the students had a point of view – an attitude about the situation – and were sufficiently empowered to enter into dialogue in role.

‘Is there Anything Else I Need to Know about Frame?’

Well, in the second part of the key question at the beginning of this chapter, we also mentioned the need for roles to be *distanced*. This equally important function of frame, working in tandem with the communication/tension function, protects participants into the experience of the drama through ‘*distancing*’. This really is an important issue, so let's spend some time examining it.

If we accept that it is the teacher's intention to take learners into new areas of experience, often these will be so far removed from their everyday lives or so sensitive that they will need to be approached with care. We have mentioned already the importance of selecting a communication frame that

will still allow the students to have one foot on the firm ground of their own experience but we must also consider the *distance* function of frame as a means of protecting the participants into the drama experience. Often, in practice, this means that it is better to approach the core of the drama from a tangent, rather than diving into the middle of something in a way that leads the students, because they have not been given the circumstances under which to do anything else, to engage at a superficial or disruptive level, resulting in the quality of the drama and therefore the learning being undermined.

In other words, taking a ‘cooler’ approach to the learning area is often better than taking a ‘hot’ one.

‘How does Distancing Relate to Context and Role and to the Theme/Learning Area?’

Distancing is possible *both through time and emotional relationship* to the main area of exploration. We want to make this essential feature more explicit so we have represented it diagrammatically.

The grid model ([Figure 6.1](#)) sets out in detail the critical planning concepts of learning area, context, role and the two functions of frame in relation to a theme/learning area, which is both far removed from the experiences of the students and potentially harrowing. As we have tried to show in this range of approaches, it is possible to engage with the material in numerous ways – not all of which are included here by any means. What the grid illustrates is a range of possible roles to be taken by the students, the contexts in which the drama might unfold and the essential frames that provide the dramatic tension. We have moved through varying degrees of both time and emotional distance from the main area of exploration, indicating a shift from what we have earlier described as a ‘hot’ experience towards a ‘cooler’ one.

It should be clear from what we have said so far, that this function of frame refers to the way in which it empowers participants in the communication process within the drama. Basically, it gives them something to say by providing what Dorothy Heathcote calls a 'power stance' – in other words, a position of sufficient *authority* from which to proceed in the drama. The importance of empowering them in this way demands that the choice of the *communication frame* is considered carefully. We do not wish to leave the students floundering in the drama.

But there is something of a paradox here. It is the job of teachers to enable those we teach to come to understand the world around them in order that they can function more successfully within it. This means that we are constantly seeking to enable students to go from the known to the unknown so that they meet new ideas, concepts and understandings or are enabled to gain new insights and shifts in perceptions about things they know already.

Drama is a powerful process by which these ends can be gained but it does imply that we are regularly establishing dramas about times, places, peoples and circumstances that are beyond the experiences of our students. In fact, this means that what we regularly are asking them to do demands that they step onto the shaky ground of the unknown. In drama terms this usually means asking them to take on the roles and behave as if they are people of whom they have little prior knowledge, and herein lies a potential for floundering.

'How can the Teacher Guard Against this?'

Well, we need to ensure that the students have *one* foot on firm ground, and we can do this by selecting a communication frame that will enable them to draw on their own real life experience so that they can bring authenticity to the drama. Let's look at some examples of dramas to make this clearer.

In a drama set in the west of the United States, it's not a matter of being cowhands but cowhands *who have lost their horses*; in a drama set in the West Indies of the early 1800s, it's not a matter of being slaves but slaves who are *secretly planning a rebellion*; or in a drama set at an archaeological site, it's not a matter of archaeologists but archaeologists *who must complete the dig within a week*. The important factor in all of these examples is that they are not merely descriptive but function dynamically. What is important is not what the people look like or where they are so much as what they feel and think; that is, *what drives them*.

In these examples, students who cannot know the experience of cowhands *do* know something of loss and therefore it is on that level they enter the drama and so can immediately talk with authority about dealing with the

Learning Area	Context	Role	Frame	
			Communication	Distance
The horror of warfare techniques	In the trenches in France	Soldiers ...	who have no gas masks	HOT None
The physical/mental consequences of war	In a field hospital	Nursing/ ambulance personnel ...	who are understaffed and under-equipped	Not by time, a little by relationship
The strategy of war	In strategic command HQ	Generals/military staff ...	who cannot afford further defeat	Not by time, a little by relationship
Consequences for those left behind	At the town hall waiting for new casualty lists	Family members ...	who have heard of new losses	Not by time, a little by relationship
The propaganda of war	Film studio/ location	Film makers ...	who are instructed by government to make postwar documentary with a positive spin	Somewhat by time, more by relationship
Importance of remembrance	The Cenotaph	Veterans ...	who are late for ceremony	Not by relationship but by time
Cultural significance of war	Museum	Curators ...	who cannot display all items	By relationship and by time
Symbolic representation of war, the role of women	Design studio	Sculptors ...	whose design has been rejected for not including women's role	Greatest distance by time and by relationship COOL

Figure 6.1 The two aspects of frame

‘Could you Explain the Grid in a Little More Detail?’

Well, let's take two of the examples from the grid and expand them to reveal how the lessons might progress. By doing this we hope to show the relationship between the two aspects of frame working together with role and context to maximise the quality of the drama experience for the learners.

If we look at the ‘hottest’ situation in terms of the distance function of frame, in which the students take on the roles of soldiers, we can see that there is a potential for the kind of disruptive behaviour or superficial engagement that we referred to earlier. In this situation, the participants are not distanced by time at all so there remains a real possibility for inappropriate behaviour because what the students are likely to know about soldiers is fighting! However, by careful selection of a communication/tension frame, namely as soldiers *who have no gas masks*, we are able to minimise this possibility. We are able to cool down the situation considerably because, now, the action of the drama will be focused on deciding how to cope with the gas mask situation and *not* with hand-to-hand combat. The students will be able to draw upon their real life experiences of ‘making do’ and problem-

solving, so creating a better chance of them engaging with the learning area of the drama in a manner that is more meaningful and less superficial.

Now, let's look at the 'coolest' example on the grid, which involves the students in role as sculptors. This is the coolest situation because the participants are distanced greatly by *both* time and emotional relationship, so already the communication and distance functions of frame reduce the potential for disruption, though not necessarily for superficiality! But, in addition, the careful selection of the communication function of frame offers the potential for shifts in perceptions about the war with regard to gender.

The whole grid shows different roles placed in dramatic contexts that have communication and distancing frames at incrementally greater removes from the hot zone of the fighting. Each example addresses the same broad learning area of the First World War. But, because the roles, context and frame differ in each individual example, the learning outcomes will be different. However, it needs to be emphasised that although each leads to a particular aspect of the area of learning, none is 'better' than any other. Each does, however, offer a different learning experience. The skill of the teacher is to make an appropriate choice dependent upon the particular class with whom she is working. This will be governed by the age, experience, social health, curriculum concerns and so on, of the class.

'Could you Show how Frame Fits into the Key Examples?'

Of course, now would be a good time to look at them again and add this next layer to the planning.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Civil servant from the Ministry	. . . must keep their expedition to the rainforest secret.

Reasons for Choice of Frame

These 6- and 7-year-olds had no experience of being botanists and little experience of the technical language of botany. However, all children of this

age understand what it means to keep a secret. Therefore, at the outset of the drama, they were able to engage authentically with the experience as the group discussed the arrangements to be made, which would ensure the covert nature of the expedition was not compromised. Moreover, being botanists rather than rainforest dwellers gave the students a cool perspective sufficiently distanced from the hot zone to be able to examine the learning focus of the ‘threat to the environment’ objectively while still being engaged by the excitement of going on an adventure, which students of this age so enjoy.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students’ roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London who . . . <i>Teacher’s role</i> Ship’s captain	. . . are discontent with their lives in London.

Reasons for Choice of Frame

Given that this drama took place within an historical context, the children quite clearly could have no experience of being Victorian Londoners. However, they all had experience of being ‘fed up’ and wishing that things could be different. This is, after all, a feeling that we all understand. They could, therefore, quickly enter the drama by articulating why they were feeling discontented with their lives. You will notice that in this example, there is little distance from the hot zone. However, we must remember that this learning area was not beyond the experience of this particular class of children. The overwhelming majority came from families that had relocated to London from a range of places, both intra- and international.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students’ roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers who . . . <i>Teacher’s role</i> Head of Law Chambers	. . . need to meet a deadline to present evidence for the official hearing.

Reasons for Choice of Frame

Clearly, this class did not have experience of being lawyers; however, they all understood very well the pressures of time. Moreover, they understood the principle of responsibility to other people, in this case, the client and the Head of Chambers who needed the evidence on time. The students were distanced by means of delaying the advent of the hearing so that the drama focused on the assemblage of evidence rather than an emotive confrontation in the courtroom.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.	Mark's brother Thomas Musonda as a collective role who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Shadowy role as narrator or community member	. . . has to decide whether to leave his baby brother at an orphanage.

Reasons for Choice of Frame

While the students in Zambia had little or no previous experience of working with process drama, the teacher wanted them to engage with the drama in a personal and meaningful way, and to experience directly and reflect on significant aspects of the social upheaval that arise from a health crisis like the HIV pandemic in Zambia and other countries across the world. Building the role of Thomas as a collective one gave the students the opportunity to struggle at first hand with the kind of dilemma that many people face when confronted with personal loss and the possible disintegration of their families, while protecting them into the experience by ensuring no one participant carried the burden of such an exposed role.

It is worth remembering that, in each of these examples, the teacher drew upon her knowledge of the students in her class to help her select a frame that was appropriate for *them*.

So, in this chapter we hope that we've made clear that whenever you choose a frame, the communication function (offering collective concern and power

stance and therefore an *affective engagement* with the drama) together with the distancing function (which protects into the experience) combine to offer the greatest potential for high quality drama and, therefore, learning.

‘Is the Planning Complete Now?’

There are still two further aspects of planning we need to bring into the equation before you’ll be ready to begin the drama. One is ‘*strategies*’ and we will come back to this later. The other aspect is ‘*sign*’ and that is the subject of the next chapter.

KEY QUESTION: ‘What artefacts, personal items, sounds, images and so on will I need to bring significance to the events of the drama?’

People make sense of the world around them by a continuous processing of information. This information may be presented in many different forms, for example the written or spoken word, pictures, diagrams, photographs, maps, road signs, clothing, architecture, furnishings, works of art (drama, dance, music and visual art); in fact, the list is endless. These potentially information-bearing phenomena are known as ‘signs’ and the academic study of signs and how meaning is communicated in society is known as ‘semiotics’.

‘How is this Relevant for Process Drama?’

There’s no need here to go into too much detail about the discipline of semiotics, but effective planning for process drama requires some insight and understanding about the ways in which signs may be generated and interpreted. It might be helpful if we begin by considering how signs are used by theatre practitioners to create meaning for an audience.

In the theatre, objects, light, sound and words are organised for significance. A performance in the theatre is a highly selective, deliberate event, which is designed to enable the making of meaning for its audience. In other words, all that the members of the audience see and hear has been deliberately selected in order to clearly communicate the meaning of the play to them, but they must *read* it.

In effect, theatre is a semiotic system that is concerned with processes of signification and communication via which meanings are generated and exchanged. Each individual sign-carrying element is known as a ‘sign-vehicle’.

Together, they combine in order to communicate information to an audience.

‘This Seems Complicated’

Looking at some specific examples might clarify this. If the stage is set with a dining table on which there are four place settings, the audience is being led to believe that there is a reasonable expectation that four people will arrive to eat a meal. If only three arrive the audience may further reasonably conclude that someone is missing. Further clues may be yielded by (a) what the three actors say to each other, (b) their gender, (c) their age, (d) their costume – including the colour and/or style, (e) the decor of the room, (f) sound effects, (g) lighting and so on. This totality will be read and so lead the audience to recognise a crofter’s cottage, a hotel dining room or a king’s palace.

However, in the theatre there is yet another, perhaps even more important, aspect to sign. Sign-vehicles may be invested with special features, qualities and attributes that they do not have in real life. While in real life the utilitarian function of an object is usually more important than its signification, in the theatre it is the signification that usually takes precedence. Furthermore, this signification can be divided into two categories. First, the sign-vehicle may stand for something that is concrete and second, it may stand for something that is abstract. For example, a stick, when functioning in the concrete mode, can represent a range of objects including a golf club, a spear, a donkey, even a baby or a dance partner. In the abstract mode it can represent the wand of truth, the rod of correction, the sword of justice.

In summary, the theatrical sign is polyfunctional. In other words, theatre gives permission for things to be read as things other than they are. A long piece of cloth can function as the train of a dress, an ocean, a river, a wall, a tent or mountains when used in the concrete mode or a confused state of mind, security, a feeling of claustrophobia or imprisonment (if tightly bound) when used in the abstract mode.

It will be clear that an appreciation and understanding of this principle of the polyfunctionality of the theatrical sign is also critical for the successful planning of process drama experiences. However, we don’t need to create a full-blown theatrical setting for process drama to take place. In fact, it would be counterproductive to do so. What the teacher needs to do is to use things such as artefacts and personal items – documents, images, sounds and three-dimensional objects for instance – to direct the participants’ attention and help them to explore actively the precise focus of the lesson. What we actually need to do is *combine the students’ willing suspension of disbelief; a well-chosen context; roles and frame, with the teacher’s careful selection of a few well-chosen signs, which the teacher has prepared in advance, and which*

will hook the students into the focus of the drama at its outset.

It might be useful at this point to introduce a somewhat pared down version of the American semiotician C.S. Pierce's (1990) classification of signs, namely *symbol*, *icon* and *index* (Figure 7.1).

Symbol	Icon	Index
Signifies as a replica which must be interpreted	Signifies by means of resemblance	Signifies through an existential relationship

Figure 7.1 Pierce's sign classification

‘Why is this Classification Useful for Process Drama?’

If in the theatre, as we have already stated, objects, light, sound and words are organised for significance, it might be useful to learn a little more about the nature of those signs. After all, the more we understand things, the more likely we are to use them to best advantage.

A *symbol* signifies as a replica that must be interpreted – for example a crown is not only something to be worn on the head but also may represent the institution of the monarchy itself. Symbols of this nature are used extensively in the theatre as in life. Flags represent nations, colours represent political affiliations or emotional states or social conventions – stereotypically in Western cultures, for example, the widow wears black, the virgin wears white, the harlot wears red. In addition, because of the polyfunctionality of the theatrical sign, as identified by Erika Fischer-Lichte in her 1992 book *The Semiotics of Theatre*, a chair can stand for a motor car, a mountain, a stepladder, an umbrella, etc.

An *icon* signifies by means of resemblance. A good example from the theatre might be a portrait or scenery where a pictorial or graphic representation of a person, object or setting is used.

An *index* signifies through an existential relationship. For example, a knock at the door points to someone on the other side, a telephone ringing points to someone wishing to speak, smoke points to the possible existence of a fire. So, ‘symbol’ may correspond to both metaphor and metonym, ‘icon’ to the more literal and representational, while ‘index’ is about relatedness.

In her pioneering drama work, Dorothy Heathcote eventually grew to understand that, in an educational situation, the semiotic system operating in the theatre would need to be adjusted to the requirements of education. However, her approach developed more along the lines of Jerome Bruner's

1966 classification of ‘symbolic, iconic and enactive representation’ than of the Pierce (1990) trichotomy ([Figure 7.2](#)).

Symbolic	Iconic	Expressive
Relating to the linguistic or numerical function	Relating to the visual or graphic function	Relating to the active, performing function

Figure 7.2 Bruner/Heathcote’s trichotomy

At the risk of paraphrasing Bruner, much of what happens in schools occurs in the symbolic domain, principally where letters, words and numbers are the things that stand for concepts, objects and calculations. In most educational systems worldwide it is this system of the symbolic representation that is privileged. Student competence is measured in terms of how well they can handle these writing and numerical systems.

Iconic representation appears to be less privileged in education, so that art, craft, technical drawing, modelling and draughtsmanship are often regarded as vocational studies and are therefore less valued than academic subjects.

Finally, there is enactive or expressive representation – voice, body, dance, drama, music – and these tend to be valued least of all in education yet, ironically, are highly prized in terms of the position they hold in high culture – theatre, opera, ballet, for example.

Once the drama teacher begins to understand that she has symbolic, iconic and expressive systems of representation at her disposal she can begin to fulfil the requirements of the drama more efficiently by plugging in to the most appropriate signing system. Because drama is perceived primarily as an expressive art form, teachers are frequently, mistakenly as it happens, tempted to move their work directly into the expressive mode. Just as the director of a play must consider many other aspects of staging apart from the expressive aspects of the performance – for example, sets, costumes, sound effects – so the teacher must sign into the classroom the elements of the drama in the most appropriate way. An example may help.

Good signing in process drama eases the need to have somebody keep the drama going because good signing will generate tasks that will further generate new signs and tensions. An example of this at work was during one of the first drama experiences we had with Dorothy Heathcote, which was with residents of an adult facility in the North East of England for people with mental disabilities. Trying to get some (expressive) horses, played by members of the drama team, back to their owner, we had to take them on a

journey. Part of that journey took us on a train journey through a long dark tunnel containing horrors of our own invention. Everyone was protected into the experience because we were imagining those things that would frighten the horses but, of course, we were working through our own basic fears as well, by drawing insects, spiders, snakes and ghosts on a long roll of paper representing (iconically) the inside of the tunnel. Knowing that we were framed as people who had to protect these horses, we were then freed to realise new tensions by creating the most horrible things imaginable but with which we felt we could cope. The very act of drawing them somehow disarmed them of their potential to frighten us, while they retained their horrifying potential to scare the horses.

‘But why is this so Important?’

This identification of symbolic, iconic and expressive systems of representation is not merely an interesting piece of educational theory but constitutes a very useful tool that has the potential to assist teachers enormously in identifying the ways in which signs will be generated in process drama. This is, after all, a type of drama in which some signs will be prepared in advance, while others will have to be generated as they are required. The precise nature of these signs will have important consequences, too. What we have said already, and are trying to emphasise, is that because they are doing drama many teachers feel bound to gravitate directly towards the expressive system of representation. But this is not always the most desirable option. Perhaps another example will help.

Two teachers team-teaching a lesson on decision-making with a class of 45 seven-year-olds opted to use the dramatic context of a restaurant, and it is interesting to see exactly how the different systems of representation we have been outlining were used during the course of the lesson.

One of the teachers, out of role, spoke with the children and explained that they were going to be part of a drama about a restaurant. The teacher then gave out circles cut from old computer paper that she explained were going to be their plates. She then asked them to decorate the edges, the borders of the plates, with their crayons. While they were getting on with that task, the teacher turned to the chalkboard and wrote the words ‘Minnie’s Restaurant – Menu’, followed by a list of dishes available. The children were then invited to make their choice from the menu and to draw their dinners on their plates. Only very gradually, through the talk of the teacher, the eventual appearance of the menu on the board and the children’s careful decoration of the plates and drawing of their dinners, was the sense of ‘restaurant-ness’ signed into the classroom.

In other types of drama, many of the elements that would go into signing the idea of restaurant might have been constructed, painted and preset before the start of the play, for example, menu, tables, chairs, place settings. And, indeed, the teacher here could have prepared many of those things in advance. She chose instead to get the children to make them as part of the learning activity and up to this point all their activities were clearly located within the symbolic (writing the restaurant name and menu) and iconic (decorating and drawing on the plates) systems of representation.

This approach also helped the teacher to build up the idea of the children's roles as customers in the restaurant before she finally put on an apron and picked up a notebook and pencil to sign her role as waitress and they entered fully into the expressive events of the drama with her question to them, 'Would you like anything to drink with your meal?' Teachers can benefit from knowing that there are alternative ways of doing things as a result of the availability of these systems of representation. If the requirements of the drama call for the idea of a dog in, say, a drama about the police canine division, how will the dog be signed into the room? Knowing what you do about these systems of symbolic, iconic and expressive representation, you now have a choice. You can sign the idea of a dog, symbolically, by writing its name or the word 'dog' on a piece of paper, sticking it on the wall and negotiating with the students that, in the drama, this is where the dog is chained. You can sign the idea of a dog, iconically, by making a drawing or three-dimensional model of the dog in its kennel. Alternatively, you could create the dog expressively but in this case you run the risk that somebody may end up barking uncontrollably because someone will be 'playing the part' of the dog.

In their work on *Bo Peep*, Nigel Toye and Francis Prendiville (2000) avoided the barking dog through a series of controlled signs. Francis, in the role of the farmer, wore a tweed cap, carried a shepherd's crook and set down on the ground a brightly coloured dog bowl before whistling for the dog and calling its name. When the nursery children with whom they were working were invited to come forward one at a time to pat the dog, they were able to locate the (invisible) dog, because they knew where the dog's bowl was, and so could enter into the drama.

The system of signing chosen will determine not only how effectively something is signed into the room but will also determine what you can do with it. That is, the nature of the engagement.

When a teacher conducted a drama about a distressed farmer whose cow, Daisy, had fallen down a big hole, the 6-year-olds, in the role of farm workers, were faced with the enormous problem of getting Daisy out of the hole. What

considerations went into signing Daisy for the children? The symbolic representation of Daisy's name written on a piece of paper would sign her presence adequately, but would not serve the enactment of the rescue very well. Iconic representation would be fine, that is having Daisy represented by a large drawing of a cow (a life-size, three-dimensional model would have been both too literal as well as impractical), but hauling a drawing of Daisy out of the hole as part of the rescue just wouldn't ring true for anyone either. Having someone representing Daisy expressively might have meant having someone in a cow mask, mooing incessantly, which in all probability would only have shattered the intense and urgent manner in which they devised their ingenious rescue apparatus and carried out their plan. Actually, in order for Daisy to be rescued she had to not be physically represented at all.

This sounds paradoxical but, ironically, by not having a visible cow, the children were liberated to 'see' her through the eyes of their imagination. They were able to imagine the level of her distress, the awkward way in which she was stuck in the hole, the amount of space they had to work in and the size and weight of the animal that had to be rescued. The plan they devised for the rescue involved the construction and use of lifting apparatus operated by everyone pulling together on ropes, while Daisy was soothed by tempting her with her favourite food and the sounds of familiar voices. This apparatus was also created in the imagination of children so that it was possible for them to 'feel' the weight of Daisy on the lifting platform and know they had a big job to do. So, the teacher was faced with finding a different means by which to sign Daisy's presence that did not rely upon something concrete. In fact, this was achieved through expressively signing the hole by having the children stand around its perimeter and signing Daisy symbolically through the children keeping her calm by singing their choice of song, *Daisy, Daisy*. Daisy had to be present in the drama but invisible for the purposes of the rescue.

So, what the teacher uses as signs, as well as how they are used, will vary from one drama to another. However, there is one principle in their selection that remains constant for *all* dramas. That is the need for the chosen signs to be clear, uncluttered and absolutely focused on the learning area of the drama, since it is the learning that is critical.

'You Mentioned Earlier that Some Signs will be Prepared in Advance. Can you say why?'

As we've said before, process drama has many things in common with other areas of the curriculum in respect of the planning and preparation the teacher needs to undertake before the lesson begins. You will be very familiar with the

need to prepare your teaching materials in advance for many of the lessons you teach in other areas of the curriculum. In a nutshell, signs that are prepared in advance can be regarded as your teaching materials for the lesson. Some may be concerned with helping to transform your working space, some will be used to evoke a mood, some to foreshadow events of the unfolding drama, some to create absent others (that is to say, represent someone who is not actually present), some to identify community, some to identify role and/or status; all will need to lead the students' attention to the focus of the drama – the learning area or theme.

For example, in a drama about life in a fishing village, the teacher needed to indicate that fish stocks had been seriously depleted by over-fishing and undesirable fishing practices such as the use of dynamite. This had reduced the boats to taking immature fish as the larger fish had gone. The teacher's choice of sign was governed by the need to focus the attention of the students on the learning area. Therefore, she finally selected a real fishing net but in addition the students in role drew small fishes on pieces of paper that were then placed in the net. What is important here is that the teacher needed to restrict the size of the fish in order to evoke the dilemma, which she achieved by limiting the size of the paper that the children had been given. This may seem rather obvious but is actually crucial. She could not have rejected what the children had created but if the fish had been too big then the sign would have worked against the theme of the drama rather than supporting it.

So, what we have here is an example of sign helping to establish the context of the drama both through what the teacher has prepared in advance – the fishing net – and by the sign generated by the students in role – the fish.

‘Can you Relate this to the Key Examples?’

Well, let's return to the key examples again, and see which signs the teacher prepared.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Civil servant from the Ministry	. . . must keep their expedition to the rainforest secret.	Photograph of rare plant, secrecy pact, writing materials, clipboard, requisition slips.

Reasons for Choice of Signs

In this drama the teacher needed to find a sign to focus the students' attention on the plant that was to be the object of the botanists' expedition to the rainforest. Ultimately, she selected a photograph of a real plant. First, this choice was made because it was photograph of an unusual plant (in fact a species of orchid) with which the children were unfamiliar. However, the teacher also chose this photograph because the plant was placed against a black background that gave no point of reference to the size of the plant. This was important. It meant that the children were at liberty in the drama to 'discover' specimens and no matter what size they reported, they would all be right. In role, both teacher and children were able to conclude in the expedition's log that 'it starts as a small plant but can grow to immense proportions'. In order to support the frame of the drama, the teacher also created a 'confidentiality agreement', to which the botanists had to add their signatures, and Ministry requisition slips and other bureaucratic impedimenta.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London who ... <i>Teacher's role</i> Ship's captain	... are discontent with their lives in London.	Broadsheet announcing gold strike and a public meeting, large wall map of route between England and Australia, small map of Australia, gold nugget.

Reasons for Choice of Signs

Here, the teacher created a broadsheet flyer that announced both the finding of gold in Australia and a public meeting for people who wished to take passage to Australia. This sign worked to focus the students on the learning area by the use of counterpoint. While the teacher could have used any number of artefacts to suggest a discontented life in London, she actually chose to create a sign that would place that discontentment into high relief by holding out the tantalizing prospect of a means for things to be different – going to Australia and making one's fortune – so fuelling the action of the drama. She reinforced this with the presence of a nugget of gold while, at the same time, symbolising the enormity of the undertaking by the presence of a huge map of the route between the two countries that actually extended around two walls of the classroom.

Key Example 3: 11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers who ... <i>Teacher's role</i> Head of Law Chambers	... need to meet a deadline to present evidence for the official hearing.	Brief from client, law books, documents file.

Reasons for Choice of Signs

In this example, the teacher had to communicate clearly the nature of the law profession that was achieved through the presence of the law books. These, along with the files and other documentation, also helped to point the students in the direction of the research with which they were to be engaged throughout the week of their activity. However, it was the brief – the instructions from the client contained in a specific letter – in this case from a teacher suspended from her post for teaching evolution theory – which really worked to hook the students in their roles as junior lawyers, into the main thrust of this task-based drama. A major objective of this drama was the continuous production of student-generated signs – to be used as evidence in the final hearing.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling.	Mark's older brother Thomas Musonda as a collective role who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Shadowy role as narrator or community member	. . . has to decide whether to leave his baby brother at an orphanage.	Boy's jacket, bundle of cloth representing baby, pens, paper.

Reasons for Choice of Sign

The boy's jacket was an important component for building a way into this particular drama. It performed a number of functions. It inducted a male presence into the space by functioning both as a sign of 'young masculinity' as well as representing the disembodied role of 14-year-old Mark. It protected the participants from having to deal with the stigma of HIV/AIDS by allowing them to build the idea of someone who had been HIV positive since birth and to maintain a level of detachment and objectivity. None of the participants was asked too quickly to decide whether they would be willing to portray such a role without first being fully prepared. This caution was

necessary since it was also quite possible that individuals among the student participants might actually have been HIV positive. For the purposes of the drama the bundle of cloth simultaneously signified the idea of an infant, and functioned as the role of Mark as a baby. It also allowed the teacher to shift the drama back in time so that the participants were transported in 'flashback' mode to a time 14 years earlier, when Mark was a baby. Finally the 'notes' of the fictional case study helped to furnish the teacher in the shadowy role of narrator with the details of the case, yet allowed enough freedom for the teacher to become actively engaged with the collective role of Thomas Mosunda as the drama unfolded.

From the key examples, we can see that the teacher, in each case, generated a number of different items with which to sign the drama. However, if we look into this a little more we can see there are actually three different aspects of prepared sign that each teacher created. One we have called the 'hook', another we have called 'other prepared sign' and the third we have called 'teacher sign'. This is a critical distinction and it is essential that the teacher include each in the planning process. It is worth dwelling on this for a moment.

If we look back to [Chapter 6](#) on Frame, we will recall that frame is the tension giver in the drama and that this tension is directly related to the learning area. If we follow this through to our consideration of sign, we will see that in process drama sign demonstrates in a physical and symbolic way the tension that is provided by the frame.

When the teacher chooses appropriately, the things used as sign will carry within them the energy, urgency and imperative for the drama to unfold. In the sign grid ([Figure 7.3](#)), we have set out our three key examples and, in addition, the two First World War examples that we looked at in [Chapter 6](#). We have included the signing for each example, this time broken down into the three categories.

Learning Area	Context	Students' roles	Frame	Teacher's role	Sign a) Hook b) Other prepared sign c) Teacher sign
Why people undertake long and difficult journeys in the hope of something better at the end	Victorian London	Inhabitants of London ...	who are discontent with their lives in London	Shadowy role/ Ship's captain	a) Broadsheet announcing gold strike and a public meeting b) Large wall map of route between UK and Australia c) Small map of Australia and a gold nugget
Can evolution theory and creation theory be reconciled?	Present-day Jamaican law firm	Junior lawyers ...	who have to gather evidence in four days	Head of legal firm	a) Brief from client b) Law books, documents c) File
The horror of warfare techniques	First World War trenches in France	Soldiers ...	who have no gas masks	Quartermaster	a) Instructions for using gas masks, empty gas mask box b) Ground plan of trenches on floor c) Clipboard with orders
The symbolic representation of war and the role of women in war	Post-First World War artists studio	Sculptors ...	whose designs have been rejected for not including the role of women	Cleaning lady	a) Rejection letter b) Studio 'clutter', sculpture designs c) Cleaning materials
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people	Present-day briefing at the Ministry of Agriculture	Botanists ...	who must keep their expedition to the rainforest secret	Civil servant from the ministry	a) Photograph of rare plant b) Map of region c) Requisition slips
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatised individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia caring for an HIV positive sibling	The brother, Thomas Musonda, as a collective role ...	who has to decide whether to leave his baby brother at an orphanage	Shadowy role as narrator/ Community member	a) Boy's jacket b) Bundle of cloth representing the baby c) Case file

Figure 7.3 Sign grid

Now, having looked at the grid, let's spend some time examining how each sign works in the dramas. In the first example, the sign that 'hooks' the children into the drama is a broadsheet announcing a gold strike in Australia.

This drama began with the children brainstorming and then creating individual still images that helped them to establish the dramatic context. However, it was the introduction of this document, as hook, with its careful wording, which immediately brought tension to the drama. In fact, the hook had to hold within it the potential to engage the students' interest in the drama by attracting their attention and curiosity.

In addition, the teacher introduced a powerful prepared sign through the prominent display of a map that showed both Great Britain and Australia. In the space between the two countries, the map held within it the dramatic potential for the epic journey about to unfold. However, this would unfold only over a sustained period of time. In other words, the empty space had significance, which as yet the students might not have fully understood but which the teacher had to.

Similarly, in the second example shown on the grid, the teacher hooked the students into the drama with the presence of the client in the form of a letter and further signed the legal profession with law books and documents on the table that were to be used over time in the gathering of evidence.

The preceding examples can be described as *simple* hooks because they

worked through a single sign-vehicle, namely the handbill in example one and the letter in example two. In the third example, however, the instructions for using gas masks worked together with the delayed introduction of the empty gas mask box, which should have contained the new issue for the company of soldiers. These combined to form a *compound* hook that fully established the danger of the soldiers' situation and the critical nature of the drill. The ground plan of the trenches taped to the floor indicated the confined environment in which the soldiers would have to operate over time and although a ground plan was prepared ahead of time by the teacher, it could have been created by the students at the outset of the drama as a context building strategy. The empty gas mask box acted as a complex signifier of the soldiers' predicament, heightened the dramatic tension and provided a compelling motivation to further fuel the unfolding drama.

In the fourth example, once again, the rejection letter functioned as a simple hook and linked the children immediately to the tension of the frame, while the additional studio clutter and sculpture designs signed the nature of the dramatic context that would be used over a period of time in the development of new designs.

In the fifth example, the picture of the plant to be collected on the expedition acted as a simple hook and linked the students directly to the mystery of the journey because of the strange nature of the plant. The map of the region worked in a different way to the map used in the journey to Australia. While that map was displayed from the outset, this was not the case in the rainforest expedition. In fact, the teacher held it in reserve as a means to refocus the tension of the drama away from the now established secret nature of the journey towards the difficulties of mounting a search in unknown territory. By adjusting the signification during the course of any drama, the teacher is able to continually focus and refocus the students' attention and their commitment to the unfolding action.

Finally, in the last example the boy's jacket was used to 'hook' the students into engaging with the disembodied role of Mark and his HIV infection, while his story and that of his brother Thomas was developed. It also served to 'distance' any notion of stigma and protected the student participants until they were ready to create the embodied role of Mark later in the drama. The bundle of cloth representing the infant Mark was used to clearly establish the dilemma facing his 12-year-old brother Thomas, left with the responsibility for a baby who was HIV positive. The bundle also served as a clear signifier of a flashback in time within the dramatic action. The case study notes supported the teacher's role as narrator but could be set aside for a shift into role as a community member commenting on the brothers' lives, or even participation

in the collective role of Thomas.

However, in all six examples, additional signing was present and was used to *convey the role of the teacher* in the drama. This is also part of the signing that the teacher must prepare before the drama begins, the map and gold nugget in example one, the file in example two, the clipboard with orders in example three, the cleaning materials in example four and the requisition forms in example five. These are all external indicators of the role the teacher would adopt in the drama but would serve largely to support the *behaviour and attitude* manifested by the role as the drama takes place.

So now, five parts of the jigsaw puzzle that needs to be completed are in place. We've identified the theme, context, roles, frame and sign. What remains is to identify those drama strategies – the ways of working with performance forms – which we are going to need to make the drama happen in time and space. This leads us to the next chapter on *strategies*.

KEY QUESTION: ‘Which ways of working will I use? In which combination? For what purpose?’

If you have worked your way through the planning process as we have outlined in the preceding chapters, you will now find yourself in the position of having to consider the many different ways in which you and the students may be able to bring the drama to life.

To help with this choice, we should spend a moment thinking again about three theatre elements – contrast, time and space.

In [Chapter 2](#) we talked about drama hinging on three sets of contrasts – silence and sound, darkness and light, stillness and movement – and mentioned how meaning can be made through the friction at the interface between them. Contrasts can be used to construct and explore environment and mood, the very essence of the fictional circumstances under scrutiny, as they unfold in space and time. They are tools that the drama teacher has at her disposal, and that are available to both herself and her students as a broad range of clearly identifiable strategies that may be used to slow down, speed up or stop time, to create the illusion of wide open spaces or terrible confinement, to demonstrate social position and power or lack of it, to listen to people’s innermost thoughts and connect with their feelings, as well as a host of other things. These contrasting elements are what the teacher uses to mould dramatic form.

But as we have already mentioned, there is a wide range of strategies or performance forms available through which the teacher can shape the drama – to make it come to life. The key to success here is in knowing which strategies to use at which point, in which combination and for which purpose.

This is very important. It might seem, for example, that deciding that the students will pretend to be paddling down the river towards the first cataract

of the Nile, and having the class of 35 children sitting on the hall floor in lines of five or six, one behind the other, shuffling along on their bottoms, is the obvious way in which a drama about ancient Egypt might be brought to life. However, the result of this decision is actually likely to reduce the class to giggling and rolling around on the floor – not a desirable situation for the teacher!

The outcome of this will be to shatter the tension of the drama and the commitment of the students to what is happening because this literal approach is clearly inappropriate to these dramatic circumstances.

‘Why is it Inappropriate?’

At first glance, the teacher does seem to have brought the situation to life. After all, in our discussion of teacher-in-role, we stressed that process drama has whole-group improvisation at its heart. We are not contradicting ourselves here. Whole-group improvisation with TIR is *one* of the key ways of working in process drama. However, it is not the *only* way and neither is it always the best way. In fact, there is a rich variety of drama strategies available and the teacher needs to recognise and understand them in order to choose the one that is going to make any particular part of the drama happen, *most meaningfully*.

‘What do you Mean?’

Well, in considering which strategies to use at different points in the drama, we need to remember that we are working in an art form. Drama works within a fictional framework and so perhaps can never really be ‘accurate’. So, the students shuffling along on their bottoms cannot give an accurate portrayal of fighting rapids on a mighty river. However, when working in drama we need to recognise that while we cannot recreate ‘accurately’, we need always to strive to create ‘meaningfully’. This engages us with aesthetic considerations.

Creating the negotiation of the rapids through whole-group improvisation is unlikely to be successful because this strategy brings the students too close to their own play behaviour. It works against any possibility of maintaining the carefully nurtured and developed commitment created earlier in the drama, by breaking the suspension of disbelief – the students become themselves again, playing at paddling a canoe, and dramatic tension is lost.

However, if we take the same situation again, we can perhaps see how the outcome can be very different – and more successful and meaningful – by evoking this part of the drama through a different drama strategy. For example, the teacher could enable the students like this:

- divide them into groups of four or five;
- each group, out of role, works out the story of their canoe's journey down the river;
- each group chooses the most important, exciting or dangerous moment of that journey;
- each group makes a still image or tableau of that moment;
- each person decides on one line of dialogue that they were saying, which sums up how they were feeling/what they were thinking at that moment;
- in turn, each group presents its frozen moment, including the dialogue, as the teacher plays a recording of the sound of a raging and dangerous river.

‘What does this Give the Drama that the other Strategy Doesn’t?’

To begin with, being in a smaller working group helps the students to focus on the implications of the dramatic context – it makes them think about the fictional situation and gives them time to reflect on what it might actually be like. It also provides the opportunity for the teacher to move between the groups and help the students in their task; the use of still image precipitates them into finding the essence of the dramatic moment rather than dissipating it; it allows a greater input from each student and it encourages the possibility of a greater emotional connection to the event by challenging them to crystallise the feelings of the archaeologists in this perilous situation. It also provides the means by which all of the students in the class can *see* what happened to everyone else on the journey, so strengthening the fabric of the drama itself.

From this example we hope that you will see that choice of appropriate strategies is as important a planning element as all those that we have mentioned so far. This means that the teacher will have to address her choice of drama strategies very carefully.

‘Could you Explain more about these Drama Strategies?’

Drama strategies are the different performance forms that, when combined, build and make the process drama happen in action.

At the beginning of this book, and at different points throughout it, we have made reference to the elements of theatre – focus, metaphor, tension, symbol, contrast, role, time and space – which we stated were common to all forms of drama experience. Drama strategies, therefore, encapsulate in their different forms, these same key elements of theatre. So, if we return to the river example, we can see that the reason the first example fell apart at the seams

was because the inappropriate choice of ‘whole-group improvisation’ led to the elements of role and tension being lost.

But we can also see from the river example that different parts of a process drama can be ‘acted out’ in different ways. There is a common pool of performance forms available from which different theatre genres may draw. These forms can be combined together in a wide variety of ways to enrich, enliven and deepen the quality of the drama experience. So, when the teacher chooses strategies – performance forms – from an informed position, understanding what each can offer to the structure of the drama and, therefore, to the experience of the participants, she is able to create dramas that provoke stimulating thought and discussion, and precipitate the participants into action.

Well-crafted process dramas engage participants emotionally, kinaesthetically, tactilely, visually and cognitively by providing opportunities to develop new perspectives and insights through an empowering framework for the exploration of ideas, feelings and the making of meaning. The choice of appropriate strategy at each point as the drama unfolds, added to the choice of learning area, context, role, frame and sign, is, in our view, the means by which such well-crafted process dramas are made.

‘So where do these Appropriate Strategies Come from?’

There is a range of performance forms available to establish the context, move the narrative forward, explore and deepen the meaning and provide the opportunity to reflect upon the experience for the audience. In process drama we need to make different parts of the drama happen in different ways to maximise the learning opportunities for the students so that they make meaning for themselves.

Let’s explore this a bit more. When we watch a staged play as part of an external audience, we may observe actors who narrate sections of the story while it is being enacted by others. Or a soliloquy may allow us to hear what’s going on in a character’s mind. An aside may startle us as a character appears to step out of the action of the play and communicate directly with the audience rather than with other characters on stage. Action may be mimed, dialogue conducted between characters, sound effects used to create moods and atmosphere. As members of a watching audience, we’ve become familiar with a whole range of theatre forms and skilled in reading them in order to extract meaning from them.

As we have said earlier, in process drama there is no watching audience, but the internal audience is always present and we need to draw upon this wealth of theatre forms in this type of drama, too, in order to make meaning for that

audience – that is, for the participants themselves.

‘How Many Strategies are Available for a Drama Teacher to Use?’

There are numerous drama strategies, or performance forms, available and Jonathan Neelands and Tony Goode have categorised and set out written descriptions of many key conventions in their book, *Structuring Drama Work* (2000), which is an excellent resource (see ‘Further reading’ section). It is important for drama teachers to be familiar with the range of strategies available to them. The more they have at their command, the more sophisticated the dramas they construct with their students will be.

However, grasping them all and knowing when to use them and what effect they will have on the drama will obviously take time. It would be unreasonable to expect a teacher to have a complete grasp of the whole repertoire of available theatre forms from the outset. We believe that any teacher must build that repertoire of strategies, as must the students, for it is in this area that both students and teachers will learn most about what theatre form can do within process drama. It is in using a range of drama strategies that students and teachers, like all good theatre practitioners, will continue to explore, test and stretch the boundaries of the art form.

‘Can I Get a List?’

We’ve already referred to an excellent book and offer guidance on further reading at the end of this book, but our advice is to start with a basic tool kit and add to it as you become more confident. One way of developing a repertoire of strategies to use in process drama is, first of all, to identify what ways of working are familiar to you already. Potential ways of working may not only be drawn from the performance forms of formal western theatre, but are to be found in all sorts of performance traditions. So, whatever cultural tradition you are working in it’s a good idea to note down some of its performance forms.

- Are there any folk forms with which you are familiar?
- Are there songs that tell stories or commemorate people or events within the community?
- Is there a storytelling tradition?
- Are there any rituals, ceremonies, festivals or carnivals in your community?
- Are there any dance forms to which you could turn for inspiration?

- Are there special costumes for important occasions?
- Is there a tradition of masks and/or puppetry?
- Are there special art and craft skills associated with performance – for example, straw weaving, painting, costume building?

In addition, you may see live theatre performances from time to time. Have you ever seen any techniques or conventions used in these theatre performances that you could make use of in your dramas? Some of the strategies most frequently used in process drama and other theatre genres have emerged from social settings (meetings, interviews, telephone conversations); technology (rewinding or fast-forwarding the action, sound tracks, slow motion and sound effects); changing the numbers involved (pair work, whole-group improvisation, small group playmaking); children's games (freeze/still image, ring play and other formations). You may very quickly find yourself accumulating a range of useful performance forms that can be invaluable to you in your drama work. What is important to remember is that these performance forms are, in effect, simply different ways of presenting human experience.

But before we go any further, let's consider the different categories or *sorts* of strategy you will need at your disposal. Different strategies actually serve different purposes and in order to build a well-crafted drama you'll need to recognise the different types of purpose you'll need, and to recognise which strategy serves which purpose.

'What do you Mean by Strategies Serving a Purpose?'

When we look into how a drama is structured we can see that the nature of what is happening does not remain constant. In order to create the drama and move the story on so that the participants gain from the experience in the way that we hope, we have to recognise that strategies will need to do different things.

Choosing the right kinds of drama strategies allows us to ensure that the drama is of the highest quality possible. For example, there will be times when we need strategies that will build the dramatic context. That is to say, once we have decided on the dramatic context in which the drama will unfold, we have to find means by which to make it concrete for the participants. We may wish to do this by defining or redefining the space in which the drama is unfolding and this could be achieved by rearranging the furniture to suggest the desks and chairs of a travel agency; or by marking out the trenches of the First World War with masking tape on the floor; or by creating a palace wall made up of everyone in the class. But, defining the space will not be the only

strategy available for establishing the dramatic context. The teacher may be more concerned, initially, with individual students' 'sense of belonging' to a group in the dramatic context and so she may have them drawing or writing in role, making badges or filling in forms. Whichever strategy she chooses, it will serve its purpose in the development of the drama (in this case, the building of the dramatic context), in a particular way.

Shifting into the main body of the story or 'narrative' being created in the drama will mean shifting to new strategies that allow the drama to develop and unfold in a different way. In our First World War example, this may mean shifting to an 'overheard conversation', perhaps having the soldiers overhear officers discussing the shortage of gas masks, or to a 'meeting' where the soldiers meet to decide how best to prepare for a potential gas attack. Such shifts of strategy facilitate a move into the main body of the action of the story, development of a greater awareness and understanding of the issues and problems of the circumstances of the drama.

Opportunities for students engaging with the deeper emotional or symbolic aspects of the drama may be introduced through a further shift towards strategies that deepen the experiences through the affective power of the art form. For example, students as soldiers might write what may be their last letters home or write as if they were war poets.

Finally, 'giving witness' as survivors of a trench gas attack at a tribunal after the war represents yet another shift, which now presents the students with the opportunity to reflect seriously on the full implication of the drama in a manner that is meaningful and not superficial.

What we have just described does not amount to a complete lesson plan but it does give an indication of the ways in which a careful application of selected performance forms serves to move forward and deepen the experience of the drama for its participants.

'It Seems as if Different Strategies Work in Different Ways. Is this so?'

Neelands and Goode classified strategies as 'context building', 'narrative building', 'poetic' and 'reflective' and drama teachers everywhere have found this classification very helpful. It is, therefore, well worth thinking about the functions different types of strategy can serve in a process drama. They can, generally speaking, serve four different purposes. It is most often the case that well-crafted and therefore successful dramas are structured in a way that incorporates different strategies that serve all four purposes in order to give students as deep and complete an experience as possible. So, let's give some

attention to examining the four types of strategy.

Put simply, as a teacher you will find that you need strategies to:

- a. establish the dramatic context;
- b. move the story of the drama forward;
- c. explore a greater depth of meaning and feeling;
- d. help the participants to reflect on the drama.

To start with, it is essential that you equip yourself with a basic 'tool kit' of drama strategies and then add to it as you become more confident.

We don't necessarily subscribe to the view that particular strategies may only be used for specific purposes, for example, context building *only*. Depending on the teacher's intention, some strategies can be used as different forms of action and can also serve more than one purpose at once.

Let's try to pull together a basic tool kit of drama strategies by once again looking at our key examples. For each of these we have drawn up the complete list of strategies used in the development of the dramas and briefly outlined the elements of the narrative that were carried by each strategy.

Key Example 1: 6/7-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Taking plant species from an environment impacts negatively on the local people.	Present-day Ministry of Agriculture expedition to the rainforest.	Botanists who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Civil servant from the Ministry	. . . must keep their expedition to the rainforest secret.	Photograph of rare plant, secrecy pact, writing materials, clipboard, requisition slips.

Strategies Used

1. Out of role discussion – what is a botanist?
2. Teacher-in-role – civil servant from the Ministry of Agriculture.
3. Whole-group improvisation – a confidential meeting of botanists at the Ministry – teacher-in-role introduces the secret expedition.
4. Ritual – signing of the secrecy agreement.
5. Small groups – deciding on what equipment to take.
6. Small groups – deciding on cover story for travelling to Brazil.
7. Whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role getting through immigration at the airport.

8. Meeting with teacher-in-role – deciding which route to take to the search area.
9. Group still images – the highlight of your journey through the rainforest.
10. Group narratives – each group's story of their journey to the meeting point – reporting sightings of plant en route.
11. Pictogram – message in pictures from the rainforest dwellers.
12. Whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role – deciphering the message and deciding what to do as the plant is medicine for the rainforest dwellers.
13. Pair work – devising a sign language to communicate with the rainforest dwellers.
14. Teacher-in-role (as a person from the rainforest) and pair work – communicating the message.
15. Whole-group improvisation – agreeing a compromise solution to the problem.
16. Whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role as Minister – facing the music.
17. Small group work – press conference.
18. Group still images – photographic record of the key moments of the expedition.

Key Example 2: 8/9-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
What makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?	Victorian London as gold find in Australia is announced.	Inhabitants of London who . . . <i>Teacher's role</i> Ship's captain	. . . are discontent with their lives in London.	Broadsheet announcing gold strike and a public meeting, large wall map of route between England and Australia, small map of Australia, gold nugget.

Strategies Used

1. Brainstorm of why people leave where they are living and go on a long and

- difficult journey in the hope of something better at the other end.
2. Individual still image – moment of contentment with life in London.
 3. Individual still image – same role – moment of discontentment with life in London.
 4. Pair conversations – tell partner why discontent.
 5. Teacher in shadowy role – spreading news of gold strike and meeting in town hall about ship going to Australia – pairs discussing this news.
 6. Whole-group improvisation – public meeting – teacher-in-role as Captain of ship.
 7. Group still image – the moment the groups decided to go.
 8. Reading the images – who is happy, who is the powerful one, what is the relationship between the people in the groups?
 9. Writing in role – diary entries that night – place on map on wall near London.
 10. Whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role on the quayside signing up for passage – TIR stressing can't take much on board.
 11. Drawing in role – keepsakes – tell others near you what it is and why it is precious to you – add to map on wall.
 12. Individual mime – packing your small case of personal belongings.
 13. Still images plus thought-tracking – what is going through your mind as you leave for the ship – speak, then move to meeting point.
 14. Whole-group improvisation with TIR – getting on board.
 15. Polaroid photos of each group at foot of gangway – write group caption for picture summing up group feelings – put on map.
 16. Writing in role – diary entries, first night on ship – put on map.
 17. Small group playmaking – the first thing to go wrong.
 18. Sharing the incidents – named by the whole group – place of incident marked on map and name written on.
 19. Out of role, one incident selected by whole group to explore consequences – outbreak of infectious disease.
 20. Whole-group improvisation with TIR – ship meeting to decide what to do.
 21. Ritual – burial at sea – thought-tracking as body is buried.
 22. Writing in role – diary entry, that night – add to map around point where incident was marked.
 23. Celebration – ship free from disease. Storytelling of other celebrations attended – trying to guess what Australia will be like – what to do with the gold when found.
 24. 24 Storm at sea – out of role decide story of what happened to your travelling group in your part of the ship during storm.
 25. In role – group still image of most important or dangerous moment of the

- story.
26. Add two more images – one a few moments before and another a few moments after.
 27. Put together in series of three still images.
 28. Add a line of dialogue for each person in each image.
 29. Bring still images to life in slow motion and string together in continuous sequence of movement – add dialogue.
 30. Performance carousel – whole class shares storm sequences consecutively – rest of class creating sounds of storm when not showing their episode.
 31. Ceremony – giving thanks for salvation from the storm.
 32. Writing in role – diary entry, that night – add to the map at the location of the storm.
 33. Arrival in Australia – disembarking from the ship – teacher narration and whole-class mime of gathering belongings.
 34. Photographs of disembarkation – polaroids – add caption and add to map.
 35. Writing in role – letters home – add to map.
 36. Whole-group improvisation – meeting to decide what to do about getting to gold fields – three possible routes – which way to go? Debating the pros and cons – stick together or separate – children decided to stick together.
 37. Writing in role – diary entry, that night.
 38. Journey through the mountains – using same strategy as for the storm at sea.
 39. Arrival in the gold fields – whole-group improvisation with TIR – taking leave of each other as we separate to stake our claims.
 40. Staking claims and finding gold – group mime and teacher narration.
 41. Writing in role – diary entry, that night.
 42. Teacher narration and small group mime – finding gold.
 43. Writing in role – letters home telling of conditions and success.
 44. Marking the moment – individually go to that part of the map that shows the most important part of the drama for you and sharing with the others the reasons for your choice.
 45. Monument to the Gold Seekers – reflection on journey – in groups create a statue that symbolises the experiences of the travellers – add an inscription to go round plinth – share with other groups – polaroids of statues – add to the map.

Key Example 3: -11/13-Year-Olds

<i>Theme/learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Creation theory versus evolution theory – why does a tension exist between those who hold different views about the origins of life on earth?	Present-day Jamaican law firm gathering evidence for a case.	Junior lawyers who . . . <i>Teachers role</i> Head of Law Chambers	. . . need to meet a deadline to present evidence for the official hearing.	Brief from client, law books, documents file.

Strategies Used

1. Teacher-in-role as senior partner with law firm briefs legal team about new case.
2. Teacher-in-role reads letter from a teacher seeking legal assistance. She has been dismissed from her post for teaching evolution theory, against the expressed wishes of the school governors, who had instructed her to teach creation theory and to be guided by the account of the creation as set down in the Old Testament.
3. Brainstorming in role about what kinds of evidence to present at a projected hearing that would be in the best interests of the client, without necessarily further alienating the governors of the school.
4. Decision made to present a 'balanced' body of evidence, with suggestions for different types of approaches that might be taken in the gathering of evidence in this case.
5. Dividing up into smaller groups for gathering and development of specific types of evidence.
6. Introduction to selection of useful research literature, information, materials, etc.
7. Opportunities for question and answer sessions, interviews and interaction with resource persons including qualified anthropologist, choreographer, visual artist, etc.
8. Daily meetings in role to monitor the progress of the work.
9. Choreographing a 'creation' dance after completing a cross-cultural comparison of creation stories and myths of origin.
10. Assembly, in role, of a large collage mural on primate evolution depicting Australopithecus, Homo Erectus, Cro-magnon man, Homo Sapiens, etc.
11. 11 Construction, in role, of a three-dimensional model of a Pterodactyl as a hanging mobile.
12. Installation, in role, of a life-size, two-dimensional outline of a

- Tyrannosaurus Rex on the side of a two-storey building.
13. Development and construction, in role, of an interactive model of plate tectonics.
 14. Choosing, in role, a suitable scale and production of a geological timeline representing approximately 400 million years of the earth's history.
 15. Designing and producing, in role, the models for a dinosaur diorama.
 16. Small group site meetings at the workstations for each of the evidence-gathering projects.
 17. Presenting evidence in role as junior counsel at the final hearing.
 18. Symbolic, ritualised depiction of creation in dance/drama form.
 19. Attempting, in role, to reconcile the opposing views presented by both sides in this argument.

Key Example 4: 15/18-Year-Olds

<i>Theme /learning area</i>	<i>Context</i>	<i>Students' roles</i>	<i>Frame</i>	<i>Sign</i>
Investigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on family life in Zambia – why does HIV/AIDS often produce scapegoats and stigmatized individuals and how can this type of response be challenged?	Present-day location in Zambia for an HIV positive sibling.	The brother Thomas Musonda as a collective role who . . .	. . . has to decide whether to leave his baby brother at an orphanage.	Boy's jacket, bundle for infant, pens, paper.
		<i>Teacher's role</i> Shadowy role as narrator or community member		

Strategies Used

1. Teacher inducts the role of Mark who is HIV positive, representing his presence by carefully arranging a boy's jacket over a chair. From this the teacher uses storytelling to develop the introductory scenario.
2. Brainstorming together, the students insert some of the details into the story.
3. A student volunteer creates the still image representing Mark's older brother Thomas who is HIV negative.
4. 4 Using a bundle of cloth given to Thomas to represent the baby Mark, the teacher is able to flashback the drama to a time 12 years earlier.
5. Teacher-in-role as Thomas introduces and demonstrates the use of

thought-tracking.

6. Thought-tracking is used with the still image of Thomas holding the baby Mark, to articulate something of Thomas's serious dilemma.
7. Students are invited to write in role as Thomas by composing the note he leaves with his baby brother when he leaves him at the orphanage.
8. The use of folk forms and, since this drama is being done in a school in multi-lingual Zambia, the use of vernacular languages is an important step in establishing ownership of the learning. A traditional lullaby sung in Nyanja, a local language commonly used in the Lusaka region, is introduced by a female student to the rest of the class.
9. The notes written in role by the individual students are read aloud to the rest of the class.
10. The reading becomes ritualized as it is punctuated by the singing of the lullaby, which produces a powerful dramatic moment.
11. Students work in small groups as 'playwrights' who are filling in the 'missing' years between Thomas's painful decision to give up his younger brother, and the present time of the established drama when Mark is 14 years of age.
12. The group playwriting constitutes not so much a flash-forward in time but a considerably slower narrative progression in time from the flashback to the present time of the drama.
13. A number of the contributions to the story foreshadow some kind of reunion and reconciliation between the two brothers.
14. Teacher leads the brainstorming to establish a consensus about the direction the action of the drama should take.
15. Thought-tracking is used to explore some of the conflicting emotions that Thomas may be experiencing in having to make a decision about re-uniting with his younger brother.
16. A still image is created of Mark – up until now only represented by a boy's jacket or as a bundle for the infant Mark. Having a student volunteer to physically represent Mark is clearly an important step forward in the drama.
17. Students use forum theatre techniques to take turns in pairs at improvising the brothers' reunion conversation with the still image in front of them throughout. This exercise consistently reveals that as a result of his experiences Mark has little trust in anyone, including Thomas.
18. The students, as themselves, write to Mark, in order to convince him that they can be trusted and that they will be his friend.
19. The lullaby sung in Nyanja earlier in the drama is reprised and has the

effect of recalling the plight of Thomas during his childhood and that of Mark in his infancy.

20. A final ceremony of reconciliation involves not only the two brothers, but involves all the students in the class reading aloud their declarations of friendship to Mark, presenting him with their letters and standing in solidarity with him at the front of the classroom. The last to come forward is the student holding the role of Thomas, and he and Mark are reconciled.

From our key examples, we have compiled a list of those strategies that we think would serve well as a basic strategy tool kit. This represents a core sample only of the available forms and you may well find that you will want to add others to your particular list. However, those drawn from our key examples are:

- Brainstorming
- Captioning photographs
- Ceremony
- Defining the space
- Drawing in role
- Folk forms
- Group sculpting
- Group still image
- Individual still image
- Maps and diagrams
- Marking the moment
- Forum theatre
- Meeting
- Pictogram
- Interviews
- Mime
- Narration
- Pair work
- Reading images
- Ritual
- Slow motion
- Small group playmaking
- Sound effects
- Storytelling
- Teacher-in-role
- Thought-tracking
- Improvisation in pairs

- Whole-group improvisation
- Writing in role
- Phone conversations

Clearly, in the early stages of your working with process drama, you will find yourself more comfortable with some strategies than others. It is sensible to walk before you can run, and therefore steadily build up your repertoire – especially as some strategies are more complex than others. The most important factor is in knowing clearly about the strategies you intend to use, and the purpose you intend them to serve, in advance of the lesson. Extending your repertoire of strategies is important, not only because this will make you a more flexible teacher, able to respond more subtly to the unfolding drama, but this is essential so that you are able to introduce your students to an ever growing body of performance forms, which is the key to their developing understanding of the nature of process drama.

‘But how will I Know when to Introduce a New Strategy into a Lesson?’

As we have already suggested, the sequence of building a process drama tends to move through the four different types of strategy – context building, narrative building, deepening the experience and reflection on the drama. While following this sequence is a good rule of thumb, especially in small-scale dramas, it should not be seen as inflexible. It may well be that it is appropriate to move back and forth between the different types of strategy.

‘Won’t this Disrupt the Story?’

Well, perhaps this would be a good point to mention about the episodic nature of process drama. We would all agree, we are sure, that drama could be described as stories in action. This might lead us to suppose that events in the drama have to unfold in a chronological order. However, this is certainly not the case, just as it is not always the case in stories, and in fact if we do always stick to a mono-directional time sequence we will miss a great opportunity to construct a tight and engaging drama and restrict the students’ opportunity to explore the issues of the drama in as full a manner as might otherwise be possible. The episodic nature of drama liberates us from chronological sequence.

‘It would Help if you went Over an Example in More Detail’

To try to illustrate this a little more clearly we will expand on the breakdown of Key Example 2, the strategies for which we have already outlined earlier.

If we look in greater detail at this analysis of the drama centred on the Australian Gold Rush, we can see a wide range of strategies in use at different times, serving different functions in the drama and, sometimes, a strategy serving more than one function. What follows is a step-by-step breakdown of how the strategies were used as the drama unfolded over the ten sessions, with an explanation of why the teacher did as she did.

Analysis of the Drama

Let's begin by reminding ourselves of some of the key elements of process drama.

Process drama can be defined largely in terms of the absence of a formal written text or script. In process drama this will be 'created in action' as the drama unfolds.

In [Chapter 1](#) we argued that there are three broad areas of learning – personal and social, cross-curricular and about the art form, which spring from engagement in process drama. In Key Example 2, the Australian Gold Rush, we will see that both Strand A learning and Strand B learning are in balance. The teacher intended that the students (a) examine an area of human experience and (b) explore aspects of drama form. In addition, personal, cultural and social learning emerges from the activity as, for example, the nature of discontentment; making life-altering decisions; writing; understanding feelings; sentiment; making private thoughts public; vocal and physical engagement and expression; drawing, planning, problem-solving and so on.

key Example 2

Session 1

1 Brainstorm of reasons why people leave where they are living and go on a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the other end.

Context building

Here the students have the opportunity to discuss together and then share with the group their own understanding and opinions about why people move location and how they feel about it. It is surprising how much understanding of this children do have. In this age of culturally diverse

and mobile populations, especially in inner-city areas, many children have real life, family experiences of relocation. In fact, the class involved in the Gold Rush drama reflected a broad range of just such family experiences. Here is just a selection of their collective understanding about what motivates people to relocate: better housing, better climate, religious persecution, adventure, political instability, employment prospects, marriage, historical connections, joining family members, being a fugitive.

2 Individual still image – moment of contentment with life in London.

Context building

3 Individual still image – same role – moment of discontentment with life in London.

Context building

Having brought motivations to the forefront of the students' thinking, what follows allows them to begin to construct in their imaginations the concrete circumstances in which the first part of the drama will unfold. Having been asked by the teacher to imagine that they lived in London in the early 1850s, they are able to capture a moment of their lives there. Although it would have been possible to create just a moment of discontentment, by creating the contented moment *first*, the contrast between it and what follows throws the discontentment into higher relief, making it more meaningful. And because the students have already brainstormed reasons for relocation, the teacher has ensured that they are equipped with something on which to base the second still image.

4 Pair conversations – tell partner why discontent.

Narrative building

5 Teacher in shadowy role – as an undefined member of the public distributing the handbill (the hook – refer to [Chapter 5](#)), excitedly spreading news of gold strike and meeting in town hall about ship going to Australia – **pairs** discussing this news in role.

Narrative building

6 Whole-group improvisation – public meeting – teacher-in-role as Captain of ship and **map** of projected route from England to Australia. The Captain extols the opportunities to be taken if the Londoners will take the risk of going to Australia and promise to pay him a percentage of any gold they find. The meeting questions him closely about motives, risks, rewards, etc.

Context/narrative building

This sequence of narrative building action is deliberately constructed by the teacher to ensure that the culminating public meeting is as effective and affective as possible. By first encouraging the students to struggle to articulate their discontentment in a relatively private conversation with just one other person, the teacher has protected them into the initial establishment of a role and is priming them for their more public participation in the meeting. The next step involves the teacher taking on a role that is not fully developed, what Dorothy Heathcote has called a 'shadowy role'. This serves, largely, as a device that injects information into the drama so that it can develop further without needing to interrupt the action. It also provides the teacher with a means of activating the frame tension of the drama and the opportunity to model language and emotional engagement for the students. These in turn also provide resources to support the students in the forthcoming public meeting. The final step in this narrative building sequence is the public meeting in which the students are involved in a whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role. This time, however, the teacher's role is very clearly defined – the Captain of the ship taking passage to Australia. Once more, the teacher is using this strategy to give information to the students within the context of the drama but this time in a much more substantial manner. This is possible because of the preliminary action that has prepared the students. The teacher's active introduction of the map at this point also helps to foreshadow the forthcoming shift in context from city to ship.

7 Group still image – the moment that the Londoners, in groups, decide to go to Australia.

Deepening

This is a crucial stage of the drama. By capturing the essence of the moment of decision, the still image holds within it the potential of all that is to come in the drama – life, death, riches, ruin. However, it is also a crucial moment within the lesson from the planning point of view. The teacher has already made her professional decision that this drama is about going to Australia. Therefore, all the students in the class must go! It would not be a good idea to allow three to stay behind in London while the others go off to seek their fortunes in the gold fields. On this occasion, the teacher manages the situation by stopping the drama at the end of the public meeting when the Captain left, having instructed those willing to take the risk to sign up the following morning – first come, first served.

The students are asked to form groups of about four or five and to decide who they are in the drama, how they know each other and where they are at the moment they decide to go to Australia. This serves two purposes in the structure of the drama. First, it cuts out the possibility of not going. The teacher makes clear that some people may be going very reluctantly but nonetheless, going they are. It also provides opportunity for the students to alter the roles they have begun to develop, if they want to.

8 Reading the images – groups present their images in turn while the others, out of role, interpret what they see – who is happy, who is the powerful one, what is the relationship between the people in the groups.

Context building

Once the groups have created their still images, they present them to each other. The observers are invited to articulate what they see. On one level, this gives the students an opportunity to explore how meaning is made in drama other than through dialogue, but on the specific level of this drama it allows the contextual community of travellers to be more clearly defined. While the act of creating the images will have done this for the individual groups, it is the sharing with, and interpretation by, the others that builds the community collectively. In other words, in the dramatic context, the students, together, get to know who their travelling companions are, what sort of people they are and what sort of attitudes they hold. Within this knowledge lies further potential for the drama's development.

9 Writing in role – diary entries that night – the hopes, fears and aspirations of the travellers. These are affixed to the map on the wall near London.

Reflective

This affords the opportunity for reflection on the drama experience so far and offers a means of capturing and recording the essence of that experience.

This session uses strategies in all four categories of dramatic action: context building, narrative building, deepening and reflective. It is important in this first session that the students have a complete experience from building the context through to reflecting on the experience. However, at the outset of *any* process drama it is important to spend time creating a clearly defined context for the participants. This will pay dividends as the drama unfolds. Taking time at the beginning of a

drama (or at a point in a drama where the context changes) to give students the opportunity to suspend disbelief, build their own investment in the drama and begin to develop a sense of ownership about the drama means that it becomes 'real' for them so that when a moment of crisis occurs, they care about it, and are motivated to do something about it. However, if the story of the drama is to develop – as it must – then we also need to employ narrative building action that will give impetus to the story. Having built the context, something must happen in it! So, in this session, time is also given to developing the narrative. However, only one deepening strategy was used. This is to be expected at the beginning of a drama because in order to fully engage on a symbolic level with the meaning of the drama, there has to have been some drama first. It is also important that the students are left with a sense of closure at the end of the session and this is provided by the individual reflection given by writing in role. But by attaching these personal reflections to the large wall map, we begin to build our collective reflection on, and memory of, the drama. As the drama unfolds over subsequent sessions, the map becomes a means by which the drama can be held in suspended animation, as it were, until the next session begins.

Having annotated this session in great detail, we hope that it is possible to see how important it is for the teacher to change the type of strategies in order to achieve specific planning and learning objectives within the drama. The important thing is to remember that some of these will have more to do with the nature of the drama itself and others will have to do with other curriculum objectives. In reading the following session descriptions, see if you can identify their planning and learning objectives.

Session 2

10 Whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role on the quayside signing up for passage – **TIR** stressing can't take much on board.

Context building and narrative building

11 Drawing in role – keepsakes – tell others near you what it is and why it is precious to you – add to map on wall.

Deepening

12 Individual mime – packing your small case of personal belongings.

Deepening

13 Still images plus thought-tracking – what is going through your mind as you leave for the ship – speak, then move to meeting point.

Deepening and reflective

14 Whole-group improvisation with TIR – getting on board.

Narrative building

15 Polaroid photos of each group at foot of gangway – write group **caption** for picture summing up group feelings – put on map.

Deepening and reflective

16 Writing in role – diary entries, first night on ship – put on map.

Reflective

In this session, considerably less time needs to be spent on context building action than in Session 1. The context of the quayside is a natural continuation of the foundation that has already been laid. More time can be given over to deepening and reflective action. This will most fully enable the students to engage with the enormity of their decision to leave, as well as the emotional dimension implicit within their prospective departure. Again, the combination of diary entries and the map provides both individual and collective reflection.

Session 3

17 Small group playmaking – the first thing to go wrong; *and*

18 Sharing the incidents – named by the whole group – place of incident marked on map and name written on.

Narrative building

This session is important in moving the story forward. The journey to Australia in the nineteenth century was both long and hazardous. The challenges to people in passage were great. Developing the narrative in this part of the story ensures that the epic nature of the voyage becomes clearer to the students. It is important to recognise that the teacher has not decided on what these incidents are. This strengthens the students' hold on the drama – they have ownership of it – and this provides the commitment and motivation to engage with the learning inherent within the drama.

Session 4

19 Out of role discussion – one of the incidents selected by whole group to explore consequences – outbreak of infectious disease; *and*

20 Whole-group improvisation with TIR – ship meeting to decide what to do.

Narrative building

21 Ritual – burial at sea – thought-tracking as body is buried.

Deepening

22 Writing in role – diary entry that night – add to map around point where incident was marked.

Deepening and reflective

Narrative action moves the story forward, but the affective is at work in the deepening and reflective aspects of the drama; most notably, in this session, in the ritual of burial at sea.

Session 5

23 Celebration – ship free from disease. **Story telling** of other celebrations attended – trying to guess what Australia will be like – what to do with the gold when found.

Deepening and reflective

24 Storm at Sea – **small group discussion** – out of role decide story of what happened to your travelling group in your part of the ship during storm.

Narrative building

25 Group still image of most important or dangerous moment of the story; *and*

26 Add two more still images – one a few moments before and another a few moments after; *and*

27 Put together in series of three still images; *and*

28 Add a line of dialogue for each person in each image; *and*

29 Bring still images to life in slow motion and string together in continuous sequence of movement – add **dialogue;** *and*

30 Whole class perform storm sequences consecutively – rest of class **creating sounds** of storm when not showing their episode.

Deepening

31 Ceremony – giving thanks for salvation from the storm.

Deepening and reflective

32 Writing in role – diary entries that night – add to the map at the location of the storm.

Reflective

In this session, there is deep engagement with the art form of drama. The storm at sea represents one of the most climactic moments of the story. It is also one of the moments that, for the teacher, holds the greatest danger of failing. If we return to what we were saying in [Chapter 6](#) on frame, we will recall that we have gone to some lengths to explain the necessity of ensuring that the participants in the drama have one foot on firm ground. So, in Session 1, although the students did not have experience of being Londoners in the nineteenth century, they all knew about feeling fed up and discontented at times. This meant that they could enter the drama with a frame of communication. However, in this session, the teacher is deliberately setting out to remove the firm ground. The frame is shifted from 'discontentment' to 'facing the dangers of a raging storm'. Fortunately, this is an experience beyond the students but, for the teacher, it poses the dilemma of how best to make the storm happen in a manner that will enhance the drama rather than detract from it. Whole-group improvisation, even with teacher-in-role, would not be satisfactory here. The students would merely invent superficially and externally without any emotional connection with experience. The result would be in danger of becoming chaotic and of losing the hard-won structure and depth of engagement achieved by the students in the preceding sessions. However, by choosing to create the storm in an incremental manner using elements of performance, the teacher protects the students in the experience by imposing a 'real life' frame in which they have to come to grips with aspects of theatricality, e.g. slow motion, sound effects, dialogue.

Session 6

33 Arrival in Australia – disembarking from the ship – **teacher narration** and **whole-class mime** of gathering belongings.

Context building

34 Photographs of disembarkation – polaroids – write **caption** and add to map.

Context building and deepening

35 Writing in role – letters home – add to map.

Reflective

36 Whole-group improvisation and TIR – meeting to decide what to do about getting to gold fields – three possible routes – which way to go? Debating the pros and cons – stick together or separate (the students in fact decided to stick together).

Narrative building

37 Writing in role – diary entries – feelings on the decision – add to map.

Reflective

This session sees the beginning of a new section of the drama. The teacher, therefore, needs to build the new context through the transition from the ship to the land. It is also important that the teacher helps the students to find a sense of completion of the first phase of the journey. So the photographs and the letters home allow them to reflect upon what has happened. It would have been possible, here, to have moved straight into a narrative building strategy. However, the pausing to reflect on what had happened also held within it all that was yet to come and so made the next shift, moving the story of the drama forward, all the more significant and meaningful.

Session 7

38 Journey through the mountains – using same strategy as for the storm at sea.

Narrative building and deepening

The students wanted their progress through the mountains to be impeded by difficulties and decided to create those difficulties – broken wagon wheels, lame horses, the loss of water barrels – by using the same way of working that had been used to make the storm at sea. This is a good example of the students taking full responsibility, not only for developing

the story of the drama but also for the artistic decision of how to make the story come to life, and building on the techniques they had begun to develop during the storm at sea episode. The teacher's role in this session was as a facilitator helping the students to turn their ideas into action.

Session 8

39 Arrival in the gold fields – **whole-group improvisation with TIR** – taking leave of each other as we separate to stake our claims.

Narrative building

40 Staking claims – defining the space by taping claims on floor.

Context building

41 **Writing in role** – diary entry that night – add to map.

Reflective

42 Teacher narration and **small group mime** – finding gold.

Narrative building

43 **Writing in role** – letters home telling of conditions and success.

Reflective

This session sees the culmination of the journey for the travellers. Once again, the context of the drama changes and with that comes the need for a strategy to signal that change. This could have been done in a number of ways but the teacher's choice of 'defining the space' works on two levels. First, it is an effective strategy for context building, *per se*. However, in addition to being appropriate in technical terms, it also suits the story of the drama – the need for the newcomers, literally, to stake their claim to land. So, taping the claims on the floor works at both levels simultaneously. The teacher's decision to narrate the finding of gold is significant. She recognised the need to ensure that this incident was as dramatically powerful and meaningful as possible. By drawing on her own storytelling and drama skills at this stage, she was able to endow the moment with significance and feeling.

Sessions 9 and 10

44 Out of role – **marking the moment** – individually go to that part of the map that shows the most important part of the drama for you and sharing

with the others the reasons for your choice.

Reflective

45 Monument to the Gold Seekers – reflection on journey – in groups create a **statue** that symbolises the experiences of the travellers – add an **inscription** to go round plinth – share with other groups – polaroids of statues – add to the map.

Deepening and reflective

The last two sessions of this unit of work were focused on drawing together the whole experience. This could have been achieved in a number of ways. The teacher could, for example, have chosen to end the drama in the gold fields by using ‘ceremony’ as a strategy to create a huge celebration to mark the finding of gold. However, if we return to the original theme or learning area for this drama, we will remember that the work was focused on ‘what makes human beings give up what they know and take a long and difficult journey in the hope of something better at the end?’ In essence, the drama was more concerned with the endeavour of the journey and less with the arrival and the gold – essential though these elements were to the drama. So, it was important for the overall learning goal to find means to complete the work. This gave prominence to the endurance of the travellers in the story of the drama and yet also gave the students opportunity to be somewhat distanced from the experience, so they could reflect on the more universal relevance of what they had done. Marking the moment out of role and sharing with the class the reasons for that moment’s significance provided a reflective distance. The students were commenting as *themselves* on the experience of the people whom they had been *in role*. And, in creating the modern-day memorials to the travellers, the students were tasked with *symbolically* representing the *essence* of the experience in a way that would communicate the meaning to others who had not made the journey.

Through this detailed examination of a process drama, we have tried to make clear the factors the teacher took into consideration in order to build the drama. We also wanted to make clear the necessity of understanding the consequences of those choices in terms of how the drama develops and in terms of the challenges different strategies present to the students.

‘It Seems Like a Huge Piece of Work, I’m not sure I Could Plan all this’

Well, the manner in which the drama is described may well make it seem an overwhelming planning task, but please remember that we have put down the drama in its entirety and you have read it all at once. In reality, of course, the entire drama was *not* planned out before the first session. Had it been, it would have been a less satisfactory experience for the students. The teacher, by planning every moment of every session in advance, would have cut out the possibility for any contribution by the students to develop the shape and direction of their work, so undermining one of the cornerstones of process drama. In fact, although she made the key planning decisions necessary to enable the drama to start – learning area, dramatic context, roles, frame and sign – as we have illustrated in earlier chapters, the teacher actually planned each session in the light of the one that had gone before – good practice in our view. This made the whole exercise more manageable for her, but also more effective for the students' learning.

As the unit of work unfolded, the teacher was able to make an informed choice of strategies, often together with the students, in order to bring the drama to life, *session by session*.

‘Does this Mean we’ve Covered Everything? You’ve not Really Mentioned Early Years or Special Needs.’

It's true that we have not referred to these specifically. However, in the next chapter we will take the opportunity to revisit the planning principles and to examine an example from each of these two areas.

Planning for Diverse Learning Groups

KEY QUESTION: ‘Can process drama work in a pre-school class or a special-needs class?’

Let’s begin with process drama in the early years.

As we mentioned at the beginning of this book, children are predisposed to learn dramatically. As human beings we are ‘wired’ for it and we will all be familiar with young children’s dramatic playing whether we are parents, siblings or are remembering our own childhood. We know that good early years practice recognises this. As you are reading, in pre-school settings around the world there will be young children who are pretending to be people other than themselves in places other than they are, enabled by their imaginations and the contents of a dressing-up box or a role-play corner.

‘Doesn’t this Mean that they are doing Process Drama Already?’

Well, no it doesn’t. Dramatic playing certainly holds within it the seeds of process drama but there are some things that are not in place, yet, that need to be added in order to move it forward for it to become drama. While, of course, recognising the integral role that free dramatic playing has in the development of children and stressing the importance of the provision of opportunities that encourage it, we would like to suggest that, alongside it, process drama can provide experiences and opportunities that can go beyond those offered just by dramatic playing. In order for this to happen as teachers/leaders we have to provide the extra ingredients to make the transition necessary to bring the process drama into being.

‘So what Exactly are those Extra Ingredients?’

They are, namely, *structure*, *tension* and *collective participation*. At the beginning of the book we pointed out that the many forms of drama all share the common elements of theatre that give them structure and that key among them is dramatic tension. In fact, [Chapter 6](#) is devoted to the discussion of frame, which is the principle of process drama that generates dramatic tension and its concomitant imperative for active participation. In addition, we hope we have made clear that drama by its nature is a social art form that is born of the collective co-creativity of its participants. Now, while undoubtedly some children may instinctively weave dramatic tension into their dramatic playing, it is by no means certain that this will happen. If this remains the case, then the opportunities and challenges of *drama* will not be available to them.

Moreover, even when there is more than one participant, often the children will play *alongside* each other, sharing the same pretend space, but not necessarily *with* each other. In other words, there is a distinct likelihood that with, for example, four children in the role-play area, while they may engage in joint dramatic playing, it is just as likely that two, three or four separate fictions will be taking place. So, if the teacher has made the professional decision that the children would benefit from the experience of process drama, then she needs to do something to ensure that a dramatic structure is developed, that dramatic tension is embedded and that the children engage collectively in the shared fiction.

‘So how can this be Done?’

The most simple and effective means to achieve the transition from dramatic playing to process drama is through teacher participation in the drama by working in role with the children. We discussed teacher-in-role in some detail in [Chapter 5](#) and included two brief examples taken from early years, but here we are going to take a full-blown process drama example and set it against the planning principles and key questions. You will see that the significant difference between this example and the one we included about ‘Sue’ not being able to dress herself properly is that on this occasion the teacher planned for the children to be in role as people other than themselves from the outset.

Early Years – Drama With 4-Year-Olds

Theme/Learning Area

'With which area of human experience do I want the children to engage?'

Actions have Consequences

Background

Three groups of 4-year-old children in the pre-school early years setting attached to a village primary school. These lively groups of children had little experience of process drama although they had considerable experience of dramatic playing in the role-play area of the classroom. The dramas all took place in the role-play area over the course of a morning and each group found its own solution to the central dilemma of the drama.

Reasons for Choice Theme

Being sensitive to the needs, views and feelings of others is a key pre-school learning area and the teacher wished to promote this and to provide an opportunity for the children to work cooperatively to solve problems by developing their imaginative role-play into drama.

Context

'Which particular circumstances will be created by the drama to explore the theme?'

A roadworks 'hole in the ground' outside the house in which an elderly lady lives with her cat

Reason for Choice of Context

The children in this early years setting were all used to playing in the role-play area. The teacher regularly set up different environments in it but these tended to be domestic or retail – a kitchen, a post office, a greengrocers and so on. She wanted to find a dramatic context that would provide the opportunity for the children to recognise that as human beings we need to take responsibility for our collective actions as well as our individual actions. In order to do this she needed to create circumstances in which a number of people, collectively, might act in a way that had an impact on someone else. She also recognised that the drama would have a greater effect if the context she chose was different to any she had already established for the children

over time in the role-play area. Moreover, especially given the age of the children, it was important for her to locate the drama in circumstances in which she could be involved in the fiction as the person affected by the collective actions of the others rather than have one of the children exposed in that way and also to ensure that she was working inside the fiction to support and challenge the children as they engaged with process drama.

A further consideration influencing the choice of context was again related to the age of the children and the teacher wanted to ensure the context held within it the possibility of including physical activity as well as thinking and talking.

Finally, it was important to find a set of circumstances that were to some extent recognisable to the children and held the possibility of events that were meaningful to them.

Roles

Children's roles – 'Who are the children going to be in the drama?'

Utility maintenance workers

Reasons for Choice of Children's Roles

There had been an ongoing series of roadworks in the village in which the school was located. Workers had been carrying out essential maintenance work on the gas supply infrastructure and it had caused considerable inconvenience and disruption to the residents. The children were very aware of what had been happening and had been excited by all the activity. The teacher determined, therefore, that turning the role-play area into a roadworks would be attractive to the children who, because of their recent lived experience, would be able to behave authentically from the outset because they knew about hard hats, digging, pneumatic drills, spades and holes in the ground. Further she felt that these roles offered the appropriate potential for physical activity and a set of circumstances in which the theme could be readily addressed because the effects of the real roadworks had had consequences for the local community and the children had had some experience of these.

Teacher's role – 'Who are you going to be in the drama?'

Elderly resident of house outside which the roadworks is taking place

Reasons for Choice of Teacher's Role

At first thought, it might seem that the obvious choice for the teacher's role would be the person in charge of the workers. This would provide a high-status role inside the fiction to direct the children's actions. However, as we discussed in [Chapter 5](#), placing yourself in a high-status role tends to undermine what the drama is striving to achieve; that is empowering the participants to contribute to the shape and direction of their own learning and confront them with the decision-making, researching, problem-solving and team working necessary to resolve the central dilemma of the drama.

By choosing instead to take the role of an elderly lady with a cat whose life has been disrupted by the roadworks, the teacher has placed herself in a position to challenge what the workers are doing but without the power to order them to do something different. The absent 'boss' means that the children in role as the workers will be thrown back on *themselves* to resolve the issue that has emerged as a result of the actions they have taken in carrying out their duties.

Frame

'Which viewpoint will the roles have in order to create tension in the drama and how distanced do the roles need to be?'

Utility workers **who in carrying out their duties are also causing cruelty to a cat**

Reasons for Choice of Frame

We stressed again at the beginning of this chapter the importance of dramatic tension in turning dramatic playing into process drama with a reminder of the contents of [Chapter 6](#). In that chapter we emphasised the necessity of moving participants in a process drama from a common interest, generated by the way in which the roles are bound together, to a collective concern generated through the addition of investment, which, in turn, generates a commitment to resolving the central dilemma of the drama.

Now, this might seem an unnecessarily subtle planning consideration for working with these pre-school children but in fact this is not so. If we recognise the benefits to learning that come from participation in a process drama, even for young children, then we have to ensure that we embed the necessary elements to ensure that drama is created. That means making sure the roles are framed within the drama.

So, in planning this drama the teacher needed to find something that would

be meaningful to the children. The context and roles had a resonance for the children because of their real life experiences in the village but the teacher had to find the dilemma. By drawing on the children's love of animals, and combining that with the children's emergent understanding about workers have to do the job they are being paid to do, she was able to create the situation in which the utility workers were torn between doing their job – digging the hole in front of the lady's house and so preventing her from going to the shop to buy cat food – and making sure that the cat had something to eat. This precipitated the children into striving to find solutions for the dilemma and putting them into action.

Sign

'What artefacts, personal items, sounds, images, documents and so on will I need to bring significance to the events of the drama?'

Large irregular piece of black paper stuck on floor to represent the hole, an item such as an old-fashioned gate-legged clothes horse to represent a safety barrier, a large sign to hang on the barrier saying DANGER, safety hats, a walking stick and an empty cat food tin

Reasons for Choice of Signs

As we discussed in [Chapter 7](#), signs provide the means by which we can direct the focus of the participants to the heart of a process drama by physically and symbolically demonstrating the tension that is provided by the frame. We examined how the teacher needs to prepare a range of signs that will serve a range of different purposes in helping to create the drama – a hook to propel the participants immediately into the drama, another prepared sign that holds within it potential, of which the participants may yet be unaware, and teacher sign that conveys the role that the teacher is playing in the drama (TIR). In this drama the teacher needed to hook the children into the dramatic context very obviously from the outset of the drama and she achieved this by effectively creating the roadworks site by means of the black paper, safety barrier and hard hats. The inclusion of the DANGER sign had a latent potency that she knew she would evoke as the drama progressed and she used the walking stick and empty cat food tin to convey the key aspects of her own role for the drama.

Strategies

Which ways of working will I use? In which combination? For what purpose?

Mime, whole-group improvisation, teacher-in-role, meeting

Reasons for Choice of Strategies

The ranges of strategies used in the running examples that appear in earlier chapters are identified in [Chapter 8](#). A quick look back will show that each teacher employed a considerable number in the course of her drama. This was not the case, however, in this pre-school drama and for two very good reasons. First, it was a single session drama and second, in all three versions, the drama only lasted between 10 and 15 minutes. Even if the use of more had been desirable, the attention span of the children prevented the inclusion of more.

This does not mean, however, that the drama we are discussing here is any less of a process drama than, for example, the Gold Rush drama that took place over 10 sessions and employed 45 different changes of strategy. You will remember we stressed earlier that the strategies the teacher chooses need to be appropriate to evoke the particular aspects of the drama that are most needed for enabling learning. We discussed how at times we may need to appropriately build context, move the narrative forward, deepen the experience by moving beyond the plot or provide the opportunity to reflect on the experience. In the space of 10 minutes and using just four strategies the teacher achieved this.

We hope that you can see from this example that process drama can provide an engaging learning experience that moves children beyond their own dramatic playing with the support and participation of the teacher/leader – provided she recognises that the planning considerations that apply in preparing work with learners in the compulsory years of schooling also apply to working with children in the pre-school and early years.

‘Have you Forgotten about Special Needs?’

Not at all. We are now going to turn our attention to an example from this very area.

Primary Special Needs – Drama With 8- to 9-Year-Olds

Theme/Learning Area

'With which area of human experience do I want the children to engage?'

Humans can Shape their Environments

Background

This group of about ten children included individuals with a broad range of learning disabilities, as well as mobility and physical challenges. The 90-minute session was conducted away from their normal school environment in Jamaica as part of a drama-teaching demonstration in which four or five of their teachers also participated. So, this drama lesson was really operating on two levels. First, the teacher leading it was committed to ensuring that the young participants with special needs were as fully engaged with the drama as possible, and second, that the participating teachers would have the opportunity to learn something about the general principles of using drama in an educational setting.

Reasons for the Choice of Theme

The school that the participating students attended catered specifically for children with major learning and intellectual challenges, and had a long tradition of enabling the students to live as independently as possible in their daily lives, while also eventually preparing them for the world of work. An area of vocational expertise to which many of the students were exposed as they got older was that of plant care and propagation and landscaping. The teacher leading the lesson was guided by the notion that pursuing a theme along the lines of 'humans can have a positive impact on their environment' would provide the young participants with opportunities to participate in active tasks and to experience empowerment as part of the unfolding drama.

Context

'Which particular circumstances will be created by the drama to explore the theme?'

A garden that needs to be cultivated, but where Sam the gardener is missing

Reason for Choice of Context

The children participating in this lesson came to it with very little experience of process drama and appeared to be somewhat dependent on their teachers and teaching assistants with respect to communication, assistance with

mobility, etc. The teacher, therefore, selected a dramatic context with which the students could not only engage with minimal assistance, but which also provided opportunities for them to give help to another person. The fact that the gardener was missing immediately presented the participants in the drama with the simple task of 'trying to find Sam'; an activity in which everyone could participate.

Roles

Children's roles

'Who are the children going to be in the drama?'

Assistant Landscape Gardeners

Reasons for Choice of Children's Roles

Because the children were familiar with the sight of older students looking after plants and landscaping the grounds in and around their school, the teacher felt that they would be able to assume the roles of gardeners themselves quite easily. The selected roles also were able to accommodate a broad range of tasks and activities, and presented the opportunity for the children to focus on their individual abilities. Taking the roles of gardeners also opened up possibilities for the children to experience a proactive helping relationship in which they were now giving assistance and were no longer the main recipients of help. The teacher also felt that decision-making and problem-solving were also likely to be a main feature of the activities of the roles selected.

Teacher's role

'Who are you going to be in the drama?'

The owner of the garden whose gardener is missing

In addition, the teacher leading this drama also facilitated another teacher in 'full role' as Sam, the missing gardener

Reasons for Choice of Teacher's Role

The facilitating teacher wanted to ease the children into the drama experience by slowing down the pace and making use of repetition in order to include all of them in the main activity. The teacher-in-role as the owner of the uncultivated garden was able to introduce a problem to the children, since

Sam the gardener was missing and no work had been done. Although the teacher took on the role of the owner, which at first glance might appear to be a high-status role, it is, in fact, a low-status role since it is used to depict a person who is in need of help. When invited to give assistance the children readily agreed, since the first order of business was simply to help to find Sam. In addition, the role of the owner of the garden presented rich opportunities for grumbling and complaining, and generally maintaining the tension.

The facilitating teacher also worked in a team-teaching situation with a second teacher in 'full role' as Sam the delinquent gardener. The full role, when introduced in this way, usually maintains the characteristics of the role throughout the drama and does not actively influence the direction in which the drama will unfold. The ability to negotiate shifts in the dramatic action remains with the teacher-in-role, who can also come out of role when required. The full role remains in role throughout and is facilitated by the teacher who is leading the session. The attitude of Sam the gardener throughout the drama indicated that he needed someone to show him what he was supposed to do to plant out the garden.

Frame

'Which viewpoint will the roles have in order to create tension in the drama and how distanced do the roles need to be?'

Assistant gardeners **who must teach the Head Gardener what he is supposed to do**

Reasons for Choice of Frame

After moving into an early helping relationship with the teacher-in-role as the distressed owner of the garden, eventually the children were faced with a serious dilemma when the teacher in the full role of Sam clearly indicated that he had no idea what he was supposed to do to landscape the garden. The owner had indicated to the children that her friends 'Jane and Louisa' were coming to visit and that she wanted to have the garden looking beautiful by the time they arrived. So the main ideas were laid in slowly until it gradually became clear to the children that they would have to show Sam what to do if the garden was to be ready in time. Because the children in this case needed time to work at their own pace, however, the idea of a deadline as a tension giver, while used, was not over-emphasised.

Sign

'What artefacts, personal items, sounds, images, documents and so on will I need to bring significance to the events of the drama?'

Large black plastic refuse bags, scrap paper in an assortment of colours, safety scissors, markers, plastic carrier bags in assorted colours, string, bunting, glue sticks, straw hat, digging fork

Reasons for Choice of Signs

The use of clear signing for this particular group of students was critical. Black plastic refuse bags were laid out to represent empty flower beds, along with Sam the gardener's straw hat and gardening fork. The hat and tool indicated Sam's 'present absence', while the flower beds foreshadowed the gardening tasks to come. So much of this drama involved the students in the generation of their own sign in the construction of the garden. The materials, paper, markers, bunting needed to bring the garden into existence and make it 'bloom' were carefully withheld until the students needed them. There was an inner logic to the fact that the flower beds could be moved around and positioned where the children wanted them, and the paper and plastic bag 'flowers' could also be rearranged at will. There was also something quite mythical about one boy who participated in the drama and decided that he would become the Sun by standing on a chair and holding up a plastic disc.

Strategies

'Which ways of working will I use? In which combination? For what purpose?'

Teacher-in-role, plus team-teaching with a teacher in full role, brainstorming, meeting, whole-group improvisation, folk forms, defining the space

Reasons for Choice of Strategies

The range of strategies used in this example was largely in response to the particular requirements of the needs of the children participating in the drama. By taking a low-status role, the teacher was able to work within the drama to focus the students on the tasks at hand. These included establishing the nature of the situation by carrying out the search for Sam the gardener, spending a lot of time waking him up and trying to get him to work; developing the narrative by interacting with Sam as assistant gardeners and trying to explain to him what he was supposed to do; deepening the

experience by helping Sam with the landscaping, including arranging the flower beds and making the flowers, the trees and sun; and finally reflecting on their experience by escorting Jane and Louisa (played by two of the participating teachers) around the garden, while singing a traditional Jamaican folk song of the same name.

It is hoped that this brief outline of a drama lesson with children with special needs will illustrate that the planning principles developed throughout this book can, with some careful consideration, apply equally to a whole range of diverse learning situations.

‘Why is it Important for Process Drama to be Adaptable to Diverse Learning Situations?’

In recent years there has been an increased awareness of the diversity of needs of all children, youth and adults, and an accompanying emphasis on inclusion in education. Inclusive education attempts to address and respond to this diversity of needs by identifying ways of increasing participation in learning, cultures and communities, and reducing and eliminating exclusion from education. Even teachers working in what they perceive to be mainstream schools face the challenge of becoming more inclusive; that is, becoming better at educating *all* children in their communities. This might involve making changes and modifications in content, approaches, structures and strategies, with a common vision that covers all children of the appropriate age range and a conviction that it is the responsibility of the regular system to educate all children.

While many of the examples in this book have been drawn from process drama conducted in mainstream schools, our own personal experiences have brought us into contact with many different learning populations. Early childhood education and teaching for special needs are often considered to be areas of specialisation in education, separate and apart from the general primary or secondary phases. Special needs may include a broad spectrum of constituents from blind and visually challenged individuals, to those who are deaf or hearing impaired or who face a range of physical challenges or learning difficulties. Some of these are reflected in the examples outlined above. But we live in an age of increasing diversity, whether as a result of migration, changing social values, wars and civil disruptions. Indeed, our own teaching experiences have involved us working with many diverse learning groups ranging from adult patients in hospice settings, to linguistic minorities, or extending from nurse-education trainers to ‘invisible’ (i.e. socially withdrawn) children.

The international challenge of including more people in education extends to children not enrolled in schools, children and young people with disabilities, working children, those living in isolated rural areas, those affected by HIV/AIDS and other health conditions, or even situations in which the issue of gender plays a significant role in their exclusion from formal learning. Added to these are situations where many young people leave school with no useful qualifications, or who drop out of school because they feel it is irrelevant. So, inclusive schools have to develop ways of teaching that respond to individual differences and which, therefore, benefit all children. They also need to change attitudes and form the basis for a just and non-discriminatory society. We believe that process drama, because it is so versatile, can make a major contribution to carrying out many of these adjustments and changes.

‘But why is Process Drama Particularly Effective in Promoting Inclusive Education?’

It seems to us that, fundamentally, it is precisely because process drama can be made to work in schools as an inclusive pedagogy that not only welcomes diversity but also accommodates it. We referred at the beginning of this book to the cornerstones of process drama, one of which was the symbolic representation of human experience, which referred in more specific terms to the ways in which humans use drama to symbolically represent life experiences and make comment on them. What is most critical, however, is that process drama uses a wide variety of forms of representation that offer learners a choice of approaches when accessing information. In other words, it presents learners with an opportunity to acquire their knowledge in different ways. Again this was highlighted in [Chapter 7](#) where we made reference to Jerome Bruner’s classification of symbolic, iconic and enactive systems of representation. The teacher’s awareness and application of these can prove to be invaluable in making the shift towards a more inclusive education.

Similarly, process drama uses different forms of action and expression to enable learners to both demonstrate and interrogate their knowledge in different ways. These too are outlined as available strategies in [Chapter 8](#), which allow both the teacher and students to choose different ways of working that can be tailored to support a wide range of preferred learning styles.

And finally, the careful selection of sign in the drama, in conjunction with the application of a broad range of strategies, creates different forms of engagement that, as we have also seen, serve to attract and deepen the

interest of learners. These can also work towards challenging students in their assumptions and motivating them towards higher levels of problem-solving and decision-making.

Process drama works in promoting inclusive education by increasing students' autonomy in making individual choices. Additionally, because of the social nature of the art form it tends to foster both collaboration and communication, while at the same time it continues to contribute to the building of group consensus. Through their participation in process drama, learners are encouraged to generate critical feedback to both the teacher and their peers. This, in turn, enhances the relevance, value and authenticity of the students' drama work through personal interpretation, while simultaneously motivating them towards greater sustained effort and continued persistence through shared, creative endeavour.

‘So have we Covered just about Everything Now?’

Well, we have now discussed using process drama within a broad range of learning situations, as well as each of the planning principles in turn, so, in one sense we have. If you have addressed each of those principles in your planning, then you are ready to put your plan into practice and bring the drama to life. The next chapter deals with key points to help you *make the drama happen*.

Making it Happen!

KEY QUESTION: 'Am I ready to begin?'

Well, almost! There are, however, some things still left to organise before you are quite ready, the first of which is the negotiation of the drama 'learning contract'.

'What does that Mean?'

This is actually a prerequisite for engaging in process drama. It is really a way of describing the relationship between the teacher and her class and is informed by her understanding of that cornerstone of process drama which holds that learners who have a sense of ownership about their learning, have a greater commitment to it, and therefore gain more from it as a result.

We've already pointed out in [Chapter 5](#) that process drama may sometimes require the teacher to renegotiate some of the ground rules of her classroom with her students. We have tried to stress that process drama implies a relationship between teacher and students that is based on a collaborative approach to the learning. It rests on a partnership in which the teacher doesn't present herself as 'the one who knows all'. Rather, the learning contract will be one which recognises that both teacher and students need to contribute to the creation and development of the drama and identifies the expectations of both. It imposes responsibilities on students and teacher alike to fulfil their parts of the bargain, but by so doing also creates the circumstances from which both parties can gain benefits. It makes clear that, if the demands of the contract are not fulfilled, *on both sides*, the drama experience will be lessened.

'I'm not sure about this'

It is quite common for teachers who are new to process drama to imagine that they need to have a whole collection of skills that they do not have at present. They worry that drama teaching requires attributes that only a few teachers have. They particularly focus on their lack of experience in drama, especially acting, and conclude that this means they are unable to teach drama. As we stressed when discussing teacher-in-role, this is not true.

Of course, there are particular skills and attitudes that are necessary for a teacher to have if she is going to work successfully in process drama, but we would argue very strongly that these are the skills and attitudes that are the hallmark of *all* good teachers. They are centred on the view that the teacher has of herself within the learning process – a view that sees the teacher in a learning partnership with the students she teaches.

We wish to underline that teaching drama does *not* encourage any negation of responsibility on the part of the teacher. The view of drama in education as an activity in which the teacher was concerned with giving students carte blanche to ‘express themselves’ is one which no longer has currency. We will always carry the ultimate, professional responsibility for what happens in our classrooms, and we will always need to make informed decisions about the direction of our students’ learning. However, within these parameters, the type of relationship we need to develop with them to create the climate in which process drama may flourish will be one of ‘colleagueness’. This climate will have an impact on the manner in which the teacher negotiates with her students, structures her questions to them and her responses to those they ask. If you have already established this sort of working relationship with your class you are well on your way to negotiating the drama ‘learning contract’.

However, particularly if both you and your class are new to process drama, you will need to make *explicit* the contract between you. This is important for several reasons. First, we are inviting students to have feet in two worlds simultaneously – their own real world and the fictional world of the drama – and the learning contract helps participants to recognise the boundaries of each so that they are able to behave appropriately. Second, the contract will ensure that everyone knows what is expected of everyone else, so strengthening the sense of the drama as a shared experience with shared benefits and shared responsibilities. Third, the contract gives a point of reference for reflection upon the experience so that, as a group, it is possible to see how well everyone has lived up to the contract and how they might move forward next time.

‘So how do I Make the Contract with the Students?’

It might be useful to provide a short set of key points that will help you to

develop the contract.

You will need to agree to:

- accept that students will contribute meaningfully to the shape and direction of their own learning;
- be ready to withhold some of your knowledge from time to time so that the students can develop and demonstrate theirs;
- ask the sorts of questions that are open and invite genuine responses from the students: these will often be indirect or ‘musing’ – ‘I’ve often wondered about ...’, ‘Can anyone think of ...’, ‘Does anyone here have experience of this sort of situation?’;
- be prepared to weave into the fabric of the drama the contributions of the students;
- make clear to the students what they are doing and why – never ‘con’ them, accept that they need to know that it’s drama;
- protect students into the experience by sensitive choices of material and ways of working.

The students will need to agree to:

- accept that working in drama is serious;
- accept that each has something to offer and respect the contributions of others;
- accept that drama is about thinking and feeling as well as action;
- behave in a manner that is appropriate;
- be ready to take responsibility for helping to shape the direction of the drama.

You all will need to agree to:

- a set of rules to help the drama to ‘run’ – for example, signals for pausing the drama;
- recognise that everyone needs to work together for the common good of the drama;
- be willing to trust each other;
- be willing to make an effort;
- be willing to take a risk with the knowledge that everyone will support the drama to develop;
- accept that you all need to develop a consensus about what is happening in the drama because the drama belongs to you all.

‘Am I there, Now?’

Well, by following the planning principles that we have described in the

previous chapters, you will now have decided what the learning area for the drama is, having taken into account curriculum demands and the availability of time and space; the dramatic context in which it is to happen; the roles that both you and the students are going to take; the frame that will provide the dramatic tension and distance the students; the signs that you are going to use to bring significance to the drama and focus the students' attention on the learning area, and you will have decided on the different ways of working you are going to use. You will also have negotiated the ground rules for the work with the students through the drama learning contract.

As we pointed out at the end of [Chapter 2](#), sometimes ideas will overlap or pop into your mind simultaneously or in a different planning order to the one we have set out. Although this may seem confusing, don't worry as long as you have each element included in the plan. Selection of the learning area must always come first, but it doesn't matter if you have thought of roles before context, provided that you have chosen roles that will lead the students to the learning area.

However, while having all these elements in place is good, something else must happen before they become drama.

[Figure 10.1](#) provides a construction kit with which to build the drama. If you imagine it as an engine, made up of different parts, it is now fully fuelled and ready to go but, actually, it won't go until you have added the spark plug and switched it on. This is the position you are in now. You have the engine but still need the *spark* to ignite the drama – *to make it happen*. You need to find a mechanism for switching the drama on.

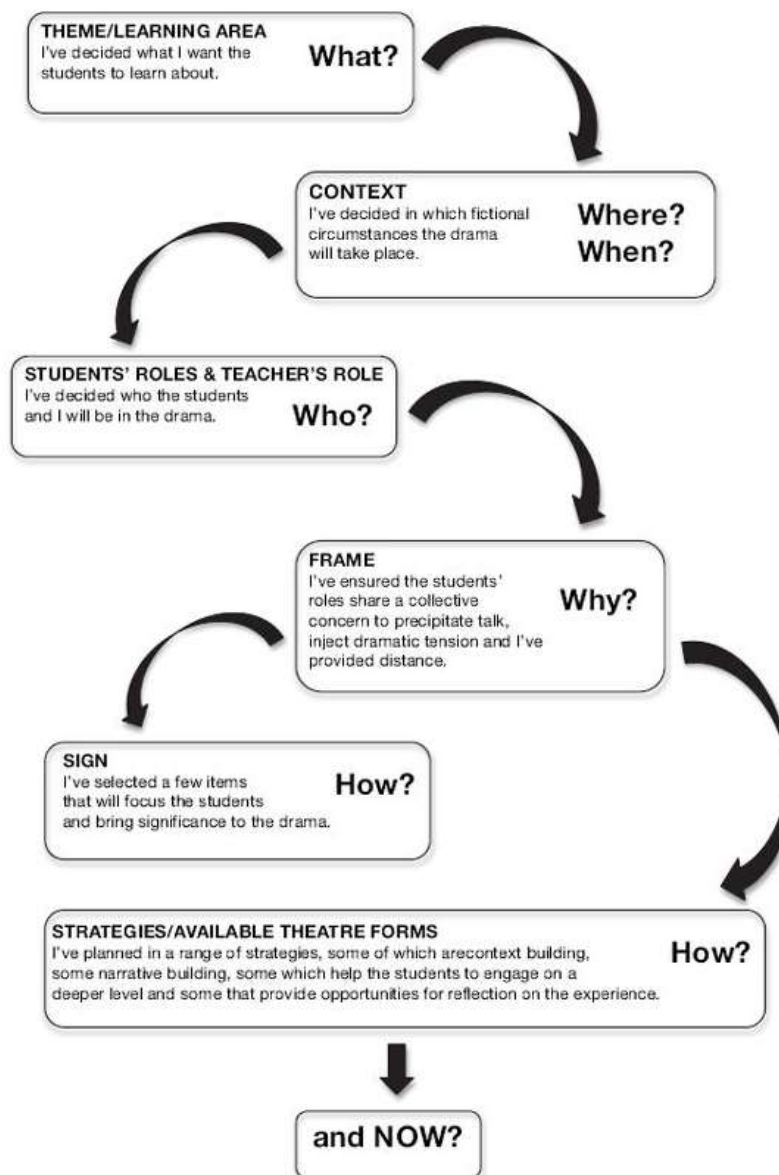


Figure 10.1 The process drama engine

To look at it in another way, you've now arrived at the moment when you say 'and now the drama is going to begin'. The big question is, 'How do I make it happen?' The answer is that you need to move into what is known as the '*now time* of the drama'.

'What does this Mean?'

Well, put simply, it means that drama happens in the *present moment*. If we

remember that drama can be described as ideas in action, it is obvious that action happens now, in the present moment. We can talk about what action will take place in the future; we can talk about what action has taken place in the past; but if we want to *engage* in action, if it is to happen at all, it must happen *now*.

Thinking about storytelling for a moment will really help to illustrate this point. Stories are almost always told in the past tense – the ‘One time, long time...’ of Caribbean storytelling, or its European equivalent of ‘Once upon a time ...’. However, if others enact the story as the storyteller is telling it, while he continues to tell the story in the past tense, the enactment takes place *in the present* – the past of the story is liberated into the ‘now time’ of drama.

Occasionally, colloquially, someone might relate events in the present tense; for example, ‘I’m going down the street, when this bloke comes up to me and starts asking the way to the fountain. Well, I’m thinking what’s all this about? We haven’t got one here! And he’s carrying a bucket!’ In this case, although the language is constructed in the present tense, the storyteller is still referring to events that took place in the past, and others enacting the story would still be engaged in releasing those past events into the ‘now time’ of the drama – into the present moment.

In a play, dialogue unfolds as direct speech, in a fictional context, happening now. In process drama, this has to be equally true. While there is no pre-written script, nonetheless the dialogue between the participants will be in the present moment, just as all conversation is.

‘Isn’t this a Bit Obvious?’

Well, it is and it isn’t. We often expect people to instinctively know that drama unfolds in the ‘now time’ of a fictional construct but frequently they’re not aware of what the full implications of that are for the art form. For example, in [Chapter 4](#) we made the distinction between the real life context of the school and classroom, the general contextualisation of learning that drama can provide within education and the fictional context of the drama. These do not exist separately, but represent parallel states, if you will. When we are working in the fictional context of the drama, it is still within the real life context of the classroom, but we make a psychological and emotional shift. Similarly, the general contextualisation of learning is manifested in the particular fictional circumstances of the drama.

‘So What’s that Got to do with “Now Time”?’

Well, the ‘now time’ of the drama exists as part of the real time of the school

day but shifting into the ‘now time’ of the drama *alters our perception of time*.

‘How, Exactly, does this Relate to Process Drama?’

Let’s look at an example.

If we go back to the Vikings example that we used in [Chapter 5](#) when we looked at context, the teacher could discuss with her class what it might have been like for the monks on Lindisfarne facing the imminent invasion. In reply to her questions, the students might respond like this:

Teacher: ‘What do you think the monks could see?’

Students: ‘The long ships would be on the horizon.’

‘They might see fierce people with swords.’

‘There would be a row of shields on the side of the boat.’

‘They might see nothing if it was dark, miss.’

Teacher: How do you think the monks would be feeling?’

Students: ‘Scared, miss.’

‘Worried.’

‘They might be worried about what the Vikings will steal.’

This type of conversation talks *about* the situation but there is a world of difference between this and:

‘Brethren, lock the church door, we have little time’

because this *shifts the drama into the now time* of the fictional circumstance. We are no longer talking about it – we are there in it, it is happening to us, now! In effect, the drama has begun. This is an absolutely critical concept. While discussing or brainstorming ideas with the class could be useful activities that would inform the drama by helping the students to focus on the content of the drama, if they only ever talk about it, the drama will never happen.

We referred earlier to the storyteller telling the story in the past tense but with its simultaneous enactment in the present moment. This alteration of our perception places us squarely within the time frame and experience of the story. The possibility of our effecting this shift into the ‘now time’ of the drama opens up a host of different possibilities. Language holds within it many different tenses to which we relate from our position in the present. In real circumstances we can neither relive the past nor experience the future – yet we can refer to them in language and even go so far as to speculate as to what might have been, or what might be in the future. The ‘now time’ of the

drama is an enormously powerful tool simply because it holds within it the potential to release us into a 'spectrum of presents' or 'new reals'. The learning that comes about in process drama (both about the art form and through it) is not achieved in the simplistic improvising of a 'now' situation but by using the possibilities inherent within that 'now' to explore dramatically:

- this is how it was
- this is how it might have been
- this is how it may be
- this is how it will be
- this is how it ought to be
- this is how it should have been
- this is how it could have been
- this is how it usually is
- this is how it usually was
- this is how we would like it to be

but all experienced as 'now'.

So when the teacher shifts the students, in the example given above, from the mere speculation of 'they might see fierce people with swords' to 'Brethren, lock the church door, we have little time', a switch has been thrown that catapults the participants immediately into the direct perception of a 'so this is what it was like' situation – *only it's happening now*.

'But will the Students Really Know what's Going on if you Say, "Brethren, Lock the Door"?'

Well, they certainly won't, if it is said out of context, with no preparation. But we have already indicated that a preparatory discussion or other context building activities would be desirable. Indeed, we really do believe that it is vital to keep the students informed about what's going on. Students need to know what they

are doing and this includes knowing that what they are doing is drama and that it is not real, *even if it feels real*. And it is precisely because it does feel real that it is a good idea to tell the students that the drama is going to begin and not suddenly spring things on them. While this may not seem like a big problem with a drama about something so obviously historical as the Vikings, it is, and even more so if the drama is focused on a contemporary issue such as bullying, racism or pollution, when it might be more difficult for the students to see the boundary between the fictional and real contexts.

However, we are *not* suggesting that you need to plot out every aspect of

the drama before it unfolds. As we have pointed out, process drama is fundamentally an improvised form and there has to be scope within it for the contribution of the participants. The development by the students of a sense of ownership about their learning, you will remember, is one of the cornerstones of process drama. Moreover, if the teacher decides everything that is going to happen in the session, not only does she work against the development of this sense of ownership but places a limit on the scope for creative and imaginative input by the students and for unforeseen development in dramatic tension.

So, prior to the cry 'Brethren, lock the church door ...' the teacher may have conducted a brainstorming session similar to the one above; used still images to build the scene on the island prior to the ships being sighted; she might have used recorded plain chant to evoke the atmosphere of the monastery; indeed, she might have combined all of these strategies to build the context of the drama.

However, when, as teacher-in-role, she addresses the assembled monastic community and says, 'Lock the church door, we have little time', something fundamental takes place. The drama is brought into existence because she has made it happen *now*, and those 'fierce people with swords' are now created as 'absent others' who, in turn, create the artistic process of the self-spectator. In other words, the 'absent others' (in this case the Viking invaders) make us see 'us behaving' (as monks under threat of attack) and selecting choices (one of which is locking the church door). So in throwing the switch that propels us into the discourse of the drama, it is the attitude, language and stance of the teacher that is essential.

'Could you Say More about this Attitude, Language and Stance?'

Suppose we think again about something we mentioned in [Chapter 6](#) on frame. You will recall that we talked about the teacher's aim of moving students from the known to the unknown so that they gain new insights and shifts of perceptions, and that we emphasised how successful process drama is in enabling this to happen. However, you will also remember that an important consequence of this is that teachers will be constantly asking students to step onto the shaky ground of the unknown. One of the mechanisms for helping the participants into this experience, as we pointed out, was to select a communication frame that had an element of familiarity from the students' real life experiences – loss, secrecy, time constraints.

However, there is another powerful set of tools that the teacher has at her

disposal and which she can use to ignite the drama and support her students into 'now time'. These are the attitude, language and stance, together with the body language she adopts when moving into teacher-in-role.

If we again look back to our discussion of frame as the means by which dramatic tension is created in process drama, we will recall that it is possible to do this in three distinct ways and that the last two directly involve teacher-in-role.

- Through the differences in opinion between the students' roles – 'I think we should negotiate with the strangers', 'No, I think we should run', 'I think there may be something in this for me'.
- Through the differences between the students' roles and the teacher-in-role – 'You'll all have to work overtime and for less money'; 'But my family can't survive on what you pay now'.
- Through the differences between the collective view of the students' roles and teacher-in-role, together, and an absent antagonist – 'What are we going to do to get past the monster?'

With the attitude of her role she is able to present something with which, or against which, the students can react, and through the language she selects she can provide a model that the students can follow.

So, 'Brethren, lock the church door, we have little time', spoken by teacher-in-role as one of the monks, does two things. First, it creates frame (through the differences between the collective view of the students and teacher-in-role, together, and an absent antagonist). Second, the structure of the language draws a different style of discourse from the students than 'Quick, they're nearly here!'

It is for this reason that we firmly believe that *teacher-in-role is central to process drama* and should not be regarded merely as just one among the wide number of drama strategies available. As we have already seen in [Chapter 5](#), teacher-in-role enables the teacher to operate strategically from within the drama and so negotiate and renegotiate circumstances within the fiction, in order to enhance learning opportunities. A critical component of that negotiation will be negotiating the shifts into the 'now time' of the drama.

'You've Said Earlier that there will be Lots of Different Strategies Used in a Drama. but if we are Living it through as if it is Happening Now, How Can I Change Strategies?'

It is important to realise that drama can stop and start. Just because it is enacted in the present moment doesn't mean that it has to be a long, continuous, uninterrupted process. In fact, it is desirable that it's not! There

are going to be times when you wish to change strategy in order to move the story of the drama forward, to change the context of the drama, to deepen the experience, to reflect upon what has gone on or prepare for what is to come. If we think again about process drama being *episodic* in nature this should help to clarify this point.

If we restrict ourselves to the drama moving forward in a chronological, linear fashion, we are limiting the opportunities for the students to gain the maximum benefit from the experience, both in terms of learning about the process drama genre and about other things through the drama.

However, if we think of process drama as a sequence of linked episodes, then we are liberated to explore the substance of the drama from a range of different perspectives, to move forwards, backwards and sideways in time, change role, miss out aspects of the story that do not readily lend themselves to dramatisation. Actually, this is precisely what playwrights frequently do. They change scenes, they allow the audience to see events through the eyes of different characters, they warp time and space and allude to events that would be impractical or undesirable to present in performance. Given that – as we have stressed throughout – process drama is a theatre genre in which the teacher and students together ‘write’ the play as it unfolds in action, we should not be surprised that episodic progression applies equally to process drama.

‘Is this Episodic Thing Really so Important?’

Actually, yes it is. As we’ve just pointed out, it allows the teacher to stop the drama, for both the students and herself to come out of role, change the time, place and roles and alter the strategies being used, reflect upon what has happened and plan what to do next. This may mean moving the story of the drama forward in time, but it could equally be about revisiting what has happened to examine the consequences of alternative decisions and courses of action, to see events from the viewpoint of other roles, to explore what was happening simultaneously elsewhere. The episodic structure creates freedom to slow down and even reverse the inexorable march of time. This gives the teacher the means by which she is able to stretch and challenge the students to engage more deeply with the substance of the drama and gain changes in perceptions and understandings. The ability to warp time in this fashion is one of the keys to successful learning in process drama.

‘Can you Say More about Time?’

Well, let’s come back to the notion that drama is a form of story. The curiosity,

which is one of the key features of human nature, leads us all to want to know the end of the story, whether the 'story' is a piece of gossip, half-overheard; a breaking news item; *Harry Potter*; *Rumpelstiltskin*; *Hamlet* or the next episode of a soap opera like *Eastenders*. Students engaged in process drama are no different in their response to the unfolding story of the drama. Like us all, they are driven to know what happens in the end. Moreover, if we don't find out the end of the story, somehow we feel cheated; we feel disconcerted and unsettled. We miss the feeling of satisfaction that we get from learning how things turned out.

Recognising this basic instinct can really help us as teachers to hone the way we shape process dramas. It helps to make clear to us that we have a sort of juggling act going on, or perhaps a tug-of-war is a better analogy.

On the one hand, we have the momentum to get to the end of the story that is fuelled by the students' natural curiosity about what happens next. On the other, we have our teacherly desire to challenge the students to really get to grips with the learning by getting down below the surface of the material. The dilemma is that the first can make it more difficult to achieve the second!

'What's this Got to do with Time and Episodes?'

Two things, really. First, it has an impact on how long a process drama lasts. It is perfectly possible to structure a process drama that is a one-off lesson. Let's say that it lasts anywhere between half an hour and an hour, which is a range within which many teachers might operate. Within such a period of time (real life time, that is), the teacher can create a very successful and satisfying learning experience for her class. However, she will have to remember, to use the old adage, to cut her coat according to her cloth. She will have to strike a balance between the students' desire to get to the end of the story and her desire to challenge their understanding. Under the constraints of the stand-alone lesson, therefore, she has to select a learning area or theme which it is possible for the students to explore, with some depth and purpose, within the story of a drama, which will need to be concluded in the single session. This is where the episodic structure comes into its own. It allows the teacher to be highly selective in choosing which aspects of the story to develop with the class, allowing the story to move forward while still focusing the students on the learning area; it enables her to select strategies that will do what she needs them to do, economically, and enables the provision of a structure that sees the story resolved within the real life time constraints of the one-off lesson.

On the other hand, if the teacher is able to develop a process drama over a number of sessions, as in our key examples, then she has the scope to engage

the students with a learning area that is more wide-ranging, more demanding or more complex. The episodic structure will again facilitate this exploration because its inherent potential for changing time, place, roles and performance form allows for the participants' engagement with both the breadth and the depth demanded by such a learning area.

'But you Said there were Two Things'

Yes, and the second one is to do with how the teacher weaves the contributions of the students into the drama.

As we have stressed, one of the cornerstones of process drama is the students' ownership of their learning. This means the teacher must provide a structure in which their contributions to the shaping of the work can be fore-fronted and acted upon. Within whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role, the sense of urgency provided by the 'living through' experience, coupled with the questioning skills of the teacher (in role), will stimulate a range of responses from the students as they struggle with the problems of resolving the dilemma of the drama.

Sharp 'thinking on your feet' skills make it possible for the teacher-in-role to weave in the contributions of the students as the drama continues, and many process dramas are, indeed, resolved in this manner. However, if we recognise the value of the episodic form, we can see that a broader range of possibilities become available to class and teacher. It becomes possible to stop the drama and discuss how to turn the students' response into dramatic action. Preparation can be made, actions 'rehearsed', consequences seen and revisions made in their light. Moreover, the teacher is able to select the most appropriate way of working to enable the students to see and feel their ideas realised in action.

'When you Talked about the Drama Learning Contract, You Mentioned Questioning and Now You've Mentioned it Again. could you Say More about this?'

We're sure we all agree that questioning is a key skill for every teacher. Indeed, there are many educationalists who have written in detail and with power and authority about the centrality of the question to the learning process.

As classroom practitioners we know that we need to be subtle in our use of questioning with students and recognise the need to employ different types of questions at different times because we require them to serve different purposes in enabling the learning of those we teach. This is equally true within

the structure of process drama.

However, all questioning in process drama should be predicated on the understanding that there is, generally speaking, no clearly defined 'right' answer. This is born out of two broader understandings. The first is that all good theatre poses questions rather than provides answers. It holds an aspect of the human condition up for examination and, through the lens of the dramatic context and the interaction of the characters found there, allows our thoughts and feelings to be disturbed as we struggle to find the answers for ourselves. The second is that process drama is a collaborative form in which the teacher and students, together, construct the meaning. What follows on from this is that the teacher will have to construct her questions in such a manner that the understanding and experience of her students can be heard and their ideas and solutions woven into the fabric of the drama.

'Could you Expand on this?'

Well, it might be useful to spend a moment or two looking at the different types of questions that are crucial in facilitating the development of a process drama and the engagement of the students with it. Seeing the purposes they serve should make it easier to know which sort of questions to use, and when. We have included examples from both in the 'now time' of the drama and from outside it because the teacher's questioning strategies in both of these situations impact on her chances of building the drama, together, with the students.

Category

Questions that

Examples

help define parameters and summarise

decisions

In the drama

'Are we agreed that we'll all go to Australia?'

Out of the drama

'Do we all agree that when I speak again our drama will have begun?'

These remind the students of the drama learning contract and support the students in their understanding that process drama is a social form.

ask for information

In the drama

'Does anyone know how to contact the people who live here in the rainforest?'

	<i>Out of the drama</i> 'Which strategy should we use to make the next part of the drama happen?'
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These remind the students that they are involved in a collaboration with their teacher in structuring the drama.

provide information	<i>In the drama</i> 'How will we get all the other things into the wagon, apart from the mining gear?' <i>Out of the drama</i> 'Have we thought of all the problems which the lawyers will face?'
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These steer the students without the teacher imposing her ideas.

challenge the students to think more deeply	<i>In the drama</i> 'Has everyone written their last letter home?' <i>Out of the drama</i> 'How did you feel when you saw the message and realised what it meant?'
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These focus the students to consider the implications of the drama.

stimulate investigation and research	<i>In the drama</i> 'Do we know exactly what Darwin wrote?' <i>Out of the drama</i> 'How long would it have taken a ship to sail to Australia in those days?'
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These challenge the students to find out information in order that the drama can move on.

offer choices	<i>In the drama</i> 'Should we all go together or split up now and rendezvous later?'
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Out of the drama

‘Do you want an imaginary dragon or do you want me to be the dragon for you?’

These challenge the students to make a decision between two courses of action while excluding the possibility of others.

increase tension

In the drama

‘Does anyone know how hot it gets here?’

Out of the drama

‘What would you like the next danger to be?’

These allow the teacher to refocus or increase the tension of the drama.

provide opportunity for reflection

In the drama

‘I wonder what made each of us decide to make this journey?’

Out of the drama

‘What sort of person would have stood up for the others like that?’

These challenge the students to think about what the experience means to them.

The structure of many of these questions is designed to be musing, reflective and inviting. They seek to draw the students in through more indirect routes that put the teacher firmly in a position of not knowing or of uncertainty. This approach to questioning is firmly related to the status of the role that the teacher takes in the drama. We can see here that a role that does not carry with it the ultimate authority is one that will more readily be able to ask the sorts of questions we have been discussing here. In other words, this combination of TIR status and questioning consequently puts the onus of decision onto the students.

Of course, one of the consequences of asking students questions to which you really do want them to respond is that you get a host of answers. As we have stressed throughout, process drama actively seeks to involve students in shaping the direction of their own learning, and as you can see from this brief

selection of sample questions the teacher is inviting genuine responses that will help to shape the direction of the drama. However, this also means that action is required of her in order that she fulfils her part of the bargain – the bargain being that to invite students to find the solution to the immediate problem at hand, means the teacher has a duty to find the means by which they can see their ideas in action and meet the consequences of them.

This is a key point. Your sophisticated questioning will count for nothing if you hear the students' responses and then say, 'but this is what we are going to do'. The students will feel cheated and let down and quickly realise that you were not really interested in what they thought, and that you make all the decisions anyway. This slip will undermine your hard work and skill in structuring a drama in which the students have been committed and involved.

We realise that for teachers coming newly to process drama it feels 'safer' to have the course of the drama mapped out in complete detail because it feels as if you know exactly what is going to happen at all times. However, if you follow this through into practice, it will mean that the learners will not be making any real contribution to what is happening in the drama. They will merely be acting as the puppets while the teacher pulls their strings. In consequence, they will have little sense of ownership about their work and gain relatively little from it.

'So how do you Include all the Students' Ideas?'

Well, it's not always going to be possible to do so. There will be times when they have offered downright contradictory suggestions or suggestions which are out of sync with the place and time of the drama. However, the key to success here is making each student feel his contribution is valued within the framework of the collaborative nature of drama.

We are sure this will not be a new idea to you. As classroom practitioners you will already have a number of strategies that you employ to ensure that the voices of all of your students are heard. However, here are a number of strategies that we have found successful:

- recording the students' contributions publicly – on paper or a chalkboard, for example – so the whole group can consider all the possibilities;
- sharing ideas with a partner or small group – 'Talk to the botanist near you and see if you can think of a plan' – before presenting it to the rest of the group;
- looking for commonalities in responses and clustering them together.

As we mentioned at the beginning of this section on questioning, a great deal has already been written about the topic. If you would like to find out

more, there are a number of texts that have very thorough and clear sections on questioning in drama and you will find details of them at the end of the book in the 'Further reading' section.

'You've not Mentioned Monitoring and Assessment of Progress'

That's true. Our aim has been to focus on the principles of planning process drama in a way that allows it to be used within different curricula briefs. However, the clear relationship between progression and assessment and the particular demands of any individual curriculum means that a detailed examination of this important area is beyond the scope of this book. However, there are some key points that we would like to stress.

First, monitoring student progress and the assessment of achievement is as important in drama as it is in any other area of the curriculum. There has long been a debate about whether it is possible to assess achievement in the arts and, if it is possible, whether it is desirable. There are those who have argued that the very act of assessment somehow stifles students' creativity and undermines the very development that teachers are trying to engender.

We do not subscribe to this view. As teachers, our task is to promote the learning of our students and in order to do that we need to know how they are getting on. Furthermore, to ignore the current educational climate, which sees monitoring, assessment, reporting and accountability as key elements of practice, would be foolhardy. Moreover, we think that all teachers recognise the key part assessing achievement plays in the planning process – irrespective of what is being taught. The assessment–planning–teaching–learning loop will be familiar to us all.

So, the critical point, for us, is not whether drama should be assessed, but *how* it should be assessed.

As teachers, we will all be conscious of the need to match assessment methods to the progress and achievement that is to be assessed. But this raises a second, critical point. We need to be clear about *what students may learn* by engaging in drama so that we can identify appropriate methods for assessing it.

Teachers in some countries have an explicit drama curriculum that contains detailed level descriptors of achievement in drama. Others teach in a context where drama is less developed in a national drama curriculum. More may find themselves working within a local- or school-developed drama curriculum. Still others will find themselves using drama as a methodology within other curriculum subjects.

However, recalling [Chapter 1](#) will remind us of the potential drama offers for learning about the art form and, through the art form, about other things. We identified three broad categories of learning – learning about the art form itself; personal, cultural and social learning, including language, spiritual and moral development; and cross-curricular learning. Effective, useful assessment then, needs to take into account the range of learning possibilities. However, the *weighting* that any particular programme will give to each of these areas will depend on the sort of curriculum structure in which the drama is taking place.

However, we think that a further key point lies here. While assessment of students' progress in their understanding of, say, conservation issues, evolution, issues of HIV/AIDS or the Australian Gold Rush, or of their ability to work as team members or to problem-solve, is absolutely appropriate and desirable, assessing the achievement *only* that is content-led or concerned with personal and social development will *not* provide the teacher with an insight into the progress her students are making *in drama*. This is really very important. If we accept that developing ability in the art form of drama is not only of value intrinsically, but also that becoming more adept in working in the art form will improve the quality of learning in those areas that spring from working through it, then it becomes clear that monitoring student progress in drama is essential. As we pointed out in [Chapter 1](#), the higher the quality of the drama experience, the higher the quality of the learning; and essential to this is the increasing skill, confidence and sophistication with which students engage in drama. Assessment of these, then, becomes a key element in the ongoing cycle of teaching and learning.

To put it another way, no matter in which curriculum structure we teach drama, our aim should be to *strike a balance in assessment*, monitoring progress in all three categories of learning.

‘What about Assessment Methods?’

We have already mentioned the need to match methods of assessment to the types of achievement being assessed and, once again, the teacher's particular curriculum brief will have an impact here. There are already a number of publications that contain good advice on assessment in clear and informative chapters, which we feel are very helpful, and we have included details in the ‘Further reading’ section. In addition, we would suggest bearing the following general points in mind. When assessing drama the teacher needs to:

- recognise the place and value of drama in her particular curriculum structure;

- develop procedures that are, as far as possible, objective, fair and criteria-referenced;
- recognise the tensions between the social, ephemeral nature of drama and the need to monitor individual progress;
- accommodate different types of learning in drama;
- recognise that the nature of drama means not all learning outcomes in drama are predictable;
- involve students in the assessment of their own progress;
- remember that assessment informs future planning.

Useful assessment methods include:

- observation and note-taking by the teacher;
- student-kept drama log;
- photographs, audio and video recordings;
- debriefing discussions between peers and with teacher;
- writing and drawing in and out of role.

There is one further point that we should stress here. This particular book is concerned with process drama, but, as we made clear at the very outset, process drama is not the only type of drama used within an educational context. Whether following an explicit drama curriculum or using drama in a cross-curricular manner, there are other ways of working, apart from process drama, with which the teacher will need to engage her class from time to time – presentations in assemblies, the study of plays and playwrights, the performance of a play, playwriting, responding to and evaluating drama, physical theatre, puppetry, mime, the craft and technical aspects of theatre, and so on. While all fall under the drama umbrella, each offers a different emphasis of opportunity for students; some in what we called Strand A learning and some in Strand B, and assessment processes will need to recognise this. What we must remember is that it is the combination of different ways of working that will meet the demands of a curriculum and that no single way of working is going to serve the needs of all of the students all of the time. They need to have the opportunity to engage with a wide spectrum of drama if they are to make progress in the fullest sense.

However, although process drama is not the entirety of drama in an educational context, it is, nonetheless, a central and powerful means by which students learn about drama and, through it, about other things.

‘And Now?’

Before you have a go at putting it all into practice, we want you to give some

consideration to the notion that the planning continues even as the drama is unfolding. Since the dramatic action may change direction according to teacher/ student input and response, the following chapter explains something about what we have called 'planning on your feet'.

Planning ‘On your Feet’ in the Unfolding Drama

KEY QUESTION: ‘Is doing process drama successfully simply a matter of adhering to all the planning principles outlined so far?’

Certainly the planning principles laid out to this point will take you to a very good starting place, but as you become more confident in your process drama teaching, you will be ready to introduce greater subtlety and nuance into your practice. So, in this chapter we are going to take a closer look at how this can be achieved both before the drama begins and, critically, once it is under way and unfolding through the action, reaction and interaction of the roles.

So far, we have illustrated what we have been saying throughout with accounts of fully developed dramas, which could only have been written *after* the event. In reality, of course, because of its essentially improvisatory, negotiated nature, the first phase of planning for process drama will take the teacher to the initial *starting* point for the drama, even in situations where the final outcome of the drama has already been agreed on. The main body of the drama, the play, so to speak, has yet to be generated. It will be created, ‘written’, discovered, negotiated by students and teacher, *together*, in what the influential philosopher of mind and art, Suzanne Langer (1953), powerfully described as the ‘perpetual present moment’ that is ‘filled with its own future’.

Now, while each of the key planning principles outlined so far quite obviously has a connection to each of the others, nonetheless, it is going to be useful here to turn our attention to the particular interconnectivity of just three of them – namely context, role and frame. We are not implying the others are less important in the overall planning process, since this is patently not the case. However, drama contextualises learning in fictional

circumstances, and it is important for us as teachers to understand not only how to plan a *particular* dramatic context effectively, but also to recognise that *multiple* dramatic contexts are available to us, through which to explore a theme, because this gives us the scope for nuancing and subtlety of approach *and* greater opportunity to weave in the contributions of the learners to the shape and direction of their learning.

Recognising that there exists a multiplicity of dramatic contexts in relation to a particular learning area provides the means by which it can be approached from a range of perspectives, something that we (Bowell and Heap, 2002) have called *the spectrum of circumstance*. Therefore, understanding further something of the manner in which the three elements context, role and frame hold within them the potential for generating a broad and subtle range of dramatic circumstances can enable the teacher to see the widest possibilities for engaging students with a particular learning area and refining it as the drama unfolds.

Depending on the chosen context, a whole range of roles is available – not only for the participants but also the teacher-in-role, as we illustrated earlier in [Chapter 5](#). These roles, as we saw, are not enough by themselves to carry the drama, and dramatic tension needs to be generated through frame, as [Chapter 6](#) discusses. So, context, role and frame, in combination, give us the where, when, who and why of the drama. Getting to grips with this notion of a range of circumstances in which the drama can happen is really liberating, and opens the way for the teacher to facilitate the exploration of a learning area from a multiplicity of different perspectives – social, historical, political, moral, scientific, artistic and cultural.

‘So Instead of Planning Each Principle Separately, Should they be Grouped Together?’

Well, not necessarily. However, it might be useful to recall that in Chapters 4 and 5 we mentioned that as we plan context, role and frame, roles will emerge quite naturally from a particular dramatic context and get their active potential from the point of view provided by the frame. This natural affinity means that context, role and frame can, between them, generate a range of different dramatic circumstances in which to explore the theme of the drama. But the actual choosing of a particular set of fictional circumstances presents the teacher with a challenge. It lies in having to envisage a broad range of human experience, in order to choose from it the particular dramatic context that will best serve the learning of the particular group she will be teaching. This means recognising that a particular and focussed dramatic context holds

within it the potential to explore the bigger picture. A look back to [Chapter 4](#) will show that we have already used the Viking example to list seven different dramatic contexts in which the same learning area might be explored.

We often describe this selection process as the ‘hourglass dilemma’ (see [Figure 11.1](#)), because of the need to distil the learning area into the tight focus of a defined fiction so that through the drama participants arrive at insight and understanding of the bigger picture.

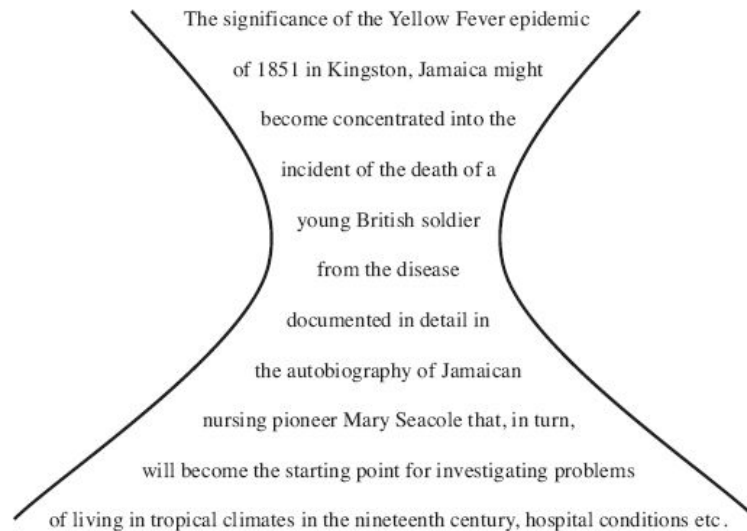


Figure 11.1 The hourglass dilemma

‘Could you Explain Further, Please?’

Of course.

For example, learning something about prevailing conditions in nineteenth-century nursing, hospitals and public health issues, while drawing inferences about modern medical advances and the current renewed challenges in the field of epidemiology, could be focussed on the nineteenth-century Jamaican nurse Mary Seacole’s account of the 1851 Yellow Fever epidemic in Kingston. The dramatic context could be even more narrowly and deeply focussed on the details of a documented incident of the death of a young British soldier during the epidemic, affording a number of opportunities for direct physical, personal and emotional engagement with this catastrophic event.

This narrow focus on a single incident gives the learners the opportunity to become deeply engaged through drama and establish a serious commitment to the topic. It then becomes possible for them to open up to a more meaningful study of conditions in nursing, hospitals, medical procedures of

the period under consideration, and the major developments that have taken place since that time. To put it another way, narrow and deep is better by far than broad and shallow when it comes to structuring drama to enabling meaningful learning. It is what Dorothy Heathcote throughout her career described as finding the universal in the particular.

‘But what has this Got to do with Planning on your Feet?’

Getting to grips with this notion of a spectrum of possible circumstances will do two things.

First, you will be in a position to bring greater subtlety and precision to the pre-action planning (before the drama begins). However, second, you will also have the skill and confidence to ensure that the drama can *progress* by making shifts in one, two or all three of these fundamental planning principles and recognise that such adjustments, made as the drama unfolds, will produce new situations and develop the potential for further sets of learning outcomes. That is to say *new combinations* of context, role and frame bring diversity of choice to the teacher with the consequential ability to fine-tune the drama and, as a result the learning, as it is unfolding through the creative endeavour of students and teacher, together.

‘Why do you think that Recognising this Relationship between Context, Role and Frame is so Critical when Using Process Drama?’

Well, we believe the interplay between these three planning principles constitutes the ‘essence’ of process drama. At first glance it might seem otherwise, and teachers may be tempted to believe that, rather, it is having a broad range of dramatic strategies at one’s fingertips, which truly represents the ‘essence’ of the drama. However, in our experience, this can lead them to focusing on getting familiar with as many drama strategies as possible at the expense of paying sufficient attention to the other equally important aspects of the dramatic structure.

We need to remind ourselves to see drama strategies for what they are, which is really the means by which the substance of the drama is given shape and form, or as Jonothan Neelands and Tony Goode (2000) have called them, ‘available forms in theatre and drama’. If the critical interplay between context, role and frame is not fully appreciated and achieved, then the strategies, no matter how well-chosen and executed they are, may well be rendered largely ineffective in delivering the learning and providing a satisfying drama experience for the participants. Adjusting the action of the

drama as it is unfolding involves more than just adjusting the strategies being used, since it is the interplay between context, role and frame unfolding in ‘now time’ that establishes the immediacy of thinking, feeling and action that provokes learning. That is, the experience that *‘this is happening to us, here and now, because...’*

‘Can’t the Teacher and Students Simply Introduce a New Strategy without Adjusting any Other Elements in the Drama?’

Yes, there are times when this might be so. In [Chapter 8](#) we looked at the different purposes that strategies can serve in bringing a drama into being: building the dramatic context, moving the narrative of the drama forward, exploring a greater depth of meaning and feeling and reflecting on the experience. Sometimes we may want to use strategies in combination to, for example, build a context. For instance, ‘Defining the Space’ could be followed with ‘Objects of Character’ and ‘Role-on-the-Wall’. These would all be concerned with establishing the same context. However, in this chapter we are encouraging you towards a greater confidence and finesse in your planning and part of that is to get a hold on the dynamic and flexible nature of process drama, remembering that strategies are not the drama but are the means by which we bring it into being.

‘Could you Elaborate on this a Little More, Please?’

Well with this in mind, let’s look further into how we can exploit the relationship between context, role and frame for the benefit of the drama and, therefore, its participants.

As we have already seen, part of the power of process drama for learners lies precisely in the immediacy of thinking and feeling and action that takes place in the present moment. The ‘now time’ places the participants firmly in the time frame and experience of the ‘story’ of the drama.

In real circumstances, we can never relive the past nor experience the future – yet we can refer to them in language and even go so far as to speculate what might have been or what might still be. The ‘now time’ of the drama is an enormously powerful feature, because it holds within it the potential to release us into a ‘spectrum of presents’. Learning that comes about in process drama is not achieved in the simplistic improvising of a ‘now’ situation but by using the possibilities inherent within that ‘now’ to explore dramatically a range of experience, including a ‘spec -trum of whens’; ‘a spectrum of wheres’; ‘a spectrum of whats’; ‘a spectrum of whos’; and ‘a

spectrum of whys’. In combination, they create the spectrum of circum - stance we have been talking about – and they all happen in the present moment.

‘Could you go Over that Again?’

Well, you’ll remember that in the last chapter, [Chapter 10](#), we began talking about ‘now time’ and explained that it allows us to explore a whole range of possibilities, but all experienced as ‘now’.

This is a good moment to remind ourselves that when we were discussing dramatic context in [Chapter 4](#) we saw that it actually consists of three elements – time, place and event, so we could illustrate that more fully by expanding as follows:

<i>Time</i>	<i>Place</i>	<i>Event</i>
This is how it was	This is where it was	This is what it was
This is how it might have been	This is where it might have been	This is what it might have been
This is how it may be	This is where it may be	This is what it may be
This is how it will be	This is where it will be	This is what it will be
This is how it ought to be	This is where it ought to be	This is what it ought to be
This is how it should have been	This is where it should have been	This is what it should have been
This is how it could have been	This is where it could have been	This is what it could have been
This is how it usually is	This is where it usually is	This is what it usually is
This is how it usually was	This is where it usually was	This is what it usually was
This is how we would like it to be	This is where we would like it to be	This is what we would like it to be
But all experienced as ‘now’	But all experienced as ‘here’	But all experienced as ‘this’

Now if we extend this approach to include ‘role’ and ‘frame’, then we can see that ‘now time’ also enables us to generate:

<i>Role</i>	<i>Frame</i>
This is who it was	This is why it was

This is who it might have been
This is who it may be
This is who it will be
This is who it ought to be
This is who it should have been
This is who it could have been
This is who it usually is
This is who is usually was
This is who we would like it to be
But all experienced as 'us'

This is why it might have been
This is why it may be
This is why it will be
This is why it ought to be
This is why it should have been
This is why it could have been
This is why it usually is
This is why is usually was
This is why we would like it to be
But all experienced as 'because'

'It Seems a Lot to take in. Can you Give me an Example of how this Works in Practice?'

OK. Let us take a look at what these principles might mean in practical terms to a teacher in the classroom by developing an example of process drama, which uses as its inspiration a short but rich and significant story by the Brothers Grimm, *The Old Man and his Grandson*.

There was once a very old man, whose eyes had become dimmed, his ears dull of hearing, his knees trembled, and when he sat at the table to eat he could barely hold the spoon to his lips, spilling broth upon the tablecloth or letting it dribble from his mouth. His son and his son's wife were both revolted by this and finally banished the grandfather to sit in a corner where they gave him his food in an earthenware bowl. He used to look longingly towards the table with his eyes brimming with tears. Once, his trembling hands could not hold his bowl and it dropped to the ground, breaking and spilling its contents. His young daughter-in-law scolded him dreadfully but he said nothing and only sighed. The following day she bought him a wooden bowl from which he had to eat.

However, one day they were sitting thus when the little grandson began to gather together some bits of wood. *'What are you doing?'* asked the father. *'I am making a little trough'*, answered the child, *'for you and mother to eat out of when I am big.'*

The man and his wife looked at each other and began to cry. Then they took the old grandfather to the table and, from that day on, always let him eat with them and said nothing if he spilled a little of anything.

In developing a drama experience for students from this story, the teacher may very well decide to do the following. Let us suppose that:

- a. The teacher takes on the **role** of a 'nosy' neighbour, along with the students in similar 'neighbourly' roles.
- b. The **context** is that they have just overheard their neighbour, the old man, weeping, and his daughter-in-law scolding him.
- c. The **frame** is the dilemma they face:
 - Is some kind of abuse taking place?
 - Should the neighbours mind their own business?
 - Should they, as responsible citizens, report the incident to the police?
 - Would calling in a social worker be better?
 - What would be the most appropriate action to take?
- d. From this initial premise, the **strategies** used can be introduced and altered, e.g., an overheard conversation; a neighbourhood committee meeting; tele -phone conversations with the police; writing in role to a social worker, the newspapers, etc.

However, in developing the drama, context, role and frame can all be changed, and consequently the learning outcomes altered.

- i. To begin with, the **roles** can change. The teacher's role can be changed to that of police officer, the daughter-in-law from the story, a social worker, newspaper reporter, etc. as required. The students too, could take on the roles of police, social workers, construction workers in the neighbourhood, tele -phone repair workers, etc.
- ii. The **context** could be altered. Remembering that context includes the elements of **time**, **place** and **event**, it might very well shift to 'making a report at a police station', 'working on a possible story at a newspaper office', 'a discussion at the village meeting hall', etc.
- iii. The **frame** might be adjusted as teacher and/or students adopt different points of view, reflected in the following situations:
 - police officers may think along the lines of, 'You can't just barge in and arrest somebody, because you heard an argument.'
 - social workers might respond by saying that, 'We have no real evidence of abuse, and the old man isn't one of our regular clients.'
 - the neighbours of the old man, on the other hand, might very well insist that 'We have to be able to protect one of our own.'

However, when the teacher undertakes to make an even more radical change in the drama, the following might happen:

- A. The story moves several years forward in time, with the teacher-in-role as

the little grandson from the story now grown into an adult. He is interviewing the students in role as workers who are applying for jobs in the factory that he owns, in which he designs and manufactures 'aids to independent living' for people who are elderly, disabled or infirm.

- B. The teacher-in-role as the now adult grandson explains to the aspiring workers that the most important qualification for getting a job is an understanding of what older people may need to help them remain independent, and he offers to introduce them to an older person who is also one of the factory's clients.
- C. The teacher-in-role as the adult grandson is replaced by the teacher-in-role as the older person, who is faced with the challenges of failing sight, hearing impairment, restricted mobility, difficulties in getting out of a chair, having a bath, or carrying out what might otherwise be considered simple tasks, etc.
- D. The students use the information gathered in their interview with the older person to develop some ideas for a new line of products, which will assist in promoting independent living among older people.

Within this unit of drama work with teacher-in-role, the central **strategies** used include:

- overheard conversations
- meetings
- interviews
- writing/drawing in role.

However, the teacher, in this second instance, has also:

- changed the **teacher's role** in the drama;
- changed the **role of the students** in the drama;
- shifted the **context** from simply applying for a job to actively developing new technologies to assist older people;
- altered the **frame** in the case of the teacher's role as the grandson to someone who is deeply committed to helping the elderly;
- altered the **frame** in the case of the teacher's role as the elderly informant to someone who wishes to remain as independent as possible for as long as possible;
- altered the **frame** in the case of the students' roles from people who need jobs to people who need to actively demonstrate empathy with the needs of older persons in order to secure that job.

'So when I Make Adjustments to the Drama Using Context,

Role and Frame Like this, I Use Strategies to Make it all Happen?’

Exactly. Because, as we said a moment ago, they are the means by which the drama is brought into being.

This brief example is intended to make clear that it is the shifts in context, role and frame, *working together* with a range of strategies and signs, which broadens and strengthens the drama experience for the students and so provides a richer and more rounded learning experience through a changing set of lenses. If we look in greater detail, it can be seen that these shifts offer a multiplicity of opportunities to explore the theme.

Each of these elements can be shifted independently, as well as in different combinations with the others, to produce something like this:

<i>Context</i>	<i>Role</i>	<i>Frame</i>
Context shifts	Role remains the same	Frame remains the same
Context remains the same	Role shifts	Frame remains the same
Context remains the same	Role remains the same	Frame shifts
Context shifts	Role shifts	Frame remains the same
Context remains the same	Role shifts	Frame shifts
Context shifts	Role remains the same	Frame shifts
Context shifts	Role shifts	Frame shifts

Let’s now go back to the original scenario suggested by the Grimm Brothers’ story, and see how different shifts can create a range of possibilities in a more concrete example:

<i>The nature of the shift ...</i>	<i>Context, role, frame</i>
1 Shifting the neighbours to a time before the events of the story might still find them with an opinion about the old man’s family, drama and provide opportunity which may be one of suspicion, because the family is ‘stand-offish’, or antisocial in some way.	Changing the context will alter the ‘where’ and ‘when’ of the drama and provide opportunity to explore events prior to or subsequent to the main dilemma that is the focus of the drama.
2 Shifting the learners’ and teacher’s roles from neighbours to workmen in the neighbourhood who hold a similar point of view about the event but whose roles possess a different history, status and	Changing the roles in the same context will change the ‘who’ of the drama. These new roles support the viewpoint held by the original roles but have a

authority to take action.	different reason for being there and are engaged in different tasks.
3 Shifting the neighbours' outlook from one of concern for the old man's welfare and wanting to intervene in the situation to being worried about whether they could be charged with creating a public nuisance should they be found to have falsely accused the family of elder abuse.	Changing the frame gives existing roles in the existing situation a different point of view and outlook on the circumstances of the drama. This alters the source and nature of the dramatic tension.
4 Shifting the place, time and event from the location of the neighbourhood to a newspaper office and the neighbours to newspaper reporters working on a story but maintaining the general point of view of: 'That couple wants locking up.' Once again the new roles possess a different level of empowerment in relation to the main events of the story since they can create a public outcry in the press.	Changing the context and role moves the learners to new roles in a new situation (and so new tasks and new levels of empowerment) while maintaining a similar point of view on unfolding events.
5 Shifting the situation to one where the neighbours have been featured in a newspaper story, and are not happy about the negative publicity they have received and are even having doubts about getting further involved in the matter.	Changing context and frame means existing roles are enabled to produce a new response to the changing circumstances of the drama.
6 Shifting the roles of the neighbours to police officers who feel they cannot arrest someone on the basis of hearsay and who are worried about overstepping their authority.	Changing role and frame puts new roles with a different point of view into the existing situation.
7 Shifting the roles from neighbours to workers applying for jobs in a factory owned by the old man's now grown-up grandson, where they will design and manufacture 'aids to independent living' for older people.	Changing context, role and frame produces an entirely new situation (new time, place and event) in which the teacher and learners taking new roles, and with new points of view can continue their exploration of the chosen theme but resulting in

‘My Goodness. This Looks a Bit Daunting’

All these permutations add up to a sophisticated structure that may seem quite overwhelming when confronted suddenly in practice, but it isn't really. Once you get comfortable and confident with the idea you'll find it hugely exciting and liberating. Add to it the ways in which sign and strategies are brought to bear upon the creation of mood, focus and action, and what is revealed is the absolute richness of possibilities that teachers and students have at their disposal to create, sustain and develop dynamic process dramas that are powerful, purposeful and relevant to the needs and interests of the learners. Instead of having to wrack your brain for the one idea, like finding a needle in a haystack, you will actually have a multiple ideas generator at your beck and call.

‘It Seems that the Kind of Planning Outlined Earlier in this Book Won't Prepare me for the Complications that May Arise when I'm Doing a Process Drama in Practice!’

On the contrary. It is true that the attention of the earlier part of this book on the pre-action phase of the drama does not focus on the full range and complexity of the systems and dynamics at work as the drama begins to unfold in action. However, the key examples that we included were carefully chosen to illustrate the planning process at work and to show the interrelatedness of the principles. We chose to foreground, first, the dynamics at work within the selection of strategies as being the most tangible and the most readily managed by the teacher new to process drama in creating successful dramas with her students. The point being made here, now, is that your careful and detailed planning, in combination with a clear understanding of the ways in which the planning principles interconnect with one another, will support you as you move forward to focus more sharply on the process in *action* – while the drama is happening.

‘Why does Process Drama Seem to Get More Complicated in Practice?’

Process drama *seems* to become more complex because of the possible range of alternative pathways through the drama along which the teacher and students together might carve out their creative journey towards meaningful

artistic and learning outcomes. But this richness of choice actually makes the teacher's task easier and much more skilfully managed. Importantly, it enables her to fold the ideas of the students into the developing drama, developing their sense of ownership about their learning – a cornerstone of process drama, as you will recall from [Chapter 2](#).

To use an analogy, process drama as it develops is a bit like two people trying to sustain a rally in tennis. The teacher hits the 'ball' over the net and the students return it. Depending on where it lands, the teacher responds, as do the students in turn and so, back and forth, the shape of the rally is created by the exchanges between them. In the drama, each responds to the contributions of the other and the drama is created by these exchanges.

It might help to look at this diagrammatically, so we are going to use one of the versions of the early years drama that we discussed in [Chapter 9](#) – the one about the roadworks and the hungry cat! Each version of the drama only lasted about 10 minutes, but nonetheless we can use one to show how the responsibility for shaping the developing drama passed back and forth between teacher and children, just as it does in good process drama of any length or complexity with participants of any age ([Figure 11.2](#)).

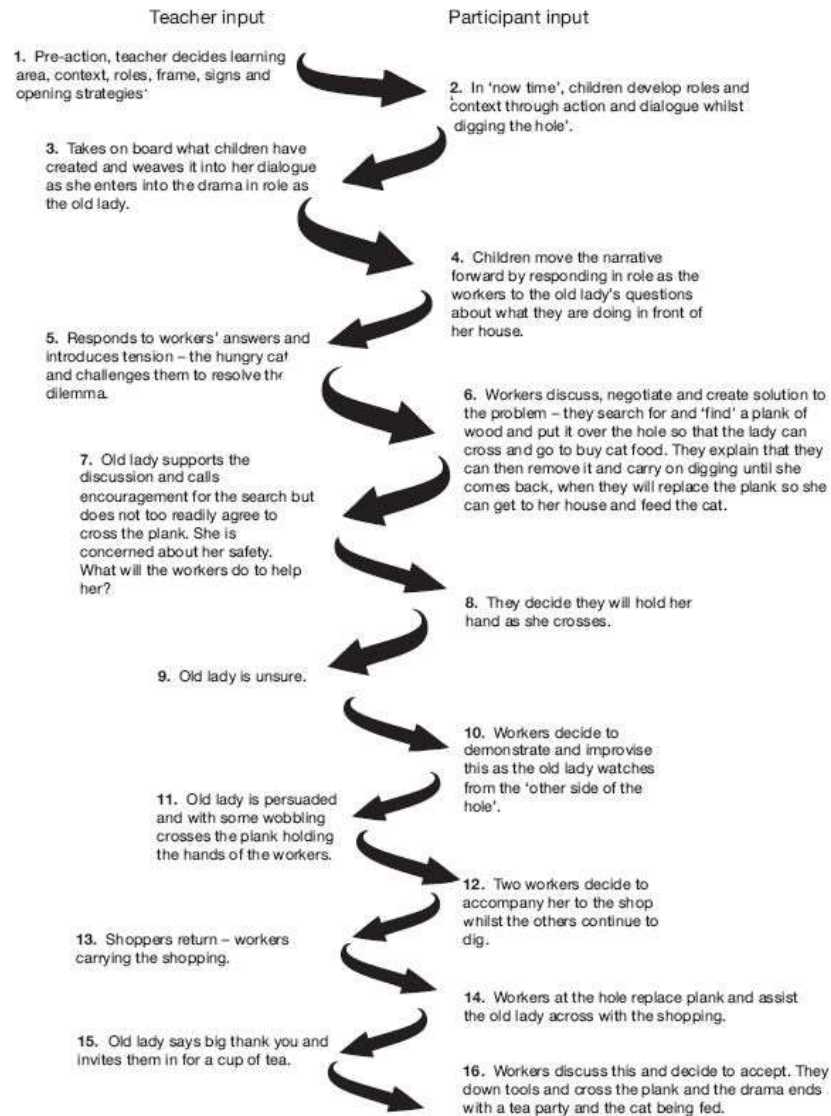


Figure 11.2 The unfolding drama

We hope that you can see from the diagram that the teacher's pre-action planning laid the foundation on which the drama was built by both her and the children together as it unfolded. The teacher did not know in advance what plan the children would devise to resolve the dilemma of the drama, neither did she have a solution in her mind. She did know, of course, what the learning area of the drama was – it was the first planning question she answered, but she recognised the need to negotiate how the learning was achieved with the children. We could describe it as an unknown journey or

perhaps, more accurately, as an unknown route to a known destination. Of course with longer and more complex process dramas with old participants there is also the delicious prospect of other unknown destinations along the way!

‘Is there Anything Else I Need to Know?’

By following the planning structure that we outlined at the beginning you will find yourself in a strong and clear position to begin your process drama with confidence. By bearing in mind what we have said in this chapter, about thinking on your feet and negotiating the progress of the drama with your students, you will be in a strong position to work collaboratively with them in a process of co-creativity that will result in powerful drama and effective, memorable learning.

We would, however, just like to mention one more thing that will take us right back to the beginning. In [Chapter 1](#) we talked about reasons for teaching drama that were compelling in the context of children’s learning. Here, we would like to add one more.

Developments in neuroscience and psychology over the past 15 years or so have provided insights into how the brain functions that seem to lend support to what drama teachers have always felt. It looks as though our brains are ‘wired’ for learning through drama.

Giacomo Rizzolatti led the team that discovered a particular type of motor neuron that they termed mirror neurons, in the early 1990s, and revealed their apparent key role in how learning happens. Rizzolatti’s ongoing work with humans reported in *Mirrors in the Brain* in 2006 (co-authored with Giorando Sinigaglia) and that of others in the field, such as V.S. Ramachandran (2003), Antonio Damasio (2010), Rhonda Blair (2007) and others, offers tantalizing glimpses into how drama might facilitate learning.

‘Could you Say More about this?’

It is beyond the scope of this book to go into great detail here. However, we will try to put it in a nutshell and perhaps tempt you to find out more for yourself.

Succinctly, because we are social beings we need to understand other people as well as ourselves and the research seems to be showing that it is mirror neurons that allow us to do this.

Rizzolatti, when researching brain function in monkeys, discovered that the same neurons were activated when a monkey observed an action as when it actually carried out the action. He went on to observe this indirectly in

humans but in 2010 it was directly observed in the human brain by Roy Mukamel, Itzhak Fried and their colleagues who reported their findings in the journal *Current Biology*, April 2010.

Essentially, as Ramachandran pointed out in his 2003 series of Reith Lectures for the BBC, 'Our brains are essentially model-making machines. We need to construct useful virtual reality simulations of the world that we can act on. Within the simulation, we need also to construct models of other people's minds because we primates are intensely social creatures.'

Evolutionary psychologist and anthropologist, Robin Dunbar, explains in his 1997 book, *Grooming Gossip and the Evolution of Language*, that having such a 'theory of mind' means 'being able to understand what another individual is thinking, to ascribe beliefs, desires, fears and hopes to someone else, and to believe that they really do experience these feelings as mental states'.

This is vital to our ability to recognise ourselves, build relationships with others and negotiate the world and our place within it. Giacomo Rizzolatti put it this way in an interview reported in the *New York Times* in 2006:

We are exquisitely social creatures. Our survival depends on understanding the actions, intentions, and emotions of others. Mirror neurons allow us to grasp the minds of others, not through conceptual thought but through direct simulation.

And Ramachandran, in his Reith Lectures, pointed out:

One of the hallmarks of our species is what we call culture. And culture depends crucially on the imitation of your parents and your teachers, and the imitation of complex skills may require the participation of motor (mirror) neurons.

Antonio Damasio, posted a series of videos on YouTube in 2010 in which he discusses his book *Self Comes to Mind*. At one point he sets out a developmental sequence concerning self, emotion and consciousness. He summarises it like this:

In short, emotion drives consciousness, consciousness drives attention and attention drives learning and long-term memory – and it all begins with an innate sense of self.

He goes on to say that:

Overall the human brain prioritises human relationships and socio-cultural interactions first.

Deep within our brain we are wired to survive by empathising and connecting with each other through action – movement and language.

Our brain is, by nature, biologically dramatic in that it exists to resolve conflict and perceived threat.'

‘Just Remind me what this has to do with Drama’

Well, the imagined experiences of Ramachandran’s ‘virtual reality simulations’ are brought into the physical world through the drama process. The key elements of mimicry and empathy generated by the firing of mirror neurons are key elements of drama. When we participate in process drama, as in all types of drama, we walk in the shoes of others and see the world through their eyes. Drama is concerned with the ways in which human beings engage with each other and build relationships. Damasio contends that emotion is the first step in the process that leads to learning. Drama is a socio-cultural entity that engages the participants on an emotional level and in doing so builds their commitment to it, so that there is the greatest opportunity for learning.

We know that this might seem complicated and, of course, it is and it is also in some ways speculative – an enticing research project is waiting to happen, somewhere. It is also true that not every neuroscientist is as convinced by the role of mirror neurons as others. Furthermore, you do not have to engage with any of this before you can teach process drama.

However, as we do set about creating process dramas with our students, we can hold in the back of our mind that a developing body of understanding seems to support the drama teachers’ long-held belief that children are predisposed to learn through drama, because the evidence seems to be showing that our brains need to ‘rehearse’ life in order for us to learn. Process drama creates no-penalty, fictional circumstances in which we can do just that.

‘And Now?’

Turn over the page and work your way through the planner you will find there to guide you neatly through planning your drama!

Process Drama Planner

In this chapter we hope to give you the opportunity of going through the planning process for yourself.

KEY QUESTION: ‘But why is there a need for a Planning Chapter – hasn’t this whole book been about planning for process drama?’

True, enough! But so far the book has been built around just six key questions. During the course of reading, however, you will have realised that we have raised a number of others. This chapter breaks down the key questions into a series of more specific guiding questions that will help you to be absolutely thorough in your planning. We believe that if you give careful consideration to these, they will serve as a very helpful checklist. If you are able to answer them, then you should be confident that you have brought together the elements needed to provide a meaningful experience for your students and yourself.

We urge you to step into the unknown if you have not yet created process drama with your students. As we said in the opening chapter, drama is empowering. When teachers exploit drama, they provide a complex, rich and vivid means through which children become artists and, through learning about the art form, develop a means through which to learn about the world around them.

There is, however, one final point to make and it is this:

Children find well-constructed drama engaging, exciting, moving, challenging, rewarding and hugely enjoyable.

A Process Drama Planner

Follow the step-by-step sequence to arrive at your plan. Use the sub-questions in each section as a checklist to ensure that you have covered all the planning points. Photocopy the pages and use the grid as a planning sheet.

Theme/Learning Area

What?

Key question 1

With which area of human experience do I want the students to engage and on what specific aspect of this do I want to focus on their learning?

When deciding on your theme or learning area, remember that learning from drama may be:

- about the art form of drama;
- personal and social (including language, cultural, moral and spiritual development);
- cross-curricular;
- that learning about drama and learning through drama are intertwined; and
- that all of this will happen within the framework of your own particular curriculum structure.

Check the following points:

- What opportunities are there for drama/role play in the curriculum you are following?
- How much flexibility do you have in choosing themes?
- Is your learning area/theme closely related to some area of human experience? If so, what?
- If the theme is not directly related to an area of human experience, how will you connect it to **people** and their experiences?
- Are there opportunities for cross-curricular learning: personal, social, moral, cultural and spiritual learning and learning about the art form of drama?

Review [Chapter 3](#) for more help in deciding what you want your students to learn about.

My chosen learning area(s) for this drama is/are:

Context

Where?

Key question 2

When?

Which particular circumstances will be created by the drama to explore the theme?

When deciding on your dramatic context, remember that:

- drama is a powerful means through which to contextualise learning;
- you need to take into consideration the real life context in which you and your students are working; and
- dramatic contexts can be located in the past, present or future.

Check the following points:

- Have you considered the number/age/social health of your class?
- Do you have a special room or space for drama, or will you have to work in the classroom?
- Are you able to rearrange furniture or will you have to work with it 'in situ'?
- Do you have the resources you need?
- What range of possible fictional circumstances have you thought of in which to explore the theme?
- Which of these will best serve your particular class?
- Will your chosen dramatic context provide opportunities for specific contextualisation of learning: e.g., oral language – technical or professional; written language – letters, reports, petitions; research, experimentation; new performance forms?

Review **Chapter 4** for more help in deciding on the dramatic context.

My chosen dramatic context is:

Role

Who?

Key question 3

Who are the students and the teacher going to be in the drama?

When deciding on the roles in the drama, remember that:

- children almost always take on adult roles in their own dramatic playing;
- at least at the outset, roles bound together through common interest are most enabling of the drama; and
- teacher-in-role is a powerful means of enabling the drama.

Check the following points:

– students' roles

- Is it likely that the roles you have selected would be found in the context you have chosen?
- Do the roles have a common interest in the circumstances of the drama?
- Are there opportunities for individual identities to be developed within the group?
- Are there likely to be opportunities for a range of opinions to be developed within the dramatic circumstances?
- Might the students be expected to change roles during the course of the drama?
- How experienced are the students in taking a role, and might they need to practice first?

– teacher-in-role

- How comfortable and experienced are you in using TIR?
- Have you planned to change roles in the drama?
- If not, how prepared are you to do so if the circumstances of the drama require it?
- What relationship will there be between the TIR and the roles of the students: e.g. authority role, colleague, devil's advocate, messenger?
- What will be the resulting status of your role in relation to those of the students?
- Will your role be able to model behaviour, attitude and language for the students to help them develop their roles?

Review **Chapter 5** for more help in deciding on the roles of the students and teacher-in-role.

My chosen role for the students is:

My chosen TIR is:

Frame

Why?

Key question 4

Which viewpoint will the roles have in order to create tension in the drama and how distanced do the roles need to be?

When deciding on the frame for the drama, remember that:

- frame creates dramatic tension to provide an imperative for action;
- the communication function of frame creates collective concern and the imperative for talk; and
- the distancing function protects into experience.

Check the following points:

- What point of view will the roles have (both TIR and students) about the event or situation being developed in the drama?
- What, exactly, is it that will give tension to the situation and help develop points of view?
- What kind of collective concern might the role be expected to develop in the dramatic context of drama?
- To what extent will the roles be empowered to do something about their situation in the drama?
- How distanced by time and/or relationship are the roles from the main area of exploration?
- What opportunities will exist for the students to deepen their investment in the unfolding situation of the drama?
- Do you envisage opportunities for re-framing the roles by shifting their point of view?
- Have you ensured sufficient protection for the students in relation to the subject matter and the experience of the drama?

Review [Chapter 6](#) for more help in deciding on the frame of the drama.

My chosen frame for drama is:

Sign

How?

Key question 5

What artefacts, personal items, sounds and so on, will I need to bring significance to the drama?

When deciding on the signs for the drama, remember that:

there are three aspects to planning sign

- signs that 'hook' the students into drama;
- other prepared signs that bring significance by focusing attention on the theme or learning area; and
- teacher's sign that supports the teacher-in-role.

Check the following points:

- What will you use to 'hook' the students into drama – a notice, map, object, sound?
- What other prepared sign might you need to have ready as the drama begins to unfold – a scroll, doctor's bag, a jewel?
- What things do you need as TIR to sign and 'reinforce' your role in the drama – item of costume, prop?
- Will you need to prepare items to sign the students' roles – badges of office?
- Will the students in role make anything to help establish the drama?
- Will you use sign to indicate 'absent others' – symbolically, iconically, expressively?
- Is the signing going to be culturally appropriate for the students and clear?

Review [Chapter 7](#) for more help in deciding on the sign for the drama.

Sign

How?

Key question 5

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- Will you need to prepare items to sign the students' roles – badges of office?
- Will the students in role make anything to help establish the drama?
- Will you use sign to indicate 'absent others' – symbolically, iconically, expressively?
- Is the signing going to be culturally appropriate for the students and clear?

Review [Chapter 7](#) for more help in deciding on the sign for the drama.

My chosen signs are:

Strategies

How?

Key question 6

Which ways of working will I use, in which combination, for what purpose?

When deciding on the strategies you are going to use in the drama, remember that:

- whole-group improvisation with teacher-in-role is a central strategy but there are many more;
- there are different types of strategy that serve different purposes in developing the drama; and
- it is important to choose the strategy that will create that part of the drama most 'meaningfully'.

Check the following points:

- Do you have sufficient strategies in your repertoire to start? Make a note of the ones with which you are comfortable.
- Do you have sufficient strategies to provide you with alternative ways of proceeding and to introduce new strategies to the students?
- Are there any strategies that you are overusing? Remember, one of your aims is to introduce students to a range of performance forms.
- Will the students have the opportunity to suggest which strategies might be used to move the drama forward?
- Are the strategies being used culturally appropriate to the students involved? Are you drawing on performance forms from the students' tradition?
- Are the strategies appropriate to the learning needs of the students?
- Are you thinking ahead about how the drama might unfold, and planning strategies that might be introduced later?
- Have you chosen strategies that are appropriate to the material being explored? Are they helping to deepen the experience for the students and encouraging reflection on the drama?

Review [Chapter 8](#) for more help in deciding on the strategies for the drama.

My chosen strategies for the drama are:

Finally:

- Have you taken into consideration the particular needs and diversity of your students?
- Have you negotiated a drama learning contract with the class?
- Does everyone understand what the parameters are?
- Have you agreed signals for starting and stopping the drama?
- Are you clear about the subtle questioning you will need to use?
- Do you remember that process drama works well as an episodic form?
- Are you willing to offer the students the opportunity to contribute to the shape and direction of their learning, and ready to weave their ideas into the drama?
- Have you given thought to assessment opportunities inside and outside the drama?
- Do you recognise that you will need to plan on your feet as the drama unfolds?
- Do you remember that drama is powerful and also FUN?

Review [Chapter 9](#) to get more help.

You are ready to shift into ‘now time’ and begin!

Further Reading

We have tried to provide a comprehensive guide to the planning of process drama. However, it is clear that no single publication can hope to cover every aspect of a subject in complete detail. There are other practitioners who have written on the subject of process drama and, of course, broader aspects of drama in an educational setting. What follows is a list of titles that will be useful if you would like to delve into process drama more deeply, or to explore the broader spectrum of drama within educational settings, or if we have whetted your appetite to find out more about the brain.

Books and Journal Articles

- Ackroyd, J. (2004) *Role Reconsidered: A Re-evaluation of the Relationship between Teacher-in-Role and Acting*. Stoke on Trent, UK: Trentham Books.
- Anderson, M. (2012) *Masterclass in Drama Education: Transforming Teaching and Learning*. London: Continuum.
- Baldwin, P. (2009) *School Improvement through Drama: A Creative Whole Class, Whole School Approach*. London: Continuum.
- Baldwin, P. (2012) *With Drama in Mind: Real Learning in Imagined Worlds*. London: Continuum.
- Blair, R. (2009) Cognitive neuroscience and acting: imagination, conceptual blending, empathy. *TDR: The Drama Review* 53(4) (T204): 93–103 (New York: MIT Press).
- Bolton, G. (1984) *Drama as Education*. Harlow: Longman.
- Bolton, G. (1992) *New Perspectives on Classroom Drama*. London: Simon and Schuster.
- Bolton, G. (1998) *Acting in Classroom Drama: A Critical Analysis*. Stoke on Trent: Trentham Books.
- Bolton, G., Heathcote, D. (1999) *So You Want to Use Role-Play: A New Approach in How to Plan*. Stoke on Trent: Trentham Books.
- Booth, D. (1994) *Story Drama*. Markham, Ontario: Pembroke Publishers.
- Bowell, P. and Heap, B.S. (2006) *Drama on the run: a prelude to mapping the*

- practice of process drama. *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 39(4): 58–69.
- Bowell, P. and Heap, B.S. (2007) Processing post-colonialism: a case study of process drama and cultural diversity. *Caribbean Quarterly* 53(1&2): 84–94.
- Cahill, H. (2010) Re-thinking the fiction-reality boundary: investigating the use of drama in HIV prevention projects in Vietnam. *Research in Drama Education: The Journal of Applied Theatre and Performance* 15(2): 155–174.
- Carol, J. et al. (2006) *Real Players? Drama, Technology and Education*. Stoke on Trent: Trentham Books.
- Dunbar, R. (2005) *The Human Story: A New History of Mankind's Evolution*. London: Faber and Faber.
- Fleming, M. (1994) *Starting Drama Teaching*. London: David Fulton Publishers.
- Fleming, M. (2001) *Teaching Drama in Primary and Secondary Schools – An Integrated Approach*. London: David Fulton Publishers.
- Gallagher, K. (2000) *Drama Education in the Lives of Girls: Imagining Possibilities*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
- Gallagher, K. (2007) *The Theatre of Urban: Youth and Schooling in Dangerous Times*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
- Gallagher, K. and Booth, D. (eds) (2003) *How Theatre Educates: Convergences and Counterpoints with Artists, Scholars and Advocates*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
- Grady, S. (2000) *Drama and Diversity: A Pluralistic Perspective for Educational Drama*. Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann.
- Heap, B.S. and Simpson, A. (2004) When you have AIDS, people laugh at you: a process drama approach to stigma with pupils in Zambia. *Caribbean Quarterly* 50(1) (Mona, Jamaica: University of the West Indies).
- Heap, B.S. and Simpson, A. (2005) A lesson for the living: promoting HIV/AIDS competence among young Zambians. *Youth Theatre Journal* 19: 89–101 (The American Alliance for Theatre and Education).
- Heathcote, D. and Bolton, G. (1995) *Drama for Learning: Dorothy Heathcote's Mantle of the Expert Approach to Education*. Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann.
- Jasinski Schneider, J., Crumpler, T.P. and Rogers, T. (eds) (2006) *Process Drama and Multiple Literacies: Addressing Social, Cultural and Ethical Issues*. Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann.
- Johnson, L. and O'Neill, C. (eds) (1984) *Dorothy Heathcote: Collected Writings on Drama and Education*. London: Hutchinson.
- Kempe, A. (ed.) (1996) *Drama Education and Special Needs*. Cheltenham: Stanley Thornes.
- Kempe, A. and Ashwell, M. (2000) *Progression in Secondary Drama*. Harlow: Heinemann.

- Kempe, A. and Nicholson, H. (2007) *Learning to Teach Drama*. London: Continuum.
- Lewis, M. and Rainer, J. (2005) *Teaching Classroom Drama and Theatre: Practical Projects for Secondary Schools*. Abingdon: Routledge.
- Morgan, N. and Saxton, J. (1984) *Teaching Drama: A Mind of Many Wonders*. London: Hutchinson.
- Neelands, J. (1992) *Learning through Imagined Experience*. Sevenoaks: Hodder and Stoughton.
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- Nicholson, H. (2005) *Applied Drama: The Gift of Theatre*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- O'Connor, P. (ed.) (2010). *Creating Democratic Citizenship through Drama Education: The Writings of Jonothan Neelands*. Stoke on Trent: Trentham Books.
- O'Neill, C. (1995) *Drama Worlds: A Framework for Process Drama*. Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann.
- O'Neill, C. and Lambert, A. (1982) *Drama Structures*. Harlow: Heinemann.
- O'Toole, J. (1992) *The Process of Drama. Negotiating Art and Meaning*. London: Routledge.
- O'Toole, J. and Dunn, J. (2002) *Pretending to Learn: Helping Children Learn through Drama*. Frenchs Forest, NSW: Longman.
- Prendiville, F. and Toye, N. (2007) *Speaking and Listening through Drama 7–11*. London: Sage Publications.
- Rainer, J. and Lewis, M. (2012) *Drama at the Heart of the Secondary School: Projects to Promote Authentic Learning*. Abingdon: David Fulton Publishers.
- Simpson, A. and Heap, B.S. (2002) *Process Drama: A Way of Changing Attitudes*. Sweden: Save the Children.
- Taylor, P. and Warner, C.D. (eds) (2006) *Structure and Spontaneity: The Process Drama of Cecily O'Neill*. Stoke on Trent: Trentham Books.
- Wagner, B.J. (1979) *Dorothy Heathcote: Drama as a Learning Medium*. London: Hutchinson.
- Warren, K. (1999) *Hooked on Drama: The Theory and Practice of Drama in the Early Years*. Katoomba, NSW: Social Science Press.
- Winston, J. (1998) *Drama, Narrative and Moral Education*. London: David Fulton Publishers.
- Winston, J. (2005) *Drama and English at the Heart of the Primary Curriculum*. London: David Fulton Publishers.
- Winston, J. and Tandy, M. (1998) *Beginning Drama 4–11*. London: David Fulton Publishers.

Woolland, B. (1993) *The Teaching of Drama in the Primary School*. Harlow: Longman.

Journals

Applied Theatre Research: *Intellect*. Visit: www.intellectbooks.co.uk/journals/view-Journal, id=218/

Drama – The Magazine of Professional Practice. *National Drama Publications*. Visit: www.dramamagazine.co.uk

Drama Australia and The Australian Drama Education Magazine. *Drama Australia*.

Drama Research: International Journal of Drama in Education. *National Drama Publications*. Visit: www.dramaresearch.co.uk

Research in Drama Education. *Carfax*.

NZADIE Journal. *New Zealand Association for Drama in Education*.

Websites

The following websites will be of interest:

American Alliance for Theatre and Education: www.aate.com/

Council of Ontario Drama and Dance Educators: <http://code.on.ca/>

Drama Australia: www.dramaaustralia.org.au/

Drama for Learning and Creativity: www.d4lc.org.uk

International Drama/Theatre in Education Association: www.idea-org.net/

National Drama – the UK's leading drama subject association: www.nationaldrama.org.uk

New Zealand Association for Drama in Education: www.nzadie.org.nz/